A Door to Our Hearts

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31252628.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Angella (She-Ra)

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by 4theHonourofGräyskülll (AVAwolfpack), But_Its_For_Science (DakianDelomast), DakianDelomast

Summary

We saved the universe, so why does it feel like sometimes I never saved anything? Space was supposed to be peaceful, we were supposed to be together, so why do I feel like we're only growing apart? We went through so much before, fought so hard to be here with each other. I just want things to be okay. I want things to stay fixed. So why does it seem like everything breaks?

Adora has woken up in Castle Grayskull, but nothing makes sense. She doesn't know how she got there, or even when. Something has gone horribly wrong and she can't even trust *when* things are happening. Catra is concealing something from her and the BFS has been injured in some mysterious event that Adora can't recall. Does the answer lie in her past, present, or future?

Notes

Hello everyone! Welcome to the 3rd novella in our series! This one is dedicated to Adora and the complications of her life that linger long after the Heart and what it is like reconciling with the pain she experienced being the hero of the goddamn universe. On the first year anniversary of Season 5, this is a special entry dedicated to the amazing wonderful world that we've been gifted with our exploration of one of our favorite characters in fiction. (I KNOW WE SAY THAT A LOT BUT THEY'RE ALL SO GOOD DON'T JUDGE.) Adora deserves some attention on the things that hurt her so much when she left the Horde and fought so, so many battles alone. We're very proud of this piece, and we hope you enjoy it!!

Also we've dropped links in to the songs intermittently in the story that either inspired or we felt best fit the scenes as we wrote them. Follow along if you like! Just decided to add them for a little extra flavor to an amazing story.

If you want the whole playlist it's available here!



Super special thanks to the amazing BA TU for setting us up with some fanart! Their work is AMAZING. Check out their art on their Instagram and Twitter!

See the end of the work for more notes

Cadets

Our feet skittered in the hall. Large pipes hissed and groaned with steam. The world tasted of oil and smelled of mold. It was our home. I followed you, sprinting through the halls. We'd learned—actually, no, you taught me how to run quietly. Even in my combat boots. No one could hear us. No one could catch us.

You skidded to a stop at the next corner and I almost bumped into you.

"What is it?" I whispered.

You cringed at my volume. "Shhh! Shadow Weaver."

"What's she doing up this late?"

"I don't know. I don't want her to catch us." You grasped your arm, holding it tightly against you.

"She won't. C'mon." I gestured you away from the corner, opposite the direction she traveled. I wasn't going to let her interrupt tonight.

A small smile graced your lips. That small tooth, the left one, it jutted out a little more than the other. That's when I knew you were happy. "I have an idea."

"What's that?" I crossed my arms forgetting the threat that lurked just around the corner.

"Follow me, I want to show you something." You bolted past me.

I waited, lingered in your wake. One of the strangest comforts was how you smelled. It was the way your fur captured the different odors of the Fright Zone and mixed it with yours. Oil, metal, sweat, and some other sources intangible. I knew the other cadets picked on you about it, but it was one of my favorite

things about you. I collected myself back into the now, and I was about to lose line of sight of you around the next corner. I sprinted off to catch up. The night was just beginning.

Just down the hall lurked the next junction. You stopped next to a large grating that concealed one of the ventilation pipes. It was never clear to me if it was venting bad air out, or worse air in. You tapped your foot impatiently as I caught up. "I was about to *die* of boredom waiting for you."

"Aren't *you* the one that's usually late?"

"Only if someone else told me where to go." You wink the golden eye at me.

"Whatever." I couldn't hide the grin though. "Where to, fearless pathfinder?"

You stopped and pointed to a grate. "Here."

"What's here?" I scratch the back of my neck under my ponytail.

"I know where they're not going to find us."

I put a hand on my hip and raised a skeptical eyebrow. "You've found the one spot in all the Fright Zone that doesn't have patrol bots or wandering cadets?"

"Yes." The confidence in your smile quelled all questions I had.

I shrugged and yanked the grate off with a groaning protest. Your head turned frantically as you intermittently watched my struggle and checked either end of the hallway. The noise… too much noise.

"Quietly." You hissed at me.

I grunted and shoved the large metal mesh left and right working it free of rust and grime. "I'm trying here, Catra."

"Try harder, dummy!" You unhelpfully lingered over my shoulder.

I was about to snap out 'stop whining and just help me' but I stifled my response when we heard footfalls. The covering on the ventilation pipe thankfully let go just then with a soft ringing of steel that my hands muted. You didn't hesitate and jumped into the darkness of the ducting. I pivoted around the heavy metal mesh plate and swung myself into the pipe to follow. There was another groan and I pulled as best I could to seal it behind us. Hopefully it held. I wondered briefly how you'd found this place before now without sullying those dainty claws of yours.

Darkness quickly enveloped us. We crawled. Hands and knees scraping against the oil, dinge, and grime. I soon lost sight of you, even though I heard you shuffling ahead of me. I reached for my belt and took out my small hand-torch. I shined it ahead illuminating your backside and the cramped tunnel we were in.

You hissed, tail whipping me across the face. "Turn that off!"

"Well I can't *see* ." I whispered back and thumbed the torch off. Acrid dust rose in the wake of your crawling and I stifled a sneeze.

You sighed and spared a glance back at me. Your blue and yellow eyes stared back at me. The pupils wide enough to swallow the whole dark. They glowed softly in the dim light. "Adora, there's only one way through this vent. And I'm in front of you."

"Oh. Right." I clipped the torch back into my belt. It was still really dark. "Where are we going?"

"Relax." Your tail swept backward more gently this time and caressed my cheek. A flickering thrill blossomed in my chest. I wanted to bat it away, but… it felt comforting in that dark. There with you. "We're almost there."

Sure enough, the light started to creep into the tunnel. It wasn't sunlight—no, it was the sickly yellow, muted by the haze of the Fright Zone. Still, it was enough. You shimmied forward and

popped the grate ahead of you. This one fell with a loud clatter, but we were outside. Noises of falling metal were the norm. Sometimes the debris was even good reflex practice.

You interlocked your fingers and stretched your arms high above your head. I watched your back flex under your leotard. Blinked, and turned back to the sprawl. The sight compelled me forward to lean on the narrow protective rail.

Nestled into the crag, the walls that held us, the Fright Zone spread and towered in the rift of volcanic rock. Enormous monuments of machinery climbed from their foundation of metal. Hard angles, irregular shapes, and noxious fumes rolling from pipes and vents. It always took my breath away.

"It's quite a view, isn't it?" I breathed deep the sulfur tingling at my nose.

You walked up next to me. "Yeah, I guess." You grazed a claw against the railing and a tinny scrape filled the emptiness.

I looked over at you and a forlorn distraction captured your attention. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing, just… if you like the view, you're going to love this." Your eyes sparkled with mischief.

I grinned at you. "I like the sound of that."

You smacked the railing twice in excitement and waved me away from the precipice below. You sprinted off, tail swaying behind you. "Try to keep up!" Suddenly, you leapt into the air, onto a narrow ledge, more of a shelf really that jutted awkwardly from the side of one of the tall pylons of the Fright Zone. Another leap took you to the next ledge.

Okay, this just wasn't fair.

I ran forward, my feet thudding on the rough-hewn metal. With a small leap, I planted my feet and sprung upwards at the wall.

My momentum carried me just high enough to grasp my fingers on the shelf. No way I was standing on that tiny thing. But there was always another option. I dug my toe into a small piece of metal, and reached up with my arm for the next handhold nestled in the face of the wall.

I might not be able to jump like you, but I could find my way up a shear wall. My hands and toes alternated anchors. Fingers barely having more than just their tips dug into the smallest of ridges. Toes held on with more friction than support. But this was nothing. The last shelf was thankfully larger, and with a heave of my shoulders I pulled myself up into a precarious squat. I didn't dare look down.

"Wow, I'm impressed. You're still the slowest person in the world but you made it." You sneered playfully. "Past the easy part, I mean."

" *That* was supposed to be easy?" I caught my breath and realized what you meant. The pylon ended where I stood. It was just empty air. You were squatting on a plate suspended in mid-air with only a branch of metal holding it up. Your tail flicked behind you smugly.

"Wanna give up?"

" *No* ." I snapped back and glared.

"Suit yourself!" You turned, and with the steps of agility only you could muster, leapt to the next platform, ascending upward into the opaque sky headed towards another pylon.

I grit my teeth, and braced myself. There was barely enough room to turn on the narrow ledge I was on, and if I did, I might not have the power under my legs to get me over the chasm. Another thud of your hands and feet told me you were quickly scaling the platforms ahead of me. A frustration lapsed through me, but… I wasn't angry. No, I felt stronger. My legs, and maybe a little spite, could carry me there. I knew they would.

Despite the awkward angle, I crouched, and leapt with all my strength. The toes of my boot gripped the plate and gave me enough confidence that I wasn't about to just plummet to my death. My foot cleared over the edge of the platform and I was in an arc towards the next narrow platform. It was exactly what I wanted to do, but as I careened towards the narrow shelf I briefly wondered if it was the best idea. I caught the plate in the middle of my torso and shunted a loud cough of air. My hands started slipping as gravity tried to pull the rest of my body down. With a quick clamor, I found my purchase and climbed up on my elbows, only feeling safe when I finally got a knee up. The next plate didn't look much easier. But I was committed now.

Okay, I can do this. I leapt to the next platform.

One.

Two.

Three.

Six.

Eight.

I stopped and rested my hands on my knees, buckled forward trying to catch my breath. My chest hurt from the inelegant landings and my fingertips burned from scrabbling at the smooth decking. But I wasn't about to let you win. Now where were you?

"Hey, Adora!"

I looked upward and there you were, waving an arm at me from over the ledge. Dammit, Catra. The pylon I was facing had a large protrusion on top of it. It pointed out over the oblivion that was the rest of the Fright Zone.

"How do I get up there?" I called out. Stealth had long ago been lost anyway.

"I dunno. Figure it out!" You unhelpfully waved and disappeared from the edge of the overhang.

I grumbled and reached down, patting at my belt. I knew how to get up there. I unclipped and unfurled my grappling hook. The long, thin filament trailed from the back, plenty long to reach up there. I pressed a button on the cylindrical grappler and four hooks popped out. I eyed my target and started a spin with the wire. After gathering enough speed, I let it fly. The wire in my opposite hand loosely held on letting the length wind out. I smirked as the hooks grabbed onto something high above.

I tugged. It felt like it would hold. I clamped my hand on the thin wire and pulled up. Then I cinched my feet around the length under me. I shimmed up, hands, feet, hands feet. The wire bit into my palms, but I was too far, and it wasn't like I had an option to go back now. Finally I reached the ledge, and saw the hook gripping a railing. Perfect.

I tugged myself upward and crested the platform, only to see you sitting on the railing on the far side, your back to me. A moon of Etheria silhouetted your body to me. A flutter surged in my chest, the same as before. I knew somehow, I'd always remember this sight. I broke my stupor and climbed up.

"'Bout time you got here." A breezy relaxation wafted through your words. The anxiety of the halls of the Fright Zone was long gone.

It was the real you, the one I so rarely saw. I reminded myself that the sass couldn't go unanswered. "It's a little harder when you're not, you know, Catra." I attempted to sound grumpy. I knew it failed.

"Whatever." You kept looking on, never facing me. "Come here."

I obliged and walked up next to you. I placed my hands on the railing and it… it looked the same as before. "This was a lot of effort for the same view."

Out of the corner of my eye, I saw the distinct eye-roll of disbelief you kept just for me. “That’s the point.”

I blinked. “Help me out here.”

You sighed and gestured out to the skyline. “It was hard getting up here. So… no one is going to find us.”

“Oh. Ohhh.” I braced my elbows on the railing, glancing sidelong at you. “That’s pretty clever.”

“Of course it is.” That unmistakable smile from before had only broadened up here.

It was very distracting. “So… why did we want to come up here?”

“I don’t know… talk?” Your voice shifted. A little corner of the smile faded and the glow of the Fright Zone all around us seemed to diminish with it.

I tried to keep my thoughts from scrambling to get that little bit of happiness back. “About what?”

The silence between us opened. A pressure radiated from you. Something…

What did you want to talk about? What hadn’t we before? We’d said everything. We kept saying everything. I grasped for something to fill the blooming silence. “I think Kyle and Rogelio have been getting along pretty well.”

You coughed out a small laugh. “That’s what you want to talk about?”

“Well…” A hot flash washed down my neck in embarrassment. “What should I say?”

“How about, ‘Wow, I can’t wait to get out of this dump.’” You curled up resting your feet on the rail. Frustration bubbled into

your pose as you crossed your arms over your knees.

I hadn't thought about that. Why get out? Why break away? We had everything, and we were safe. No princesses, regular food, friends, people that cared about us.

"You think this place is a dump?"

"Of course it is! It's always the same. It's so *boring.* " An open wave of your hand emphasized your point.

"I don't know, it's kind of nice." I leaned back, hands grasped around the rail. I tapped my thumbs before pulling back in. I stared wistfully off toward the other side of the chasm. "Having a routine, and we are going to be senior cadets soon. What's wrong with that?"

"What's wrong? It's just the same thing, Adora! I am sick of it. I want to just *go* ."

"Oh c'mon, the way you were talking last night, we were going to be calling the shots with Hordak bringing us ration bars on a platter."

"Well that was… That was different."

"Why?"

"I just want things to change." You unfurled a leg and let it drape into the oblivion below, an elbow resting on the other knee. "Some days? We take over the Horde and we're okay. Other days, I want to be anywhere but here. Anywhere where… Shadow Weaver isn't. Maybe for just a bit."

Oh.

I trail a finger over the cold metal rail. "Well, she's been nicer lately. Hasn't she?"

"To you." Your bitterness bit at the stale air.

"I mean she only yelled at you once this week! That's gotta be better."

You pushed back, jumping away from the ledge, back onto the platform behind us. I turned, tempted to reach out, to grab your hand. Anything to keep you from walking away from me.

"It's not good enough."

"Catra…" I struggled for the words.

"Adora, I want to leave. Some day… I don't know when. But I just feel like there's something better out there. And… I don't want to go… without you." You faced me. Tears glistened in those eyes.

I remember those tears.

"Okay."

I still don't know why I said it. One night we were taking over, the next we were leaving. But, I didn't ask questions. I didn't fight it. I just knew wherever you went I had to be there with you. Some day.

Biting sterile detergents intermingle with the volatile burn of degreasers in my nose. I hold the back of my wrist against it and step away again from the single clean floorplate in the airlock. You're across the room from me, nestled into a corner. Your tail flicks excitedly as you watch an interloping insect flit up the wall, a stowaway from our last adventure planetside.

"Are you going to help?" I drop the scrub brush into the bucket next to me with a loud *plop* .

"Little busy!" The bug ventures down from it's high perch. You make a leap for it, but it evades your grasp.

"Catra…"

You turn from the corner of the room to face me. The annoyance in your expression incenses me a little. “What?”

“When we drew straws for cleanup duty you said, ‘oh boy, that’s going to be easy.’”

“For you, sure.” You grin.

“Look, if I have to do this myself it’s going to take all day.” I point at the single floorplate that I had managed to scrub clean.

“How do you know it’s day? We’re in space, dummy.” You turn your attention back to the bug, tail twitching predatorily.

“You know what I mean.” I hear the tapping of my foot on the floor before I realize I am doing it.

“I guess.” The bug drifts to the top of the ceiling out of reach. You sigh and wander my way, hand on hip. “But who’s going to notice a half-assed airlock cleaning? We’re just going to track more crud in the next time we land.”

“They’re going to notice and they’re going to know *we* slacked off.” I grab a brush from the bucket and thrust it in your direction. The suds and accompanying fluid scatter across the floor.

You wrinkle your nose and grasp the handle of the brush as though it were irradiated. “You can just blame it on me, if it really bothers you.”

“That’s not the point, Catra. The point is that it has to get done.” I walk back over to the bucket to grab a rag. “You know how dangerous a grease spot can be.”

“Do you have to bring *that* up?”

“It seems relevant.”

“Hey, that was Kyle’s fault. Not me.”

"Yeah, but we all paid for it. Didn't we?" I feel myself shaking in anger.

You roll your eyes, your sneer revealing a single fang. "That's debatable."

"What?"

"Look, Adora, not all of us had such an easy time in the Fright Zone."

"Easy?" My hand clenches on the rag and water splatters on the floorplates. "I trained every day because I knew what would happen if I didn't."

"And what happened if you fell behind? Didn't get that top score? Oh, no, you got yelled at." You scowl and shake your head. "Give me a break."

"You think I wanted to work my ass off every day? You think I never wanted a break? To slack off like you? I *had* to be perfect. Or Shadow Weaver would've… Would've…" The words die in my throat.

"What, Adora?" You dichromatic eyes are steady on me. "Hurt me? Guess what, she did that anyway."

"I tried to help." I take a step back from you.

"A lot of good that did. Maybe if you cried a little harder I might've been spared a couple zaps." You point the brush at me.

"She was just as hard on me."

You cackle, a painful one of dry crumpled paper. I thought that sound was long gone. "I don't care how hard you were pushed, or whatever pressure felt so *overwhelming* . Even in the end, you were all she wanted back."

"Because she wanted to *use* me, Catra." I push the brush down, trying to reclaim the space it opened between us. "She was a monster."

"You just don't get it, do you? You could leave. You did. You always had that choice." You shake your head in disgust. "Not the rest of us. I had to get you back. It was the one thing she wanted me to do after Thaymor. I did it. I was afraid what might happen if you never came back. But somewhere I hoped…" You wipe a tear away and smile a desperate smile. "Everything could be better. Right? If I got you back, she'd love me like she did you. Things would be different then. But it didn't work out that way. You left, you fought us. You betrayed the Horde and everything Shadow Weaver taught us. But even after all of that. After everything she did to me. She still went to find *you* ." Pain twists your face. "Don't you *tell* me how hard it was living with Shadow Weaver."

"Catra…" A crushing weight lands on my heart.

"Just, shut up." You throw the brush aside and it clatters in the empty airlock, covering the soft padding of your feet as you run through the corridors of Darla.

I step in, my left arm cocks out slightly, and I pivot on the same foot. My fist slams home on an imaginary kidney, digging in deep and savage. I step back and spin with a roundhouse across the head. The heavy bag resounds with a satisfying *smack* .

You could have come with me.

I pivot back and strike with a left-right straight punch combo, shoving my front kick in, knocking the bag backwards. When it swings forward I step to the side, and strike with my elbow.

That's not the way any of this happened. Nothing worked out like it should. Nothing made sense. Not for a long time.

I want to go home.

I step away from the bag again. I spin, lashing my leg out and digging my heel into sand-filled fabric. The impact sings up my leg, dislodging some of the tension.

I stop. Take in deep breaths. Heat radiates from my body carried through my thermal top.

Why isn't this going right? Why don't things feel better?

"Darla, fire up the combat bots." I draw my collapsible staff from my belt. It opens with a sinister *shink* .

"Adora, you are operating at an elevated state. I recommend against—"

"Just do it."

I dash to the center of the mess hall. The table and supplies surround me like a disinterested audience. A combat drone emerges from a duct in the ceiling. A sharp tip of the pyramidal bot's apex points down at the floorboards. A large glowing eye is set in the middle.

Just like Shadow Weaver's gem.

I spin the staff around and a hologram projects under the floating drone. It replicates a battle android of Horde Prime's. It only fuels my anger. The projected force field of the holograms deflects my staff back with a block. It turns and aims a backhand at my head.

I duck and spin around, striking the holo where a liver would be. It is unphased as it brings another fist down like a hammer onto my head. I duck and roll away.

Wait! It was my fault. I was being reckless and—and… It's all my fault. I can see the black shadows curling around you.

The hologram charges, and extends a foot out in my direction. I pivot again and drive my staff between its legs. With a flick of my

wrist I drive the point of the staff into the ankle and lever the staff upwards as a trip. The drone simulates a fall and lands over on its side.

Please don't hurt her. My voice pleads for mercy.

I twirl the staff and drive the point down into the drone. The hologram can't stop my blow and the end of the staff splits the steel plates. It drives deeper and hits something vital. A shower of sparks erupts from the hole and some deep regret shimmers under my surface. But anger quickly buries the thought again.

I hear another drone trigger behind me. I didn't know Entrapta had built two. I let it get close to me and I spin around. I twirl my staff and bring it down diagonally across the next opponent.

Only for it to be stopped by Angella's forearm.

I startle backwards and almost trip on my heels. "Ah! Your Majesty. I'm sorry I—"

Angella's serene smile cuts me off, the familiar sight knocking me off my footing. "No need to fret, Adora," she says, and the voice too is another blow that makes me feel like I'm staggering, struggling to catch up.

"Still, I could've…"

"No, you couldn't have."

The realization catches me by surprise. "You're doing better!"

"No small thanks to everyone on this ship." She steps further into the barren makeshift arena that I had created. "The things the five of you can accomplish are stunning."

"We do our best."

"Your best has changed the galaxy, Adora." Her eyes scan over the mess I've made, eyebrow raising at the sparks shooting from

the split floorboards. “What has you causing such a ruckus in the dining room? Everyone’s starving.”

I startle, the butt of my staff bumping loudly on the metal plates as I nearly drop it. “They’ve been…?”

“Yes, but I promised them I would handle it.”

“Oh, I dunno. I was just… training.” I pace, transferring the staff between my hands. My eyes dart from the open door behind her to the mess hall table to the divot I made in the floor. I hastily cover it with my boot. “I don’t know what else to do with myself, I guess.”

Angella touches her fingers and thumbs together in her regal neutral pose. I feel her observing me but I can’t quite bring myself to meet her gaze. The old nervousness I felt in her presence returned tenfold and my only instinct is to salute her and wait for orders.

“I think you can take a break from the training for one night, Adora,” Angella says. “You deserve a rest after everything you’ve done.”

My eyes meet hers for the first time since she’s entered. I can’t help it. The softness of her voice compels me to look. But as soon as I do, it’s like the metal plates of Darla are breaking apart beneath my feet, drifting away like icebergs in the oceans, before they are swept into the blinding light of the…

The Portal.

“Your Majesty, I—” Words fail me. There is so much I want to say and tell her. So much I couldn’t say before when it was just us standing on the last island of reality. Before she flew away, leaving me with her last wish.

Angella merely opens her arms.

I drop the staff with a clatter and fall into her embrace. The sobs that rip up through my chest have been building there for a long time. Sobs I kept hidden and stifled while Glimmer needed me. While the world needed me. I can't hold them back now. Not even She-Ra would be strong enough to keep them back.

Take care of each other.

I hear those words over and over again. They've been at the back of my mind ever since. The pinprick of light at the epicenter of reality. The purpose given to me when I had lost sight of everything.

"Shh, Adora. It's okay." Angella soothes my torrent of fear and sadness. Her hand smooths my hair back, the strands that fell loose while sparring. "Everything is as it should be."

"I tried," I say, my voice muffled against her chest. "I… I did everything I could to keep my promise to you."

"You did more than enough."

I feel myself rising again, carried away from an oblivion of guilt that was rushing at me. She pulls me away with nothing more than her touch. Away from the Portal, the coldness of space, the derelict halls of the Fright Zone. The touch of something I had never known. That of a mother.

I pull my face from her tear-stained dress. "Sorry."

She smiles at me, resting her hands on my shoulders. "Better now?"

I take stock. A deep breath in. "Yes, actually."

"Good. Now, what has you so upset?"

I startle straight. "Oh, I've just been. Just been…"

"Frustrated?"

That seems like a good word for it. I nod.

"About what, dear?" Her words open a space of calm and acceptance between us.

I feel your name escaping my lips before I can pin it down. "Catra."

"I see." She scans downward, a slight uneasiness flows into her tone. "What about her?"

I fight myself. I shouldn't have said your name. What can I do now? "She's… hurt."

Angella takes a step back from me. She stands straight-backed and firm, but somehow still pliable and attentive. "Why does that upset you like this?" She gestures to the wider room, along with the bot that sits sparking a few paces away from us.

My self-consciousness catches up with me, but I bury it back down. "Because I don't want her to. I want to help. I just don't know how and none of this is going like I thought it would." I push a boot towards the damaged bot as though I could hide it behind me.

"Why is that a surprise?" These words from anyone else would feel violating. But instead Angella tugs on a string, coaxing more honesty out of me with her calm, understanding expression.

"I thought… maybe she'd be better out here, together. We could be quiet, and talk about the things that we haven't been able to. And we kind of have. It just hasn't been what I thought. She's hurt, but not in a way that I thought she would be. And she doesn't really…" I reach up and rub the back of my neck with my hand. The cool air of the ship is winning over my exertion and I feel a chill sneaking in. "I'm not feeling a connection like I hoped."

Her eyes relax, relinquishing an invisible tension she had been holding. "Do you feel guilty?"

The word strikes a blow inside of me. I pause my next breath. "Y—yeah."

"About what, dear?" She glides through the admission, my failure.

I find my staff again, and tap it lightly on Darla's floorplates. "She… Catra and Entrapta… Entrapta helped her open up a bit more to me. And…" I stop mid sentence at the astonishment in Angella's eyes. "That's a long story. But the more Catra says, the less I understand." I watch as I press the tip of the staff firmly onto the plate and twist it in my grip, avoiding looking at her directly. "She doesn't remember things the same way that I do, but the more I try to reach out to her, the more distant she feels."

"Adora, you're not alone here." I almost hear a laugh.

I pull my eyes from the floor back to her face. Her gentle bemusement disarms my rising guilt. "What?"

"I think we're all dealing with that. I am, too. Micah, he's different now. It's odd isn't it? He was gone for so long, all of Glimmer's childhood. I never *imagined* I would see him again. But here he is. Here we are. My family is united again. But it's not what I thought it would be." She smiles, exhuming a forgotten warmth. "And that's just fine."

"It doesn't feel fine." I feel a resentment rise and fall in me. I tap the staff against the floorplate again. "I guess, I just wanted things to be normal again, and I don't know how to make it all right."

"Adora, you can't save the universe from itself." Her gaze pierces me. As though she caught me in a lie. "I know you. Even after all this time. You are going to have to learn to lay down your weapons. The time for fighting for those we love is over. Now we need to care for them."

My hands clench so tight my knuckles turn white around the staff. I relax and blood pumps back into my fingers. “But how can I help them?”

She approaches me again. The gentle perfume of stardust and spring rain overwhelms me. “You have to learn calm, and peace.” She reaches forward and delicately places a hand on my shoulder. “If you keep fixing our family’s problems you won’t let them grow. Catra, most of all, needs understanding and space. She has to learn how to be a person in a very strange world. I’m not surprised she is scared.”

I shift my weight left and right. Even Angella’s presence can’t purge all of the shadow. “She still talks about Shadow Weaver, but I don’t know what to say about it. We both remember her so differently.”

“Well, that woman was a monster for what she did to you two. And I must confess, I felt the same with you.”

I look at her in confusion. “What?”

“Oh yes.” She smiles warmly. “You think you were so different when you came to Bright Moon?”

“I hadn’t thought of that…”

“Of course not. You were in the same place Catra is now. You were beside yourself. The world was strange to you. I saw in you… it hurt to see you that way. Afraid of space, of care, food, love. It took you quite a while to adjust, and we had to make accommodations for you. But in the end you healed. At least as much as you could then.”

I feel a tear creeping up. My breath stutters. “I do remember.”

“Precisely. And now Catra needs the same from you. And punching things isn’t going to fix this.”

I nod. “What can I do, then?”

“Perhaps I can show you, but I think first everyone is rather hungry.”

I feel my stomach gurgle. “Oh, right.”

Grayskull

Chapter Notes

We're just going to shamelessly plug this, if you want more Catradora Cadets go check out our anniversary tribute to the glory of She-Ra: Whispering About Whatever

A sharp crack of thunder rends through my blissful slumber, dragging me awake with the subtlety of a stun-stick. I suck in a sharp breath and I taste vinegar on my tongue. I don't know where I am. The room isn't like anything I've seen. It doesn't have the angular lines of the First Ones, the domed smoothness of Bright Moon, or the brutal industrial architecture of the Fright Zone. There's nothing to ground me. Just gray stone in a simple rectangular room. A creeping unease crawls through my thoughts. Had I been captured? Or did I fall in a hole somewhere? Where was Darla?

A shattering fear rattles my composure. Where's Catra?

A flash of lightning followed by a deafening boom interrupts my runaway panic. I take a deep breath. Disoriented or not, freaking out isn't going to help anything. I blink and scan the room for threats and critical information. Hints of gold and decaying crimson hide in the darkness.

Where *am* I?

"Catra?" I instantly wish that sounded more composed than it did. I might as well have been that kid stuck in the dark in the Fright Zone.

A weak voice calls from the other corner of the room. "Hey, Adora."

I stand shakily to my feet. As I push up, the moldy carpet slips against my fingers. I don't even notice. It's raining outside; somewhere far down the hall there are open windows, or

balconies, something. I reach down into my belt and my hand disappears in a small portal. I find the small cylinder and withdraw the hand-torch. I flick the beam on and cast it into the room, looking for you.

Tables lay in disarray around me. Long ago knocked to the russet red carpet and stained with black and green mold creeping through the decor. The wood on the tables looks impeccable even in the wet rot of the world around us. Among my feet is detritus of tarnished bronze candlesticks and shattered crystalline disks of the First Ones.

I finally spot you with the beam of my torch. The top buttons of your shirt have been torn away and it sits slightly askew on you. Your pants are torn at the knee with a red gash shining through underneath. Mud and grime coat your cheeks and one of your ears cocks to the side. You hold up your hand blocking the beam from your eyes as your pupils retract into slits. Your other grasps at your left side.

"Dammit, turn that off!"

"Catra! You're hurt!" I drop my hand and shine the light behind me.

"Hey, no it's fine." You choke on the last word.

"How is this fine? Where are we?" I rush towards you, knocking a table away. It clatters against the floor, resounding with a thud that suggests hard stone hides beneath the rug. "Are you okay?"

"Adora, I'm fine. It was just…" The indignation of being blinded slips into a quizzical stare. "Wait, you don't remember?"

I look deep into your dichromatic eyes. They stare at me, searching for something. As though I'd lie to you. What would I lie about?

Your expression dredges up more fear and panic in me. It pulls me away from any progress I make towards understanding and

now there's something between us that I don't even know about. "Catra, please. What's going on?"

"It's… There's a storm outside. We came in here to get out of it. It's some kind of acid rain thunderstorm." As though cued by your voice, another flash and crack of a lightning bolt punctuates the night, casting the bright light against your face.

The slimmest explanation helps me ground myself. "How'd you get hurt? Where's everybody? Bow, Glimmer, and Entrapta?" I remove a small medical kit from the back of my belt.

You push my hands back. "Stop!" Stubbornly, you brace against the wall with a visible wince and move to stand. Whatever helpless feeling that was roiling inside of me turns into a fever pitch. I'm lost and you won't even let me help you. It reminds me of… No, I can't give in to those thoughts. I stand to follow you to your feet.

You suck in a breath to bite back whatever agony you held in your ribs. "It's been quite a night. Things haven't really gone like we thought they would." You reach out to steady yourself on the wall you were leaning against. Actually not a wall, per say. It's a former bookshelf that has fallen away. The books scattered and burned in a rotten pile under the shattered shelves. I reach out to touch you, steady you.

You flinch. I see it, feel it. I fight back a rushing tide of fear. In a blessed mercy, your reaction dissipates into the night and I run my fingers along the smooth fabric of your button up shirt to support your shoulder. The warmth radiating from you calms me.

"Catra, what's going on? None of this makes sense."

"I know, dummy. You really need to calm down for a minute." You take a deep breath and push off the shelf. I'm alarmed at first. Were you falling? Was it a concussion? Was it—

You turn, and snatch me into an embrace. Arms cinch tight and your face falls into my jacket. In a reflex, I wrap my arms around

you. I squeeze, delicately, hoping to not aggravate whatever wound you have endured. I feel a shudder from you.

I only notice when it's gone. The fear, the panic had left at some point while I held you. I take a calming breath. My racing heart slows. "Th… Thanks. I didn't know I needed that."

You push back from me and smirk. That smile, that face. Your left fang juts out from your lips slightly more than the right. "All right, I think we're good." You roll your neck side to side to gather yourself. "Do you remember *anything* ?"

I reach deep into my memory for anything before waking up. There was Angella's face, Darla, some kind of map, fleeting conversations, and a name. Then… shouting? Fighting? I shake my head. "No. Nothing clearly. Where is everyone?"

You take a careful, measured breath. A furrowed brow indicates some kind of thought, an unsettling one. "You missed a lot then. We got cut off from Bow and Glimmer. Entrapta had a signal that she was picking up but there was an attack. Some kind of bots or latent tech that was left behind on the planet. We had split up. Glimmer got… She got hurt."

"Is she okay?" A jolt of adrenaline challenges my delicate calm. If she was hurt then we have to go find—No, one thing at a time.

"I think so. Bow and Entrapta had to take her back to Darla. We were distracting the bots to give them some time and that's when the rain came in. Needed to find some shelter for us."

"Why was I out?" I grab at the sides of my aching head. "Why can't I remember this?"

You laugh, it has that delicate scratch to it. "A bot got the jump on you. Knocked you out. Took us a minute but I guess we got to the right place." You cross the room away from me, putting a painful distance between us.

"What place?"

You blink in disbelief at me. “You… Adora… We’re on Eternia. And I think we found Castle Grayskull.”

I backpedal nearly slipping on the wet pages behind me. “How’d we get here?” I look around, trying to find some clue to prove her point. I pick the beam of the hand-torch up and flick it through the large room.

Nothing seems right with it. It’s a simple rectangular room with a primitive architecture unlike any I’ve seen. The walls are lined with former shelves and piles of books. Tables, chairs, smashed desks. I look for a sign. I know what one. There’s a flash of lightning again and the room seems to luminesce now that I know what I am looking for. Signs flicker to life from the torn covers of the books, bright First Ones runes.

Biology of the…

Trials of…

…and you.

Torn and damaged symbols overwhelm me in a menagerie of light and confusion. I look away from them. “You brought us here?”

“I wouldn’t say ‘brought’. I dragged your deadass in. You’re heavier than I remember.” Your smirk perseveres.

“Well we have to go back to them. They could get attacked again and we’re at a tactical disadvantage if we’re cut off from each other.” I mentally flip through contingencies and options to get us back to Darla, acid rain be damned.

“Adora, everyone is okay. We have to worry about ourselves right now. We’ve been trapped here for a couple hours.”

“Is Darla coming to get us?”

"Something about the rain. Shorts out her control systems. I tried scouting but…" You straighten your stance and wince.

"And what about that?" I point at your side. "Can I take a look at it?"

You wave me away again. "I know there's a lot in that stupid portal belt but I don't think you're going to find anything to help with bruised ribs. Relax Adora. I just had a fall when I was dragging you up the steps."

"Relax… right." I suck in a steadying breath.

You smirk despite the pain. "Hey, you're doing better. I almost believed you that time."

I smile through the trickles of panic lacing through my mind. I can't help myself. "All right." If you don't have enough intel on your situation, you need to go get it. I resist saying it. Training and mantras don't usually cheer you up. "You come up with any plans while I was out?"

"Hah." You scratch at your left ear and flick beads of moisture from it. "None came to mind. I was too busy watching out for more protection bots." You cough and then wince in pain.

It conjures up a sympathetic frown from me but arguing with you won't help us get out of here. "How many were there getting out here?"

"Lots. You should've seen me. Entrapta's little gift is coming in handy." You hold out your hand with your palm up. A sphere of flame ignites. It looks like a perfectly round sphere of immolating fluid suspended there. It flickers against your face and a mixture of feelings churn inside of me. You're at once more frightening than ever, but you're also here with me now. The orange gemstone set in your black choker illuminates in synchronicity with the conjured flame. You shake your hand and extinguish it.

Rationality grabs hold and the fear of our situation slips away in your little display. We were fighting together now and we both have access to magic. Might as well start enjoying it. "Well can I just transform into She-Ra. Maybe I can—" I lift up my hand, tensing as I ready to summon the Sword.

"No!"

I startle, dropping my hand, and stare at you. Your eyes are wide, pupils dilated. The runestone inlaid in the choker on your neck glows ominously. Behind you, your tail is stiff as a rail.

"Why… Why not?" What are you afraid of?

"I think… You tried to transform and it—" Your words stop and you look away from me. A painful silence grows the gap between us until you look back at me. "It fizzled and that's when a bot got the drop on you. I don't know what happened but let's not try it until we know what's going on." With shaking hands you reach behind you and tug at your tail, smoothing the bristled fur. "It was a mess. Our whole little mission, sorry, *quest* has gone sideways. Nothing is going as we expected."

I twist my mouth in thought. The ghosts of memories flicker in the back of my mind. They're so far away. Another rise of fear, of helplessness, sneaks around in my thoughts. I quell it. "Sounds like we didn't have a good plan."

"Hey, we had a great plan. The stupid planet just didn't cooperate." You feign indignation.

I smile as you relax again. "All right, but *why* are we here, Catra? I still don't know that."

"Well, Adora." Bemused sarcasm bleeds into your words and you cross your arms defiantly. "We finally found Eternia after years of searching the wide universe. There wasn't a lot of room to refuse the trip from any of us. Entrapta was beside herself with excitement of course. Bow wanted to get into the library and come back with armloads of books for his dads. Glimmer wanted

to see more of the power that the First Ones could've unleashed in the galaxy. She needed to check if there were any other Etherias that might pose a problem later. And you… I saw you excited. Happy."

Your words ring hollow in me. Some ghost of a memory tells me I should be excited. Why wouldn't I be? "I guess that makes sense."

You laugh in that melodic chuckle with a soft pain creeping behind it. I forget everything about where we are and remember training with you in the Fright Zone. That smirk, that joy. A good memory. I need that right now.

"That's a start. Now that you're not unconscious dead-weight let's go check this place out." You shift your weight to the left, but the pressure against your ribs there drives you back to the other foot.

"So a scouting mission?" A broad grin graces my face at the memory from long ago in spite of the circumstances.

You shake your head and wave at me dismissively. "Fine if that's what you want to call it." I catch that little grin again, the one you always try to hide.

"I do." I let the grin slip and pivot on my feet to cast my light around the room scanning over it once more. Gleaming symbols dot the floors from the forgotten and torn tomes. "Are all the rooms like this?"

"From what I've found, yeah. It's all the same. But I think there was some kind of throne room up here." You turn to the door behind you and walk, tail flicking left and right.

I take up a short jog to catch up to you. You have a slight limp on your left. "You sure I can't help you?"

We walk in silence before you bump your shoulder into mine. "It's fine. I'll let you know when something's actually broken." A

reassurance, though I can't quite shake my worry. You carry a contemplative smile as you look to the floor.

"All right." I chuckle and bump back.

I pick my light up again and shine it down the hall. The corridor funnels us down walls lined with gray columns. They look as though they have been carved from granite, but small sprites of light glide over the surface of them. Behind them are the matching gray walls with open windows on either side. The oppressive sound of rain is near deafening in this narrow hall.

So is the smell. Acrid, sour acid fills the air and I twitch my nose. Yours crinkles, and you have a different grimace of pain. "You ok—"

"Adora, if you keep asking that I'm going to claw you."

"S—"

"And don't apologize either."

I squeeze my lips together barely managing to tackle my reflex. "Sooo… it's really raining, huh?" I scratch the back of my neck. You playfully glance at me from the side. I cough and shine the light ahead again. A doorway twice as tall as ourselves looms at our approach. As we get closer, there are two shattered doors that look to be made of cast bronze. They've both been cleaved in half horizontally and lay in a pool of blue-green tarnish. The gemstones that were set on the face now just shattered remnants.

Other than the doors, the room seems sparse. The architecture funnels our eyes towards a dais in the middle of the room. On it is a throne of carved stone that has been also cleaved. This one down straight down the middle. Someone didn't approve of it, clearly.

"What in the name of Etheria happened—"

A piercing shriek. A dull thud. Knives of light stab into my thoughts. Into me. I clasp at my head and fall. Somewhere in the distance I hear you call my name.

"Hey, Adora!"

A smack on my shoulder woke me out of a daze.

I blinked. The Fright Zone sprawled before me in dimming light. Small skiffs jetted along between the rows of machinery carrying Horde soldiers and bots. The machinations of Hordak laced through the streets like ants. Small beacons of light scanned from unoccupied watch towers.

"Sorry, what?" I turned to see your mischievous smile.

"You zoned out there for a minute." You stood beside me, hands grasping the rungs of the handrail and you were close. Close enough I felt your body heat. Something tingled in my chest.

"I was just thinking." I turned my head to stare at the sprawl again. Noxious fumes emanated from down below, wafting up towards us. A delicate mix of a tar fire and sulfur drew out a shudder of elation from somewhere deep inside.

"About what?" You leaned forward despite the smell. You never found it as comforting as I did. I saw your nose crinkle.

"I guess…"

Your body slid a little closer to mine, the fur of your arm delicately brushing against my thermal shirt.

What were you expecting? The flutter in my chest distracted me. I swallowed and stifled the distraction. It wasn't there. "Why do you think Hordak built guard towers but never put any people in them?"

“Oh.” The disappointment in your voice cut a small gash somewhere in my heart. What was I thinking? You retreated, the gap felt cold again. “You didn’t know?”

“Know what?” The crumbling edifice of the moment tried to drag me into the darkness of the Fright Zone. I was screwing this up.

“Adora.” Your voice was almost pitying. “They’re run by bots to keep an eye out for soldiers that run.”

A wash of shame crept up through the back of my neck. “Why would they run?”

“Princesses have some kind of mind control that they use to corrupt them or something like that.” You cocked an eyebrow at me, as though I was the biggest, dumbest idiot out of all the cadets.

I kept fighting back the doubt. I was okay. This could be okay. I slipped back into a smile. “Huh, how do you know that?” A light casted the shadows long below us, jagged spikes of black swung across the landscape of metal.

Your dichromatic eyes shone in the dim light. They seemed brighter than the moons above right now. “Just talking with the other cadets. Kyle was rambling on for a bit.”

My grin broke into a toothy smile. “You were *talking* with them?”

You jolted up from the rail and crossed your arms across your chest. “Don’t you start. I’ll scratch that stupid grin off your face.” Your stiff tail and flattened ears showed the indignation you felt. But your left fang betrayed a hidden impish joy.

My smile started to hurt my cheeks. “Wow, you’re getting up to all kinds of things, aren’t you?”

You glared and turned back to the landscape, but not before the faintest hint of a growing smile crossed your lips. “Whatever. We should probably get back.”

No… not yet… couldn’t this night go on forever? I’d already screwed up. I let the moment lapse and I didn’t know what happened. We were supposed to just go back to bed now? Back to the bunkroom with the other cadets? When we… We were free right now and I wouldn’t let that go without a fight. I’d claim the night.

“Hey, look at that.” I pointed off in the distance. The flattened bunker of the forge radiated plumes of fire and smoke. The air shimmered with the rising waves of heat and made the snakes of pipes and towers dance beautifully.

“Yeah? It’s the forge, so what?” You leaned over the rail and squinted your eyes.

“I bet I can beat you there!”

I snatched the grappling hook from my belt and held it into the air above me. I hit the button on the side and the grapplers snapped out with a metallic *shink* . It clanged against the rail as I slammed it on and vaulted over the edge into the abyss below us. My hand trailed on the rope behind me. I gripped the rappelling rope and enveloped it with my legs, sliding down the length in a measured fall. It was all one fluid motion. I bet you were still standing up there.

The rope bit into my palm and scalded my hands, but I was almost to the bottom. As I got close enough, I clenched my boots tight. The sudden resistance stretched the cord and released the friction bearing, retracting the hooks and I freefalled the rest of the way to land in a crouch on the ground. The grappler fell from far above and I grabbed it out of the air, winding the cord back up as I sprinted towards the forge.

Your curses of ire so far above me were some of the sweetest noises ever to grace the Fright Zone.

The first run was a spider web of steam and sewage pipes that criss-crossed a flat run. The first pipe was low. I planted my feet and leapt into the air. With a long stride I pushed off the pipe and lunged forward. I knew this place. I have spent my life here. I couldn't get lost.

I knew exactly where to go.

A steam pipe with a patina of rust laid in front of me next. That one would be too hot to hurdle. I instead opted for a slide. I dropped to my hip and my canvas pants carried me under the pipe narrowly avoiding a stream of boiling water that fell from it.

We'd run through here before. We've made a game of it. But it never felt like this. The pounces and scratches of your pursuit were still far behind me. I already mounted quite a lead. The following few pipes were a series of hurdles until they broke into the next segment.

Box Run stretched in front of me in the narrow valley it occupied. Strange metal trapezoidal monoliths jutted from the dark below. A fall would mean at least a broken bone so the only option was to stay on top of them. Most were too far for the cadets to leap across. I guess if they were slow. I remembered asking why they were here, long ago. But no one knew. No one knew a lot of the reasons why the Fright Zone was the way it was. It made it seem more untamed in my eyes, more wild in majesty.

The first run of obstacles was easy enough. A loping gait carried me from top to top with ease. What normally was a two-footed jump, I dispatched with speed and elegance. My balance was sure. The gaps between them opened up further as they stretched on and my jumps needed to be more measured. I calculated each step. And every one of them sent me sailing through the air. My woe, my fear, the doubt from the overlook only moments before was left in my wake.

"Not so fast in a straight line, huh Catra!" I whooped into the air.

"I'll see you in the darkest dungeons of the Fright Zone, you smug little shit!" Claws rent at the metal behind me. Your jumps were more agile than mine so I knew you were catching up.

With a final leap I cleared the last of the pits of Box Run and now we were in the access roads to the forge. Angular concave walls framed the snaking path. It seemed made to be as inefficient as possible to get material and bots to the forge but that made it more fun. There weren't any shortcuts that you could take or corners you could cut. And it was flat ground again. My muscles burned with fury. It'd been so long since I ran like this. I hadn't had a reason to. This wasn't training. This wasn't another day. This was *our* time. Our night together. But we could enjoy it once you finally caught up to me. I was already preparing my victory speech.

It's okay, Catra. I'm sure you'll finally get the hang of running in a straight line. I can give you some pointers if you like.

Euphoria graced my soul. It was so easy. I felt alive. Maybe this was what being happy was like? I rounded the first corner as the drab green walls rushed past me in a blur. I planted my boot and pushed off it, rounding the obtuse angle. The depths of the machinery below belched a black column of tarry smoke from a vent hole I ran past.

I spared a quick glance behind me. You ran on all fours. Your claws were extended and you shredded the metal under you. I'd never seen you run like that, either. And you were gaining on me. But I noticed something else. A face I'd never seen before. I'd seen you smile. I'd seen you frustrated. This wasn't either of those. Your excitement ascended past any happiness I'd seen before and it thrilled me.

That didn't mean I was going to let you win.

I leaned forward and pumped my arms with my stride. It was only a couple more corners. Surely not enough time for you to catch up. I threw everything into my run.

I only noticed it when it was too late to change my footing. An iridescent pool of oil waited for me. Something left by a bot or a careless maintenance crew. My foot landed squarely on it and twisted to the side. I knew that was going to hurt later. But I had other problems. My hip slammed into the unyielding steel ground under me jolting through my body. My pants wet from the lubrication slid effortlessly on the ground right towards the gaping mouth of a vent-hole carved into the floor.

I scrambled to turn, to pivot, something to divert my course, but all of my momentum carried me to it in an awkward slide. I couldn't stop. I couldn't grab hold of anything. Instead, the yawning maw of darkness swallowed me up. With a great gulp the shadows pulled me down. Where did this vent go?

"Adora!" I heard you call.

The void swallowed me up and I plummeted down into the pit. My arm caught on the side of a pipe. It pushed me off headfirst into the wall. Once it started it was unstoppable. I rattled like a doll in pain and agony until I landed.

I remember it was loud. I remember it was dark.

I thought I was going to die.

It was loud. It was bright. The chirps, the laughing, they all grated on my senses. I tried to block them out. Rushing water, grass, it nipped at my senses and ate little bits of my sanity away. This was wrong. It felt wrong.

It felt *soft.*

I practiced on the balcony. Garden? The thing with the green things on it. I sucked in air, the perfume of lavender and hibiscus

irritated my nose. Jab, cross, kick. Kick, pivot, kick, elbow. My muscles burned. Fire fueled me.

Your face. That expression. It lingered in my mind every waking moment like a knife at the back of my neck threatening to push through at any moment.

You stepped away in fear from me that day, the Horde tanks lying scattered around us in Thaymor.

Duh! Did ya just figure that out? Manipulation is Shadow Weaver's whole thing. She's been messing with our heads since we were kids.

How could you possibly be okay with that?

Because, it doesn't matter what they do. The two of us look out for each other. And soon we'll be calling the shots. Now, can we go home?

Home.

How could that be home? How could you *ever* call that place home?

I set my teeth. I jumped up, snapping my leg out in a front kick and then fell to a knee. I reached back behind me for a shock stick to follow up with, only to grasp at empty air. Right. The tailors could make another jacket and belt, but not the Horde survival kit. Any tool to solve any problem I faced. But I had the Sword of Protection now. She-Ra. It'd be silly to ask for anything more. Don't be selfish. They wouldn't understand anyway.

Adora.

Your voice was there too. Speaking to me in the quiet moments.

Why are you doing this?

Because you left me.

I didn't… Why didn't you come with me? We were right there. If you knew Shadow Weaver was doing that to us, why did you let her—

"Adora!"

I faltered on my next roundhouse kick and my pivoting toe slipped. I barely caught myself and staggered back to balance. With my legs securely under me, I looked up. Queen Angella stood with her hands clasped in front of her.

"Your—Your Majesty!" I clamored for thought. Wait do I bow? Kneel? My hand snapped into a quick salute before I could stop myself.

"Are you all right?" Her voice harmonized with authority and kindness. But there was something else lingering as well. Was it annoyance? Had I done something wrong?

"I'm… It's fine. I'm fine." The simmering frustration died away but in its wake there was a raw pain. My salute fell limply to my side.

"You sound like my daughter." She smiled at me. "Would you like to take a walk with me?"

I didn't think I could refuse. "I… ah… Yes, Your Majesty."

She gestured back toward the palace. I picked up a gentle jog to walk at her side. Agitation climbed in my chest as my muscles drained of their blood. The distraction of exertion no longer kept my frustrations at bay. I clenched and unclenched my hands, kneading at my knuckles to alleviate some of the tension. She smelled of a spring breeze up close, and maybe something else I couldn't put a finger on. Or maybe that was just what I imagined what one would smell like. The Fright Zone didn't really have seasons.

She glided across the floors of the golden hallways with the windows high above. The sunlight of the afternoon glinted off the

glass and gemstones, scalding my eyes. Why did everything here have to be so bright… though, I guess maybe that was why they called it Bright Moon.

She nodded to a passing guard. I caught the dubious look the guard shot over their shoulder at me before turning the corner. I couldn't blame them. I'd be suspicious of a Horde soldier if they'd randomly come to the Fright Zone claiming to be an eight-foot tall warrior princess. It was ridiculous. What was I even doing here...

Queen Angella's soft voice broke me out of my thoughts. "How are you settling in?"

"Oh, me? I'm fine. You've been very… thoughtful."

"Now Adora." Her words were authoritative, but not painful. "It's not in your best interests to lie to the queen of Bright Moon."

A cold washed down my back. "I wouldn't… Yes, Comm—Your Majesty."

"Tell me the truth."

The halls were circular in their paths, horrible for cover. A paranoia grew in the back of my head. I knew none of the guards liked me. They could… I pushed the thought away. "I'm sorry. I'm not quite used to the palace yet."

"That is understandable." Angella continued forward, unperturbed. "You've spent all of your life in a very different home."

I glanced around at the open space, the glossy floor, and couldn't help but think of the dim and cramped hallways of the Fright Zone. "I didn't really know places like this existed."

"They never even spoke of Bright Moon in the Horde?" She nodded to another resident carrying an armload of pillows past us. Why did they need so many pillows here, anyway?

“They did. Just, not like this. There were supposed to be spikes and fire everywhere.”

Angella’s laughter serenaded the halls. “The thought.”

The hall eventually tapered off into the main entrance, before which was the bridge over the water and into the forest framed on either side by vertical mountain ridges with islands of floating rock. The Moonstone’s margaritaceous surface glittered in the afternoon light, glowing with warmth as birds and butterflies fluttered serenely around it. Below, the wall tents emblazoned with the crescent of Bright Moon of the Rebellion camp stood among the safety of the first trees of the Whispering Woods.

We continued walking through the balcony garden framing the main entrance. She floated down the steps while mine were measured and smooth.

“They were right about the moat at least.” I pointed out the river below and chuckled awkwardly.

Angella glanced at me sideways, her brow furrowing. “Adora, that’s just the river.”

“Oh…” Unease slipped into the back of my mind again.

We arrived at the bottom together and continued along the river. Here, the sound of the river and the waterfalls was almost deafening. A thin mist hung in the air from the water plummeting onto the stones below. A constant cascade.

Angella stepped into my field of vision. “What is wrong, dear?”

Ahead of us loomed the Whispering Woods. Even though I had crossed through it a month before, it still exuded a threatening ghost. A memory. A thought of when I lost you.

What was I supposed to say?

“This place is strange.”

"I understand," Angella said.

"You do?" I turned to her, shocked.

"Of course." She smiled at me. It had a warmth to it, but something about the expression didn't quite allay the uneasiness in me. "We've taken you in from a place that wanted to make you a soldier since you were a child. You have only known a regimen of training and sleeping. We don't live that way."

I nodded. "Thank you, Your Majesty." No other words really came to mind.

"Now, answer me honestly this time." Her hands were still clasped loosely in front of her, her wings trailing elegantly behind. How did she always seem so calm? "What is wrong, Adora?"

The dam could no longer hold. "Well, the food has all these flavors and I don't really understand why. Isn't that just wasting nutrients if things are just added to make it taste better? And the beds are still too soft and I just can't relax if I don't feel like I can jump out of it. What if someone tries to grab me? I'll just sink in! And there's too many open sight lines with the round corridors so your hallways aren't defensible. And the rooms are so big and I don't really understand why because you could fit another whole *three* squads in there. And it's so noisy that I can't really sleep—"

"Adora!"

I startled at myself, having to inhale a huge breath. Had I really just said that? I shouldn't have. What did I just say to the queen of Bright Moon? How could I have… "Sorry! I'm sorry. I didn't mean any disrespect."

She stopped. Eyes of violet looked down at me. Her implacable expression—had I just traded one mask for another? A familiar feeling of cold dread washed through me. I looked away, clenching my fists at my sides. I was ready. She couldn't hurt me. I'd been through worse.

She raised her hand, and I prepared. Tensing from head to toe. I didn't know what was coming. A strike? A blast of her magic? I was not prepared for what actually happened.

Her hand settled gently on my shoulder. "It is all right."

"What?" A rush of entangled emotions swelled. I looked up at her incredulously.

"It is all right, Adora. I think we can make some accommodations. Whatever you need to feel more comfortable. More at home." Her thumb caressed at my shoulder.

I was shocked silent.

"Would that be all right?"

The chirping of birds and rushing of the waterfalls was less distracting and more of a serenade rounding out the sharper sounds. The brightness of the sun glinting off the waters, the shining buildings less blinding and more of a warding against the darkness. The Whispering Woods less looming and more protective.

At home? Could I? Here?

"Y… Yes." I met her eyes again, nothing like the pale whites of the mask.

Her hand squeezed my shoulder, a reaffirming pressure. "Good. I want you to be comfortable if you're going to be living here with us." Sincerity bled through all of her expression. I was wrong. She wore no mask, just kindness.

I never forgot that face.

The glowing pink lines of First One's tech illuminated the shape of her face. The gold tiara framed the expressionless visage with the blazing image of a sun behind her. The sharp lines of her

spaulders fanned about her almost like wings. And clasped with her hands, the sword. The one I had destroyed.

I stood at the base of Darla's entrance ramp, looking up at her image. I still felt awed by the art that we found of She-Ra around Etheria. It still seemed unreal that she was a part of me. I couldn't ever forget it, but I also couldn't really comprehend it. Two disparate parts of myself I was still trying to reconcile. The same juxtaposition of the sleek First One's ship sitting among the twisting and wild trees of the Whispering Woods.

"Adora!" Bow patted my shoulder knocking me out of the trance I was in.

"Bow! Hey!" I jumped and turned to him. There was a layer of sweat on his forehead and he was a little out of breath. How long had he been standing there? I grinned at him. "What're you doing here?"

"Entrapta needs some Horde Prime tech as spares for Darla in case any systems fail." He nudged a box next to his foot that rattled discordantly with the metal bits and bobs inside of it.

Had he really carried that thing all the way up out here by himself? Why hadn't I heard him. I shook my head dismissing the questions. "She can patch the two of those together?" I peered into the box full of white and black armor plates and fractured computer parts.

He shrugged. "She's Entrapta. I think I'll be scared the day she says she can't do something."

"I don't even want to think about that."

"Want to help me bring it up?" He squatted down by the box again.

"I don't know. She seemed busy getting Darla back up and running."

"That's why we're *helping* her." Bow winked

A worried fleeting thought skimmed across the back of my mind. I remember her sitting on the docks, Swiftie at my back. The brilliant and energetic personality was lost in the tides of Seaworthy. She wasn't herself. And she hadn't spoken much since she got to Bright Moon. Maybe it would be good to see her.

I nodded at him and stooped down to pick up the other side of the box. "I needed to get some lifts in today anyway."

Bow chuckled to himself and nudged me forward. I started backing up the ramp of Darla. "You excited to go to space again?"

"Without a psychotic megalomaniac chasing us with an armada of clones? Sure. It'll be nice. I remember how quiet it was sometimes on the ship." I reflected back to you. Those nights we laid on the cot together. Sometimes afraid to touch each other, other times embraced so tightly we wanted to become one. Maybe we could sort things out there. Peace would be good.

"I really can't wait to meet the Star Siblings again. Their tech was completely different from the things Etherian makers can produce. I think we could set up some kind of trade with them! We could learn a lot together." He huffed out his words between his breaths.

"What's wrong, Bow?" I hefted my side a little. "Been getting soft after all the action?"

He squinted in frustration at me. "No, I just carried this thing here by myself before I saw you."

I smirked. My snarky verbal riposte was lost when we overheard her.

"Your systems appear to be slightly degraded since last time! Who's been doing basic maintenance on you? I'm going to need to do a full diagnostic screening and spares replacement before we even take off. I think that I can utilize some of the self-repair

nanomachines but some augmentation may be required.” A bite lurked in Entrapta’s words.

“Thank you, Entrapta. I have missed you, too,” Darla replied.

There was no response from Entrapta. Empty silence hung in the air in a way that struck me through the heart. A missing reply, something that needed said but couldn’t be. What was wrong? I motioned to Bow to set the box down.

We turned the corner and Entrapta stood in the empty cockpit with a diagnostic hologram filling the air above her. She didn’t move. Her back was to us, her pigtails slack. They dribbled over the floor like dead lilac snakes. The Whispering Woods loomed in the corners of the canopy window. An audience for whatever pain she was going through right now.

Bow leaned over for a quiet whisper. “I’m worried about her.”

“Me too.” I clutched my forearm.

A lapse of regret coursed through my conscience. There were words that we promised to her on Beast Island and I never thought they’d go unfulfilled. It had seemed easy after our battle with Prime that everyone would be happy and… and… *take care of each other* . Bow and I promised we’d never leave her behind again.

But she left for Beast Island with Hordak. And we just let her. Something was wrong and I couldn’t fight back the guilt.

“I need to go talk with her.”

“What are you going to say?” Bow furrowed his brow in concern.

“I don’t know but I can figure it out.” I broke from the doorway and approached her from behind. I crossed halfway through the cockpit before I thought it’d be best to not startle her too badly. “Entrapta?”

She whirls around and I have to duck a flying tendril of her hair. It sails in the air over my head. Her expression radiates overflowing joy and deep red eyes glitter in the light. "Adora! Hi! I'm so glad you came!"

I stand, shocked. What had happened to the sad, taciturn woman from moments before? She was completely different. Happy, excited.

"Greetings, Adora!" Darla chirped in her excited voice. She sounds more human by the day, like she was forgetting how to be a computer.

I stare between the two of them, looking in disbelief. "I don't… Is everything okay?" My confusion eats at my composure.

"They're *better* than okay! I have to show you something." She spins around on her pigtails to face the hologram in the middle of the room. It isn't a diagnostic of Darla anymore, it's a series of lines that lead to a singular point in the middle. Entrapta opens her pigtails and zooms in on the planet. "I've traced the neural thaumetic strings to an origin point. I think I found another locus of magic like Etheria!"

I blink and grasp my arm, that uncomfortable tic swelling up as I try to assemble how I got here, or what just happened. I turn back to look for Bow, maybe he can make sense of it? But it's just emptiness in the doorway. Even outside, the trees and sky of Etheria have been replaced with a vast, endless starfield. The discomfort eats into me so far that a tidal bloom of frustration mingles with fear.

"I…" My voice chokes.

"It's amazing! It rivals Etheria for thaumetic energy and I think that can mean only one thing!" She spins to face me. "My calculations have located Eter—" Her joy drops into concern instantly when she sees me. "Adora? Is everything okay?"

I want to say yes. I want so badly to understand what's happening. But it's hollow. I shake my head. "Something's wrong. I… I don't know what's going on."

In a blur, her hair unfolds into probes and diagnostic devices. It's fast and alarming enough that it shocks me out of my growing unease for a moment. Some radiate light from their glowing tips that scan me up and down. Others orbit with tiny radar dishes making distressing chirping noises. And another reaches out with a tiny grabbing claw to pluck a sample from my jacket. She draws her datapad from behind her and stares intently at the screen. Her eyes widen. "Uh-oh."

Entrapta is the worst person in the universe to utter those words.

"What?" My stomach freefalls and I brace my legs under me to stay upright.

"You're in a temporal dissociation." She looks up at me and concern bleeds into her eyes.

Am I being diagnosed as terminal? "A what?"

"I think a thaumetic flux has localized on you—possibly She-Ra—and has corrupted your linear time-stream resulting in a confusion of past, present, and future events."

"What does that mean?" I swallow a lump in my throat.

"It means you don't know where, or specifically when you are." She starts working through key-presses on her pad at a rate that astounds me. The quiet fills with her pattering naked fingers. When had she stopped wearing her gloves?

She finishes with her last command and looks back up to me. Her concern hasn't lifted since we started talking.

A fear slinks into the place where my stomach once was and roils inside of me. "Can you fix it?"

"I'll try, but given your temporal uncertainty, I might not be around to find the cause. Help from an intervening party might not be feasible."

I nod. I've had worse problems, but not by much. "What can I do?"

Entrapta shrugs and then reaches out to place a pigtail on my shoulder. "I don't know, but I'll do everything I can to help."

I place a hand on her comforting strands of hair. I guess that's enough for now. "Thanks."

Uncertainty

Glimmer's hurt bad!

Get out of here!

We can't just leave you with her.

Just run! I'll lead her away.

Ooh, my head. It's spinning, intermittent throbs sending the whirl going again. It's like doing loop-de-loops with Swift Wind. I like doing loop-de-loops with Swift Wind. Is that where I am? No wait… this is ground beneath me. I push against it, lifting myself up on an elbow.

My eyes are captivated by a burst of incandescent orange light. A kaleidoscopic mirage of color and heat. It's so beautiful. I want to touch it. My feet are beneath me, I'm not sure how, but they convey me forward toward the light show. Amid all the flickering lights, a shadowed figure is flipping and spinning. It's like a dance, though I don't hear any music. Princess Prom! Is that where I am?

"Adora!" Someone materializes in front of me. Some *ones* , actually. Two revolving images in my vision. They halt my progress toward the lights and I slump into them, my balance having left somewhere between this step and the last. "What are you doing, you idiot? That's fire!"

I squint, trying to discern them in my swirling vision. All I see are two luminous sets of eyes. One a blue like the gem of my sword. The other like the smoggy haze of the Fright Zone. "Woooaaahhh. You're a pretty kitty." I reach out a hand and paw at their face, gasping at the sensation against my palm. "You're so *soft* ."

They swat my hand away. "What is *wrong* with you?"

I giggle, my legs turning to jelly beneath me, but they hold me aloft. My head is so heavy, I can't keep it from falling against their chest. "Will you be my dance partner? I don't know this song."

"Oh, I recognize this." With a grunt, I shift in their arms and my head lolls back. The motion jostles some of the discordant thoughts into place. The familiar determined grimace, revealing part of a fang digging in frustration into your lip.

"I recognize *you* ." I reach up and bat at one of your ears. It flicks angrily away from my touch.

"Great," you grumble. "I'm not sure this is any better."

I slip a little further down in your grasp, and you drag me across the room. The swirling lights have died away. I guess the party is over. The disappointment leeches the ability to stand from me. You strain, growling low, and then I'm flopping to the floor, puffing up a cloud of dust.

"How did you get *heavier* in the last hour?" You kneel next to me, holding tight to your side.

I swing my arm through the dust, scattering it in the faint light around us like diaphanous crystals. My arm feels like a dull club dislodging waves of tingles through me as I move it. Swirling in patterns through my body the same way the dust swirls in the air. Laughter bubbles from my chest, turning into a cough as I inhale the dust and choke on it.

You turn a smirk towards me. "You are a bit cuter like this."

I recoil back. "Hey, I have a *girlfriend* . You can't talk to me like that." I lean in. "She scratches."

"I bet she does. Come on, sit up."

"You're pretty… pretty… oh woooow. You're *hot* . And you look *just* like her. Did… Hey!" I shout into the ashen gray halls around us. "Hey Catra! Did you have a *twin* ?"

You cringe at my volume and turn an angry eye towards me. “You wouldn’t happen to have a gag in that stupid belt of yours, would you?”

“No but I got lotsa stuff like a *torch* !” I fumble into the pocket dimension of the belt and pull out the cylindrical hand-torch. I hit the button and instead of a beam of light, the point of a retractable baton hits me in the forehead sending a rushing of dizziness through my head. It’s like I’m on the shores of Mystacor with the waves slowly crashing over me, soft and gentle and lolling. I roll with it, letting it take me. The baton scatters across the stones.

“Dammit, Adora.” You set a hand on my shoulder, coaxing me back to the floor. “Don’t…” You look left and right, trying to gather what to say.

“I’m fiiine. I might just nap now though.” My lids are heavy and weigh down on me. The floor might be hard but it’s nice. Some of the dizziness settles as I stretch out.

“Yeah. Nap. Just… stay there,” you say. “I’m figuring out how to get us out of here.”

“Catra—Catra!” I roll onto my side, an inept swing of my arm colliding against you to get your attention. “Do you wanna know a secret?”

You hesitate, your eyes narrowing as you take me in. “A secret?”

I pull myself up, holding onto your shoulders against the alternating currents of gravity pulling me back toward the floor. Our faces are close, but I have to get close to make sure. You lean in a little. I stare into your eyes, alternating my attention between the two.

“Did you know your eyes are different colors? Like one is *one* color and the other is a *different* one.” I press in closer, but there isn’t any space left and our foreheads collide. “It’s so *cool* .”

Your ears flatten in resignation and you sit back glowering at me. I slip down into your lap with a manic giggle. "Yes, Adora. I am aware. That is not a secret."

"It's not?" I'm flabbergasted. I could've sworn… I'd only just noticed myself. I just like looking at them.

"No." You speak through clenched teeth. "A secret is something people *don't* know. Not something that is on my face. Now will you *please* just go to sleep?" You unceremoniously flip me back onto the floor and you pull yourself to your feet with a nearby chair. "I don't want to be stuck in here with this version of you forever."

Your tail flicks in annoyance as you survey the room around us. It brushes my face eliciting a new series of giggles from me. It's so soft. So cute. I just want to touch it. You jump in surprise when I grab your tail, emitting a sharp squeak. Your fur poofs up like a bottlebrush and I laugh harder in delight.

"Stop that!" You yank your tail away. I frown and stare at my hand, feeling its loss deeply.

"Ooh! Ooh! Catra!" I claw myself to my feet by the dusty and desiccated table. My hand slips out from under me, but you catch me before I can clatter to the ground again. I pull myself up in your arms instead, finding stability against the dizziness by resting my head in the crook of your shoulder. "I got a secret."

"Adora, I *swear* if you tell me I have a tail, I'm gonna—"

"I had a crush on you when we were kids."

You begrudgingly wrap your arms around me to keep me from falling to the floor. "Yeah, gotta say that's not much of a secret either."

"No, no—that's not the secret." I fling an arm up so I can cup my hand by my mouth and whisper in your ear. "I actually liked

the brown rations the best. You always liked the gray kind better so I said I did too. I just wanted you to like me."

You stiffen beneath me as I let my arm slip limply over your shoulder. A small, breathy laugh escapes you and you relax, arms tightening around me. "You big idiot. You really didn't have to try so hard at *that* ."

"I know." I laugh, feeling the first rumblings of your purr against my face. It lulls me, molding the dizziness in my head into soothing crashes of waves. "Okay. I'm gonna go to sleep now."

I go limp in your arms.

"Wait—Adora—don't!"

But it's too late. I'm asleep before I hit the floor.

"Adora! Adora!"

I was jostled, hands on my shoulders heaved me up and down, my head sliding against something hard. I reluctantly opened my eyes. My head felt like it was split in two.

I saw your wide eyes capture and reflect the light like two glowing lanterns. "Adora, wake up. Please." Pleading. It was fine. I was just tired.

"I'm awake." My tongue was too fat for my mouth, slurring my words.

"C'mon, you gotta get up." You tugged at me. A budding, confused urgency pushed me forward while the ringing in my ears attempted to drag me back into darkness.

You tugged again and I fell back, a wash of soot cloyed into my nose and I coughed at the scent of carbon and tar. Was I…?

Adrenaline flushed through me. I had to get up. I banged my head on the low ceiling and it washed my vision in more stars. Another sleep. Away from the pain. No, I can't. Stay awake.

"No! Dammit Adora!" Your hands patted over my body trying desperately to find something broken inside of me.

"Catra, we gotta…" The thoughts were so far away. They swam in a morass of sticky confusion.

"I know! Sit up! Sit up!" You grasped my arms and pulled me forward. My head spun as you dragged me forward. You turned in the narrow passage, and I landed with an arm draped over your shoulder. You were careful, minding the low ceiling. The pipe. A pipe full of black tar and… oh no.

Your feet gathered under you in an awkward crouch. The pipe was too small to stand, and too narrow to comfortably kneel. I could barely see anything as I blinked through my fatigue.

You shuffled forward, feet barely able to lift off the ground. I had to do something to help. I couldn't let you just do this on your own. I tried to push up with mine. A shot of raw pain jolted up my leg from my ankle. I yelped and fell onto your back. It threw you off balance.

You faltered and I stopped my struggles. "Just stay still. I can get us out of here."

I believed you.

Shuffle step.

Shuffle step.

The roar of the inferno swelled. What was once a distant growl rose in a tremor that shook the pipe. Your body trembled under me. How long were we walking for? How long did you drag me in this crouch? What was happening, Catra? More sleep, more

grogginess. My arms were rubbery, but you clasped my wrists tight. You would not let me slip.

Dim light grew in the tunnel. My eyes adjusted to the flickering rufescence that glowed on the blackened pipe. You grunted now with every step. Your breath rattled through your teeth.

"Catra…"

"We're almost there. You're gonna owe me *big* after this. Just please hang on, Adora."

It took all of my strength to hang on. I had to. I lapsed into a clouded realization and knew where we were. I knew what was going to happen.

We reached the hole that bore the ragged marks of your claws where you had rent through that pipe. Fresh steel glinted bright in the orange glow.

I also finally felt the heat. How had I been so lucky?

You dropped through the hole first, leaving me to lie on my stomach against the lukewarm floor. I grabbed the edge of the opening and pulled my head out. My face was awash in the heat of the forge. You stood on the narrow catwalk.

Ha, catwalk.

I blinked away the growing delusions. You reached a hand up to me.

"Be careful. But hurry."

Connecting to this pipe just ahead was the furnace and corresponding crucible. It was full of scrap metal from deconstructed bots. Ready to be melted down and remade. The furnace under it was dark, but who knew for how long? Everything in this exhaust pipe was about to be consumed in a scalding torrent of smoke and inferno. Hurry Adora. Hurry.

I slapped my hand into yours. You clamped tight and pulled while I pushed with my good, left leg. I let my other dangle behind me, gritting my teeth in pain.

When my stomach cleared the hole, I couldn't hold on any longer. I fell. I twisted myself and managed to land on my shoulder. Another jarring shock shot through my spine and my vision clouded with stars again.

You didn't hesitate. You hefted my body up, tapping into strength I saw so rarely. I fell onto your shoulders again and you kept walking. At least able to stand upright again.

"We're not out of the Whispering Woods yet," you said in a strained voice.

My feet hung like dead weight behind me. I had to help. I attempted to stand again but another spike of pain lanced up my leg. I cried out and fell heavily on your shoulders again, almost knocking you down to the grating on the catwalk.

"Stop that!" you snarled. "For once just let me handle this."

I nodded and an errant bead of sweat dripped from my chin. Just pulling me over the grating was flaring up more pain in my ankle. I didn't want to say it. But the agony was a rising tide. "My leg…"

You paused. I expected a biting response. You always seemed so impatient when it was like this. When we were like this. I just wanted to help. You…

You looked down at my leg, and then back to me. Your eyes were set in determination. "Get on my back." You stooped onto the grating, legs under you in a squat.

"What're you—"

"Just get on!"

I couldn’t argue. I couldn’t stand so it was more of an awkward slide and fall. But you shouldered the weight and hooked your arms around my legs. I grasped tight around your collarbone and you lifted with shaky legs.

You carried me from that room, every step a methodical plod. The doorway was an agonizingly long walk. We stopped and I slid off your shoulders so you could turn the wheel of the door yourself. Your biceps flared and teeth clenched in exertion. You’d rip the door open if you had to. With a chilling groan the degraded metal bars released and, you pushed the door open just in time to meet the roar of the furnace’s ignition.

You turned to me and your eyes spoke the panic in your soul. “C’mon!” You scrambled towards me and grabbed roughly under my shoulders.

I thought I should protest, or drag myself through. But it’d only make things worse. You had to do this. There wasn’t another way. I slid against the cool decking and the doorway ground against my back as you dragged me over the threshold. We collapsed just on the other side. You jumped up and slammed the door shut as the ignition of the furnace finished. Black smoke menaced at the edges of the door until you spun the wheel and the bars locked shut.

Now it was just you, me, and the cacophony of a furnace with a cut exhaust pipe in the bowels of the Fright Zone.

I dragged myself up and leaned against the cool, concrete wall while you slumped on the one opposite me. Sweat soaked your fur and your breathing was still heavy. Soot adorned your cheeks and blackened your hands.

“That was close.”

Your face pinched in a sour glare at me.

I held up a hand. “Sorry!”

You waved off my apology, but you still scowled. Maybe not at me, though. "We have to get to a sick bay. I think there's one down here."

"Are you sure? I think if I just let it—"

"Yeah, I am." You stood again, legs shaking under you. You stepped across the hall and extended a hand for me. "Let's get you patched up."

I saw a mixture of worry, fear, and relief in you. I nodded and took your hand. There was no other way. Wordlessly you pulled me up and I clambered back onto your back.

You carried me there, and only once did you say I was sneaking in too many ration bars.

A diagram of different pictures and red strings lays on the floor in front of us. Entrapta sits beside me. Her strands of hair pluck up a pin and place it on another page.

"I believe the lapsing temporal disconnection is connected to states that coincide with the current circumstances, but also are in conflict with future events." She scratches her chin with a pigtail and draws her datapad.

"What kind of 'future events'? How far into the future?" The tangled web of images and schematics barely make sense to me. Some of them are pictures of five dimensional space that Entrapta was inventing as we went along. Others were drawings of the visions that I have been having as best as I can recall. One is a rough sketch of a winged figure. Angella. Was she here? Yes. Right now she is. But also she was in the past. She said something then.

Another is a drawing of a throne split down the middle. Cleaved by some sword long ago. Maybe that was something on Eternia? I'd never seen a throne like that before.

I rub my temples. You're always there, though. Always present. Present, past, future. You're trying. I'm trying. I was, am, and will try for you. I have to.

"I think it's reasonable speculation to assume it occurs on Eternia but I can't locate a triggering event in the data we've managed to transcribe from your temporally discordant cognitive experiences. We need additional illustrative diagrams to better assess the current time-entropy." The datapad chirps and she moves another pin to another diagram.

A memory flashes through me. "Wait, I think I see something." I can see him again.

Entrapta shoves the nearest writing implement and a piece of paper at me. "Quick. Before you lose it. Every tiny detail you notice."

I start sketching him out.

I finished the last stroke of wax on my diagram, rounding off the last point of a spike on Horde Prime's ship. I sat back from my cross-legged seat and examined my work. It was big enough, for sure. The Velvet Glove. What a stupid name. Was it supposed to be intimidating? I certainly wasn't scared… at all.

You want to go back for her.

I can't just leave her there. I have to try.

I was coming for you, Catra. Nothing was going to stop me.

I bit the end of a wax pencil.

"What're we doing?" Bow called from the open door of my room.

"Entrapta and I are…" I looked around. She wasn't here. Why would she be? She was tinkering somewhere on Darla. She was

so excited to have a new project, nothing could break her from that distraction. What a silly thought.

I shook my head and focused on Bow. "Making a plan." His expression was dark and I was uncomfortably reminded of that moment back on Beast Island when—I shied away from the memory. "How's Glimmer?"

"She's fine. Just sleeping for now." He leaned against the frame of the door, crossing his arms over the heart emblem on his chest. "That was pretty close getting those thulite crystals."

"You're not going to stay with her?"

"What? Why?"

I shrugged. "Just, you know… she apologized, and you've been talking about it since Beast Island how much you wanted her back. I just thought you'd… y'know… Spend time with her."

His expression was puzzled as I watched the mental cogs work behind his eyes. "We can do that when she wakes up."

I let out a long breath. "All right, well I guess she's been through a lot." I returned to my drawing and put a small diamond on the diagram for Darla.

"What're you working on?" Bow helped himself in, eyeing the scattered papers that surrounded me with discarded attempts at drawing the Velvet Glove on them. He squatted down opposite my battle plan.

"Just been thinking of how we're going to do this. It's not going to be easy. Glimmer didn't exactly clue us in on any holes or ports we could just sneak a bomb inside of."

Bow cocked his head around to get a better view of the drawing from his vantage point. He took in a deep breath. "You're really going back for Catra, aren't you?"

I bit the end of the wax pencil again, the grit of the wax coating my teeth. I looked up to meet his eyes. Sincerity and concern dominated his expression, as usual. “I think I can make it work. I have an idea.”

“Oh?” He settled into a seat across from me. He reached for one of my first drafts and studied it, a similar confused expression on his face as when he had tried to decipher the coronation instructions.

“I’ve got the only thing he’s scared of.”

“What’s that?”

“The Heart of Etheria.” I braced for his resistance.

He cast aside the paper at my words. “That’s insane! It’ll kill everyone and you can’t even activate it without She-Ra!”

I met his incredulous look with a scowl. “That’s not the point, Bow.”

“It’s still crazy. We can’t just throw you in there on a bluff.” He groped through the drafts as though hoping hidden somewhere in there was another idea. There weren’t any. I already knew.

“What else is going to get us on the ship? He’s just going to blow us up if he spots us and he doesn’t see a threat.” I set my hand on my knee. I knew I was glaring but I couldn’t help it.

Bow’s search stopped as he looked at me. “I guess, but what about the rest of us? He doesn’t have a reason to keep us alive.”

I picked the wax pencil back up. “We just have to make sure he can’t find you then.”

He pinched his chin in thought, examining the diagram. He brightened as an idea occurred to him and he tapped the rough diamond representing Darla. “What about Entrapta’s suits?”

"You mean hide outside of the ship? Is that really hiding?"

"I don't think he'd look for us there. I mean, I wouldn't."

I furrowed my brow and looked back down. "Sure, but that won't matter if you're dead. We don't know if those suits will hold up for long. I mean, yours has an ab window..."

"First, I didn't ask her to add that. Second, we won't know until we ask Entrapta." Bow scooped up the discarded drafts and tapped them into a neat stack.

"All right. I like it. Sort of. So what do we do when we're back on the ship?" I took the wax pencil and drew figures on the outside of the ship. All three of them hanging outside for Etheria knows how long.

"Glimmer said something about his ship having a bunch of computers or servers." He turned one of the papers upside-down trying to decipher what I'd drawn. "Maybe if I can get Entrapta there she can hack in and disable his security."

"You think she can do that?"

"We haven't been able to keep her from breaking into anything so we might as well put her talent to good use."

I drew a computer inside of Horde Prime's ship with a little pigtailed caricature of Entrapta. "So that's me, you, and Entrapta."

"Wait. That's Entrapta?" He pointed at my caricature.

"Y—Yeah… those are her pigtails and her… Look we didn't grab your figurines before we left. I'm working with what we got here." I tapped angrily on the page. "What about Glimmer?"

"Well, I figure she knows where Horde Prime would keep the prisoners. She can go bust out Catra."

I drew in Glimmer on a lower level, and hesitated at the thought of adding in a small Catra. I couldn't bring myself to do it. What would you even look like? It had been so long. "So we split up. I distract him by bluffing with the Heart. You and Entrapta shut down his computers. Glimmer gets Catra back. And we all get back to the ship while his security is down."

Bow scratched at his chin. "It's not our best plan."

"It's the one we got. We'll have to make it work." I drew an arrow from our ship into the Velvet Glove. This was crazy.

He took a long, considering pause. "Do you think maybe She-Ra could help us out?"

The question twisted my gut into a knot. "She's gone, Bow. All that's left are the shattered fragments of the sword, and I left those on Etheria. It doesn't work anymore. I made sure of that."

His face brimmed with a hesitant hope. "But Entrapta said—"

"No." I shook my head, shutting down the thought. I couldn't… I didn't want to think… I couldn't afford to hope. "Maybe the earthquake did something to mess with the light. I kept the cave open."

"She said you lifted the rubble all by yourself." His eyebrows sloped in lopsided skepticism.

I scowled back. "I've been training a lot since we got on Darla. And before that, fighting the Horde. I'm stronger than I've ever been."

"All right, all right." He looked back at the diagrams and his expression turned serious again. "This is going to be so dangerous and I was just hoping…" He stopped again, each of these thoughts were such a burden to him.

The wax pencil bent in my grip. "We can't rely on some hope that She-Ra will just suddenly come back. We *need* this plan."

He lifted his eyes from the schematic, deciphering me as much as the drawing. “Adora, are you sure this is worth it?”

I met his eyes once more, almost daring his doubts to challenge me.

“I know you and Catra grew up together, but she’s hurt you *so much* . Are you sure you—”

“Bow—” I was not leaving you. No one was getting left behind. Never again. “For the first time in a long time, I am sure.”

“But how? How can you be sure Catra won’t hurt you again?” His countenance flexed through more than just uncertainty. I saw worry in his face, too.

“If I don’t try, then I don’t… I’m not…” I couldn’t think of the right words. I just knew I couldn’t go back to Etheria without you.

“You really believe in this, don’t you?”

I dropped my eyes, and saw my hand clutched around my left arm. I hadn’t noticed it. “I do.”

He reached out, placing his hand on my shoulder, giving it a reassuring squeeze. A familiar gesture. One he had given me so many times since the Portal. “But you’ve already done so much. We don’t know what’s waiting on Horde Prime’s ship. She sent Glimmer away to save you. You’re already a hero. You’ve saved us over and over again and you’re about to reunite Glimmer with her dad. Everyone needs you back on Etheria and you’re just going to hand yourself over to Horde Prime?”

“I know… I know it’s stupid and crazy. I just... you don’t know what it was like growing up in the Fright Zone.” Memories of you flooded into me. Training all day. Our only purpose was to become soldiers. The only thing we were allowed to want. But through all that, I had you. We had each other. How could I have him understand? How could I ever explain it? The pranks, the exploring, talking. Every happy memory I have of those times was

with you. “You don’t know the Catra that I do. You never got to see her the way I remember and it’s been a long time since I have too... but I heard her again, Bow.” I clutched his hand on my shoulder, trying to convey the strength of my conviction. “The Catra I grew up with. I can’t leave her on that ship.”

“You’re right. I don’t know, but I believe you. I’m going. We’re going.” He sighed and drew back. I heard the burden he carried through it.

There was a long silence between the two of us, staring at the diagram with everything to say and nothing to bridge the gap.

He broke the quiet first. “Was I wrong being angry at Glimmer for so long?”

The pencil clattered onto the floor from my open hand. I fetched it back up quickly. “What? No! You just… were mad. That’s okay.”

“I guess. Glimmer can be so stubborn and so sure of herself and those are things I’ve always admired about her, but sometimes, I just wish she... If she’d just *listened* to us—” I recognized the pain in his voice.

“None of this would have happened?”

Bow relinquished a long held breath like he carried it with him all the way from Etheria. “Everything has just been going wrong for a long time.”

I felt my hand tighten on my forearm. Visions of Mara’s last message flickered in my memory. “I know what you mean but… but we might’ve never found out about the Heart of Etheria, or King Micah, or Entrapta. It’s easy to wonder how things could have been but… everything that’s happened has led us here. To this. And I have to believe it means something.”

He glanced back up, a small smile barely visible on his lips. “You’re right. It’s just all I’ve been thinking about since we left

Etheria."

"I'm sure that's all Glimmer has been thinking about too." I returned his small grin.

He lost it, quickly turning serious again. "I know Glimmer is sorry, but how can I forgive her? How are you still able to forgive Catra?"

I didn't… I hadn't… Did I need to forgive you? Was that why I was going back? I shoved the errant thought away. "I don't know... I don't know if I do forgive Catra. I just... I guess sometimes I want to believe we can all be better. I kind of need to."

"That doesn't sound a lot better than where I'm at." He worried his finger on one of the drawings, smudging a wax line of Horde Prime's ship.

"Hey, I'm doing my best. You're supposed to be the feelings guy. I'm the punching things in the face guy. I've been out of my comfort zone for a while now." I felt a lopsided grin crawl over my face.

He laughed, just the slightest chuckle. It had been a while since I heard anything like that from him. "You're actually getting pretty good at it."

"Thanks, Bow. I have a good teacher."

He looked down and smudged another line. I wanted to stop him but I resisted. "I didn't think we'd ever be sitting here making a plan to break Catra out, though. She almost killed us over and over again. I still don't know if I can trust her."

"How'd you know you could trust me when we found the sword? You didn't. Just had a feeling right? Well... I can believe in Catra. I know what she went through. And getting her back won't be easy, but I have to try. We have to take care of each other."

"I remember you saying that before."

I caught myself. His focus dialed in on me. I suddenly felt naked in front of him. "Yeah, just… I just have to help everyone. And that includes Catra. I have to get her back." I flexed my fingers around the wax pencil.

He smudged another line of my diagram. "You miss her, don't you?"

The pencil snapped between my fingers. Miss you? No that wasn't why I… "What do you mean?"

He glanced up, eyes filled with sincerity. "Angella. You really do miss her, too."

A brief lapse of relief before it settled into an old, weary grief. "Of course I do. She was… She saved me."

"It's more than that, though." He shook his head slowly, brow knitting as he looked at me. "She saved all of us, Adora. But you're the one carrying all the weight."

I shrugged and rolled the broken shard of the pencil on the floor. "Well, I guess."

"It's okay. I kind of get it."

"Bow… You're doing a lot, too."

Confusion rolled over his expression. Funny how he could sing the praises of everyone around him, but shied when it was directed his way. "What do you mean?"

"I had Catra, Lonnie, Rogelio, even Kyle. We looked out for each other. But I don't really think I knew who a friend really could be before I met you."

"I… well…" He shuffled the stack of drafts, shifted them from one side of his lap to the other.

I put my hand on his shoulder the same way he had consoled me and his nervous shuffling stopped. “You’re what’s kept us all together. We couldn’t have done any of this without you… I couldn’t have done it without you.”

His face flushed bright red against his dark skin, the same color as the emblem on his chest. “Oh... well... I try my best.”

I smiled at him and sat back. “I mean, Glimmer would’ve left me to that elemental the day we met if you hadn’t talked her out of it.”

“You’re welcome, by the way.” He winked at me.

“I won’t be able to do this without you, either.” I tap the point of the broken wax pencil on the schematic. Our makeshift, idiotic, and desperate plan. But we were going to get you back. “We’re great at quests, right?”

He reached behind him and withdrew his tracker pad. He pulled up a program and started sketching out the drawing with his finger. “Okay, but if we’re really going to do this we’ll need more than a crayon drawing.”

“Crayon?”

“That’s… you know that’s what you were using. Right?”

I feigned a cough. “Sure, yeah. I was just looking for something temporary.”

Fear

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I wake from a dream, but I'm already standing.

I try to speak, but no words come.

A heavy step of a golden sole clicks against the gray stone. Her muscles are taut and her presence menaces the quiet halls. She's roaming. No, she's hunting.

She rests a hand on the wall, a gray squared stone that makes up the monotone of the castle's architecture. A lurking frustration swells to anger, and she clamps on the block. Fingers gouge the granite like it was clay, and she wrenches it free. She spins, casting it into the far wall and it shatters into dust.

Her bellowing roar follows the pattering of scattered stone. It reverberates through the empty halls before the falling torrent of rain consumes it.

Eons of rot somehow hadn't penetrated this part of the castle. Desiccated beams hold up the roof overhead. She spares a glance into one of the rooms that line the corridor and a modest ancient bedframe lurks in the dim light. The bedding had long ago dissipated into dust.

We're in some kind of barracks or servant's quarters. No decorations adorn the walls or evidence of them anyway. She looks down and sees the ghosts of footfalls on the dusty ground. I recognize them, your bare feet. I can tell from the little scratch marks at the toes that you were running. But where were you now?

The footprints abruptly stop.

She-Ra looks at them skeptically. I sense another rise of frustration inside of her. She examines the beam above her. It bears a series of holes from your claws. She peers deeper into the darkness and two glowing dichromatic eyes stare back.

"Hey, meathead." Your voice curls around a sense of derision. The orange stone blazes on your throat.

Agony courses through my muscles. My nerves are on fire. Her heart is fury.

I am helpless.

Stop it.

She-Ra swings a hand overhead and it collides with the beam, shattering the ancient wood into the empty hall. You've already backflipped into the air and a lash of flame collides against her, staggering her backwards. The flames are a battering wave across her skin. You land on the next supporting beam with your usual grace.

She-Ra crouches low and leaps into the air, both hands outstretched to grab you. A brief flash of surprise reflects in your eyes but you simply roll backwards off the beam. You land on your feet. She-Ra slams chest-first into the supporting beam, the old wood creaking against the force.

"You're still too slow, Adora!"

My name. I'm not her. I'm not this right now. I'm trying to get her to stop Catra.

She slams a fist into the adjacent wall and the wooden beam falls. She lands in a jarring thud and you've already scattered down the hallway, your tail taut behind you.

Heat washes over my back. She-Ra spares a glance behind her. You have ignited all of the supports. They crepitate as the fire consumes them.

She-Ra braces her feet under her and charges after you. As she rounds the corner, the collapsing roof reverberates in the ground under her feet. She doesn't care. Her footfalls crack stone and a haze of bloodlust tries to drag me into an oblivion of fury. Red glowing veins course over her arms, pulsing in the hatred drawn up from some primal fire inside of her.

She rounds the next blind corner only to meet a knee that smashes against her face. The impact sends a jarring shot through her and she staggers again. Even I can feel it. No one has hit She-Ra like that before. Of course you did. She steps back holding the side of her face.

"Watch where you're going!" You grin smugly. "That tiara must be on too tight. You're even dumber than usual."

She-Ra swings an arm, the fist connects with a corner of a wall and knocks the stone away with a burst of smoke and rubble. The unleashed rage in She-Ra bleeds into my mind. I am segregated over to a small corner of her consciousness. I try to stop her. She is a runaway skiff with busted brakes.

You flip from the strike with ease and push off the wall behind you. You kick your legs out and slide on your hip between her legs. I remember these movements, flanking and avoidance. You never fought straight-on in training. You're amazing at it. I hope that She-Ra doesn't share that memory with me.

I am paralyzed to watch her move. She reaches down and grasps, narrowly missing your tail. A gout of flame bursts between her legs. I feel a dull pain in my hand and She-Ra bellows. She spins around and catches a face full of fire from your outstretched hands.

She closes her eyes and I am gifted with blackness. But it illuminates the agony of the burns She-Ra simply ignores. She staggers backwards and bumps her hip against the wall behind her. In the brief distraction, I attempt to reach out to her. Is there anything that I can do to calm her down? But her emotions are

too raw. There's less of a consciousness, more of a thread of primordial pain and anger striking a resonance.

Is this who was always lurking behind the power?

She blinks away the smoke and ashes and wipes tears from her eyes. I have no idea what damage this would do to me as well when—if—I break from this form. A burning tapestry radiates heat to her left. Black scorch marks streak across the wall. Thankfully, the timbers in here appear to be too damp to catch fire.

But where are you?

The halls are dark, near black from the night consuming Castle Grayskull. The last wicks of flame die away and She-Ra's eyes grasp at the thin wisps of light in the dark corridor.

"Hey, dummy!"

A brilliance blinds us at the end of the long hall. A radiant ball of flame hurtles towards her, seemingly as large as the entire hall itself. She-Ra sprints forward and knocks the comet of fire back with an open-handed swat.

"Oh, sh—"

The fireball rockets straight back to you. It spotlights your figure and you catch it with open hands. The force of She-Ra's counter knocks into you, driving you back.

I watch helplessly as your body impacts against the wall behind you. I hear the *thock* of your head hitting the stone.

No.

She-Ra is on you before you can recover. She reaches down, as though grabbing a child. You are nothing in her hands. So fragile.

No!

She-Ra cinches her hands around your neck. She squeezes. I see her muscles flex and strain.

Your white teeth shine in inexorable defiance of She-Ra's strength. Your eyes stare back at her. At me. Flames flicker around us and I see them cast each of your eyes in fire in a loose rhythm. Amber, blue, amber, blue.

You reach up with your hand and I hear the sound of your claws extending. You bite them down into She-Ra's wrists. Blood pours from the slash marks, but I feel her pain squashed by visceral anger.

Stop stop stop!

She won't.

A wet slap smacks against the side of her head and She-Ra's vision goes black again.

What was that?

I hear a dull noise of shuffling and voices next to us, around us. She-Ra's knee lands on the floor with a *thud* . Her hands tear at whatever covers her face. I try to reach out to her again. I can only touch at a chord of primal emotion that singes my psyche. I mentally recoil from her.

"—out of here!" I barely hear your voice amid the chaos.

"Wh… we… supp…" Who was that?

She-Ra's hands find purchase on whatever encased her head and she rips it away. A pain of skin being pulled raw jarrs through me. She bellows another roar and turns.

Bow stands in front of Catra, arrow nocked, and face of determination. Melog curls behind him, red translucent hackles raised.

"I don't know! I've been trying to find whatever is causing this but I keep getting a little *distracted* ." You bite out through gritted teeth.

She-Ra turns, arms outstretched to her sides, and she charges.

"Maybe I can buy us some time to figure it out." He looses the arrow.

In slow motion, it sails towards She-Ra. The blue sparks start arcing before even reaching her. It snaps open in a pincher and impacts onto her chest. Thin tines clamp through her armor to the skin. The jolt sends a shot even into my dim consciousness and she collapses, blessing both of us with blackness again.

Please find out what's happening.

My eyes snapped open and I gasped. Where…? I looked around, searching for the gray stones and tapestries but all I saw were pearlescent walls. Glittering, hanging crystals. Bright Moon. My heart was hammering in my chest, but I forced myself to take a breath and calm down. I was just being paranoid again.

Another cool breeze wafted through my room, carrying on it the sweet perfume of the flowers on my balcony. I hadn't thought to ask what they were. It seemed foolish. I knew what flowers were—they're the colorful bits on the plants. They were supposed to be poisonous, though. I wondered what you'd think of all these flowers.

I could just see you standing there, hand resting on your hip and waving at them dismissively. *Ugh, why do they have to be so colorful? It's like, we get it, you're pretty.*

Or maybe you'd like them. Sometimes I never knew what you actually liked. You hid those things so well.

My legs were drawn up where I sit on my bunk, or bed, rather. They really used strange words here in Bright Moon. The woods

outside thrummed with life. Bugs, frogs, and the occasional cry of some larger animal serenaded the quiet night. It probably had razor sharp fangs. I tried to imagine the beasts that lurked in the woods but the images were hard to grasp. My thoughts matched the buzz.

I thought briefly of Shadow Weaver. That mask, the fear in your face every time you saw her. That anticipation of pain. A wounding thought crossed through my mind. How much did she hurt you because I was gone? What terror were you experiencing right now?

It was hard to say. The memory of electricity ripping through me from the stun baton in Thaymor. That strange mixture of desperation and anger in your expression.

Because you left me. And if I don't bring you back, Shadow Weaver's gonna have my head. So, enough with your weird little identity crisis and let's go home already. Or do I need to zap you again?

A snake coiled around my heart.

What had happened?

What had I done?

A shadow lurked beyond the veil surrounding my bed. Somewhere in the recesses of my room, it slithered with a malicious intent. My hand went to my belt, but I wasn't wearing it. The sword… It was just out of reach. The only shadows that moved were—

A puff of shimmering magic and light in the middle of my room interrupted the threat. I scrambled back, nearly tipping off the side of my bed.

"Glimmer!?"

"Adora!" She jumped in surprise and poofed away in another teleport away from me. "Oh! You're awake."

My heart thundered against my ribs. "How the… what're you doing here?" One hand was pressed to my chest in case my heart burst free from the shock. The other I noticed had crept toward the sword on the bedside table. I took a breath, releasing some of the tension.

She giggled nervously and teleported back near my bed. She cleared her throat and brushed a hand through her hair, scattering a smattering of sparkles into the air. The back stuck up in a distinct horse-lick. With a quick flick, she adjusted her cape that she wore more like a jacket over her night clothes. "I just thought I'd check on you." She smiled and shrugged.

I blinked and slowly pulled myself back to the center of the bed, bending my knees and planting my bare feet on the hard mattress. "In the middle of the night?"

"Uh… sure! Just… making sure." She sat on the edge on the far end from me, as though determined to ignore my gaze. "Mystacor was kind of rough on you and I was worried, I guess."

I frowned at her in consternation. "How often have you been doing that?

She blushed and grinned awkwardly. "Not *often* but… I dunno. I just try to pop in here and make sure you're doing all right and most of the time you're sleeping or at least I think you are. And then I just pop back out. It's nothing really."

I itched the back of my neck. The thought of personal space was an adjustment since I had arrived here. It disquieted me to have space and doors. But now knowing that interruptions frequently occurred undermined that sense in a different way. There were times I snuck away with you, and we knew we were alone. But at times Shadow Weaver knew more than she should. Was it the magic that she wielded? Was that what Glimmer was…

"Wait, since Mystacor?"

She nodded solemnly. "It was really hard on you. And I felt bad that we didn't realize *how* bad it was."

I clutched the side of the bed and stared into the darkness of the room. "Thanks, Glimmer."

"No problem!" She reached over and set her hand on my bare foot concealed in the blankets between us. There was a strange warmth to her skin. A tingling like her sparkles. "Are you okay?"

I glanced at her hand and back up to her shimmering eyes. The touch and the earnestness reminded me of something. Something with you, but a formless darkness crept like a vine behind her, nearly touching her shadow. I blinked and it disappeared into the background. I withdrew my foot from beneath Glimmer's hand, glancing to where my sword lay. It had turned into a shield. Could I do that again?

"Ye—" I stopped in the middle of my lie. There wasn't really a point. She had understood so far. "No. Bad dreams. Bad thoughts."

Glimmer swiveled all the way onto the bed and crossed her legs to face me, wrapping her cape tighter around her. "Like what?"

I brought my legs up closer and gathered my arms up over my knees. "I don't know how to explain it. Sometimes... I think I'm seeing things. It feels like the Horde is trying to drag me back in. Or I wake up and I'm a prisoner here and it takes me a moment to remember I'm not." And sometimes you're here, and we're standing under a sky of twinkling stars together. I can't say that. Not to Glimmer. "And then I keep seeing the shadow creatures sneaking around. But they're not there. At least… I don't think they are."

Glimmer leaned over so she could set a hand down on top of my foot concealed under the blankets again. I fought off another attempt to slink away. Her touch was relentless, but not

altogether unwelcome. I wasn't getting out of it, so maybe I should relax. "They're not here, Adora. Not anymore."

I laid my cheek on my knees. "Thanks. I just… I feel really vulnerable."

"Is there anything that I can do to help?"

"I don't know." I heaved out a long sigh, feeling the fatigue within me. "I just wish it didn't feel so open all the time. Our barracks were fortified structures. Open windows are a security risk."

Glimmer chuckled and shook her head. "Yeah. We know."

I lifted my head. "You do?"

"Sure. The Horde aren't the only ones that think about combat tactics and battle plans. We've been fighting, too." She squeezed my foot.

The reassurance relaxed me some. I glanced dubiously at the open archway leading out onto my balcony. "Then why do you have so many holes in your defenses?"

Glimmer smirked and sat back. She leaves an inexplicable cold behind where she retracts her hand from my foot. "Well, for one, the Whispering Woods slows down any invaders and gives us time to pick them off. Two, the Moonstone has its aura that helps us sense any incoming attacks. Three, do you think we have guards everywhere just for decoration?"

"I guess that makes more sense. You do have a lot of them." I nodded and set my chin on my knee. "Though their helmets really diminish their line of sight. I've mentioned it to General Juliet but she just got mad at me even though I was only trying to help. I __"

"Adora!"

"Right. Sorry…"

Glimmer's smile held a certain affection in it as she looked at me. She pulled her cape around her again. "I know it's weird, but is there anything I can get you to help you feel better?"

Another creeping dread snuck up behind me. The shadows crawled again. Why wouldn't they just stop? My fears kept dragging me down into an abyss of darkness. Even when I was She-Ra now and shouldn't be afraid of anything, I couldn't manage to shake the feeling that there were eyes watching me. The same eyes that had been watching since I was a baby. She couldn't be here. Shadow Weaver had never managed to penetrate Bright Moon. We knew that. But…

I picked my head up from my knee and looked at Glimmer. Her eyes coruscated in the dim light. Did everything about her shimmer? "Shadow Weaver almost destroyed Mystacor, and I still don't really know how I stopped her. I don't know if I could do that again. Are you sure that she can't get into Bright Moon?"

"Yes." There was no trepidation in her voice. She always sounded so confident.

Another shadow twisted in the moonlight. "She still feels like she's here."

"What did she do to you, Adora?"

The question brought my thoughts to a grinding halt. How… What was I supposed to say? I'd never explained it to anybody. I'd always had you and you understood. But you weren't here. I'd left you with her…

"She raised me," I said lamely, knowing my answer was unsatisfactory. I dropped my eyes to the blanket, unable to meet Glimmer's earnestness.

Glimmer sat up from her cross-legged seat and shuffled on her knees towards me. I stared at her, trying to comprehend what

exactly she was doing. It was an inevitable conclusion, it seemed. She gently shifted my legs to the side and flipped the edge of my blanket open. With a quick shift of her legs she situated herself against me as I sat there rigidly still. She wrapped her arm around me, her cape draping over the both of us. “It’s okay. You can tell me. Whatever it is, you’re safe now. She can’t get to you here.”

Her warmth draped around me, reminding me of those nights in the Fright Zone with you. “It’s… hard to explain.” I curled tighter against my knees. Some instinct wanted to reject Glimmer’s closeness, but another wanted her closer. Ever since Mystacor, she’d become an anchor to help me keep the shadows of my past at bay. “She took me in when I was a baby. My earliest memories are with her and Catra in the Horde. She always told me I was special and I was destined for great things. I would be the Force Captain that would lead the Horde to victory.”

Glimmer rubbed my shoulder. “Well, she was wrong about a few things, wasn’t she?”

I shook my head. “She was right about a lot though, too. I had to be perfect. I had to prove her right. Because if I wasn’t special, if I wasn’t the *best* , then I wasn’t anything to her anymore. And I saw what happened to the people that disappointed her.” My hands tightened where they gripped my arm and leg. My ankle hurt, a phantom pain within me.

It was more than a memory though. It throbbed. Had I twisted it jumping off a crystal in Mystacor? I flexed my foot and it disappeared only for it to be replaced with another sensation. That of infernal electricity crackling over my skin. It faded away as quickly as it came, but the shadows pulsed as though they could do it again. I tried harder to calm myself.

Glimmer rubbed persistently between my shoulder blades, unfurling a knot of tension that lurked there. “What happened?”

The massaging coaxed the words out of me, as though she was unraveling a twisted web that kept everything tangled up inside.

"She… I didn't know what she was doing until I left. She would…" I closed my eyes, summoning the courage to dig into the memories. "She told me that I was strong. That I was the best. She told me that I had a home, a place, and that she understood me when no one else did. But then if I failed it wasn't me that she… Only Catra. I thought if I tried hard enough, if I worked hard enough, I could protect her from Shadow Weaver. It was the only thing I could do."

"That's horrible."

My arms relaxed around my elbows. Her touch felt calming even amid this fear. "But it did make me stronger. I just don't think it made me strong in the way she—"

"No, that's not the way it works." She spoke firmly, as strong in this conviction as she was with everything, but there was a gentleness to it too. "You don't push people by threatening them or the people around them. How can you say that it's okay?"

Her circling fingers spread out radiating heat and delicate sparkles against my skin. Unwinding me though I still held a coil of tension. I knew what she was trying to say, that she was trying to comfort me, but I couldn't bring myself to dismiss everything as easily as she was able to.

"I mean… it wasn't okay but it worked."

"You just said it didn't work out like she wanted it to. She was using mind games to manipulate you and flip things over on their head. She wanted you to be strong and perfect but in the worst way possible, Adora. That's not the way that people love each other or help each other." She reaches over to grasp my shoulder again to pull me into her warmth. "My mom's been hard on me and I've always felt like a disappointment to her, but she's never *hurt me for the things that I did or didn't do* . Who even does that? We don't live like that, and you don't have to anymore. Shadow Weaver didn't plan on you being… well… Adora and figuring out that she was messing with you."

Glimmer tugged me tighter against her. The touch sparked a confusion inside of me. She'd been so close since she brought me to Bright Moon. It was as disconcerting as it was welcoming. The distance and barriers inherent to the Horde didn't exist to Glimmer. It was disorienting how easily she could hug me like this when before we had to climb far out of sight or wait for the quiet moments at night. We had done it even though we knew the risk.. If we could be in this bed together now... would we still have to hide?

"Even if she dragged you back to the Fright Zone, you'd just break out again." Glimmer held me tightly, her strength almost assuring me she wouldn't let me go. "She doesn't control you anymore."

Her words broke me out of the rising warmth inside of me and my blood chilled at an intrusive memory. I saw you in my mind's eye, the red glow around you, the pain on your face. My own ineffectual voice, weak and useless. *Please don't hurt her.* The multitudinal pain within me. The thousand spikes of needles stabbing into me as I stared at the expressionless mask. *Adora, I'm disappointed in you.* The confusion of the memory casted me into a tumult that hammered against my calm.

I was not there. Not right now. Things were okay, right? "It wasn't just me, though." Having She-Ra made it easier. Having that power, the strength, everything was okay. I was accepted because of it. Glimmer showed me that Angella would accept me, but what about you? How could I do the same for you?

"You mean Catra?" Glimmer's tone was more careful now as she looked at me curiously.

I nodded faintly. "She's good at getting on Shadow Weaver's bad side and without me there…"

"She seemed fine in Salineas."

The ire at the sea gate, the taunting with which you assaulted me.

This is what you left me for? Dress-up games and a light show? And your new friends are nowhere to be seen. When did you get so weak?

You didn't seem afraid. Not then.

The memories rattled my crumbling composure. Glimmer was right here and I still felt like I was falling apart. "I know. I just… I don't want people to get hurt because of me." I want to hold onto her, fall into her arms. Instead, my eyes drift over to the Sword of Protection resting unassumingly beside the bed. "She-Ra is supposed to protect everyone and heal the planet. There's all these expectations but… I don't know if I can do it. Maybe there was a mistake and I wasn't supposed to have the sword."

Glimmer's hand slipped from behind me and she adjusted her cape to cover both of us better. "I know what it's like to have all these expectations on you."

I glanced sideways at her. A rare seriousness had overtaken her expression. These things usually deflected right off her. Her faith in her beliefs were unflappable. Tonight, I saw the weight she carried. When she caught me looking, she smiled.

"I hate it—that feeling your whole life has been planned out for you. It's not so easy having an immortal queen for a mother and the most powerful sorcerer of all time as your father sometimes." She shrugged and her eyes drifted away. "After my dad died, it always felt like there was this huge hole in Bright Moon, in my mother. I could feel it. Even as a kid. And now sometimes I think that's all I'm doing. Just trying to make up for him being gone." Her brow descended in determination, shedding the uncertainty in an instant. "But even if I am, that's what I *want* to do. I will fight for the freedom of Etheria with everything I've got." She looked at me and I felt the strength of her conviction. "Adora, you've already proven you're more than just what Shadow Weaver

wanted of you. You *chose* to leave the Horde and join the Rebellion."

I shook my head, wanting to believe so badly in what she was saying. But all I could think about was that day with you, stealing the skiff, falling into the Whispering Woods. It was all chance. Not a choice. The only choice I'd made was to leave you, and I was especially uncertain about that. "I don't know… If I hadn't found the sword, I don't know if I'd ever—"

"Adora, *no* . I just met you, but I know you, okay? You would have figured it out." Glimmer grabbed me by the shoulders and pulled me into a hug. There was strength in this embrace, too. "You're a good person with a good heart. She-Ra chose you for a reason. Whatever Shadow Weaver wanted you to be, you're already *so much more* than that."

My eyes stung. I unwrapped my arms from my legs and held onto Glimmer tightly. Hopefully she was right. I wanted to believe she was right. Maybe it was enough for her to believe in me.

When she pulled away, the night felt a little calmer. A little quieter.

"You're here with us now, okay?" She smiled at me, her eyes shimmering in the light of Etheria's moons. "I'm your friend, so whatever you need, just let me know."

I looked to my right where the Sword of Protection lay. It was nearby, but it still felt unfamiliar. "Could I get something to protect myself with?"

She laughed in confusion. "You already sleep with a sword beside you."

"I'm still not entirely sure how the thing works yet. And maybe someone grabs it while I am still asleep or they are too close and I can't swing it around at them." I mimed a motion of swinging my arm through the air while the series of possible scenarios flashed through my mind.

She tapped her chin in thought. “You have a point. Wait! I know just the thing!” She flashed away in a blink.

The sudden emptiness of the room left it feeling more imposing. A worry itched at the back of my neck. The shadows. My hand crept toward the sword. Maybe if I just—

Glimmer poofed back into the room in a shower of sparkles. “How’s this?” She pulled a knife from behind her back and held it out to me.

I took it from her. The purple handle and gem shaped blade were perfectly balanced around a violet gemstone in the hilt of the weapon. I swung it around, testing the motion. With a flick of my wrist, I tossed it upward into the air, watched it spin and complete two rotations before catching the point between my thumb and forefinger. I flipped it again, grabbing it by the handle once more.

“It’s perfect.” I felt a warmth wash over me as a smile crept across my lips.

“I knew it would be.” She leaned in for a hug, mindful of the weapon in my hands.

I was in someone’s arms. They set me gently down on a table. A haze of transient lucidity washed in and out like the sewage through waste pipes. I wasn’t quite sure where I was.

“Glimmer?” Lights danced in the corners of my tunneled vision. “Where are we?”

“Who’s…? Just sit still, Adora.”

It smelled strange in here. Was this what flowers smelled like? Wait, how would I know? I’ve only seen pictures of them. No, the medical rooms always smelled different, the most alien of the Fright Zone’s odors. Clean. Sterile. Only a few spots of grease and grime graced the drab green walls. I knew where I was.

I blinked the fatigue away and collected my memories. I had slipped off your back at some point and you carried me the rest of the way in your arms. My head still swam, but the surface beneath me was solid and steadying. I sat up on the edge of the examination table, pivoting to swing my bad leg up onto the metal surface. I tried to keep from wincing, but your attention was elsewhere. "Lucky there's no one around."

You rummaged through the cabinets nearby, tossing different sundries out of your way. "Yeah well, it's late."

"Why do you think Hordak has all of these rooms?" I unlaced my boot. The soot from the exhaust pipe coated my fingers in a sticky black film. I tugged at the rubber sole but a stinging shot of pain up my hip stopped me.

You looked up from the other side of a cabinet door. "Would you *stop* already? Just sit still!"

I begrudgingly sat back again, leaning on my elbows. The lights shone brighter in this room than most. It aggravated my rising headache.

"Ah-ha!" You scampered backwards with your treasure, a gray winding of medical gauze.

I watched you from my reclined position. You picked up my foot by the heel and loosened my laces some more. You gave it a quick tug. I sucked in a tight breath through my teeth.

"You whine too much and I'm going to cut it off." You tugged harder and the boot slipped free. You then snatched my sock cleanly off my foot. The clean skin of my foot contrasted sharply with the dreary colors of the room. The ankle was swollen nearly to the size of my calf. It was already starting to purple with bruising.

"That looks bad." You grimaced.

"I'll be fine, Catra. I've bounced back from worse." The pain was the only thing keeping me awake right now.

You stared back at me, eyes pleading. I saw fear. Over a simple sprain? Why… That wasn't what you were worried about, was it?

She'll hurt you. Won't she?

"Get some tape instead."

"What about—"

"Gauze is too stretchy." I tested my ankle. It throbbed as more blood filled the joint. Too far in any direction and it shot a spike of pain up my leg. "I need something to hold it tighter."

You nodded and hurried back to the cabinets, tossing more supplies onto the floor behind you.

"Found it!" You unfurled the tape with the tell-tale rip of the adhesive and started to wrap my ankle. I sucked in another breath.

You stopped this time, looking at me.

"Keep going. If it's tight enough, I should be able to walk on it. I might be a little slow but no one should notice."

Your scrambling agitation calmed and your movements became more methodical. Biceps stretched and flexed under the fur of your arms. You were so cute when you were focused. The little furrow to your brow. The determined frown of your expression. Another grin briefly graced my lips before I bit it back again.

You finished with a swipe of your claw over the end of the tape. Your tail swayed behind you, ears flattened as you looked up at me.

You never said it, but I could tell when you were sorry.

"Let me try it."

You scooted away from me and I pushed off the table. When I landed, I grunted in pain and nearly crumpled. You were fast. You braced under my shoulder, hands on my chest and back.

"Maybe you should just… give it a minute, Adora."

"I guess." You settled me back down on the medical table and sat. You felt so far away. Like we couldn't—That doesn't have to be the way it happened. We don't have to keep hiding. I shifted and sidled up against you, the sides of our bodies touching. I was scared you'd shift away again.

You didn't move away.

No, you… you leaned over, head resting on my shoulder, your long hair brushing against my cheek. Suddenly, it was very hard to breathe. I tentatively reached out. I reached around you, and set my hand on your hip. Every instinct in me said that you'd reject the closeness. You'd been confused and upset ever since the furnace and usually that kept you away. But you didn't pull away. Your tail flicked upward and draped over my arm.

My thoughts were a buzz that matched the sound of the bright lamps overhead.

Still, one thought shone through. The gentle caress of your tail on my arm gave me the courage to say it. "I liked today."

I heard an amused sigh. "You dummy, you almost died."

"Well… maybe just except that part." I wanted to pull you tighter. I hesitated.

You rubbed your face a little firmer on my shoulder, almost as though you could hear the things I didn't say. "I guess it was fun."

I hesitated but pushed through, emboldened by our contact. I grasped your shoulder. "Can we… could we do it again?"

A pause. It stretched into the emptiness in the room. So quiet we could hear a pin drop. I started to ache from the silence. Did I say the wrong thing?

You sat up a little. Turned to face me. Our faces hung close together. Precariously close. Your eyes were wide, soft. Maybe vulnerable? My attention dropped to the worried line of your lips and stomach twisted into a tight knot. Why did I want to lean in closer?

Your frown shifted into a mischievous grin. “I guess. If you promise to not try to get yourself killed next time.”

The tension in my gut dissipated instantly, at once relieving but also… disappointing somehow. I meet your grin with a smirk of my own. “Oh, c’mon that wasn’t my fault! I don’t even know what that grease slick was doing there.”

“Kyle probably missed it while he was on mop duty.” You pushed off the table with a soft pad of your feet bouncing in the empty room. I wished you’d stayed next to me. Just a little longer.

“He’s always on mop duty. How can he miss anything?”

You shrugged and picked up my sock.

“I don’t think my boot is going to fit with the tape and the sock.”

You grimaced in disdain. “Oh, your feet are going to be *foul* .”

I glared. “It won’t be as bad as that time you left that dead mouse in my boot.”

You answered me with a scowl, hand on hip. “Are you ever going to let that go?”

“Definitely not.”

"Whatever. I guess I'll kick Kyle out of his bed. He can sleep over you for a few nights." You grabbed my boot instead and threaded my foot into it. Delicately. Almost as if you cared.

"I don't think Rogelio would appreciate that." You started to lace up my boots but I swatted your hands away. "I can do *something* still."

"Fine." You held your hands palm out and backed away.

I pushed off the bed. I winced, but the tightness of the boot and tape held my ankle firm. You almost darted towards me again, but stopped yourself. I caught your worried glance and gave you a reassuring smile. Whether it worked or not was difficult to tell. I twisted and flexed my foot. The pain was more bearable now.

"I'm going to be slow. But I don't think anyone will notice."

You anxiously bit your lip, and nodded. "Adora…" I met your eyes again. They were soft. Softer than I remembered. "Th—Thank you."

"It's fine. I won't let her find out."

Chapter End Notes

Hey guys, we have no self-control and accidentally added a chapter. Oops.

We're sure you won't mind.

Bravery

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I waited. Painfully long at the doorway. I paced. Darla's status that epidermal sealant was needed echoed in the buzz of my head. I remembered those claw marks on the back of your neck. Was it worse this time? I wrung my hands around the tube of sealant. It felt hot from my constant worrying. I wasn't certain if I could pop it, but I sure was testing it.

I bit my cheek. What were you talking about in there with Entrapta?

Entrapta's voice crackled in the speaker over the entryway. "Adora, you can come in now." Of course she knew I was waiting.

I slammed the button with my palm and the door snapped open. You sat with your back against the wall of the dim red engine room. Entrapta had already lifted into the air and was moving away from you.

"Wait!" You reached out for her. An outstretched hand. A pang cut through me. Why did you want to talk with Entrapta and not me? Then I saw the glistening red lines cutting down your arms.

"Catra, what happened?" My feet carried me faster than I knew they could. I didn't wait to stop moving before I landed on my knees. The hard deckplate sent a shock through my legs, but I didn't notice. The cuts didn't look too deep, but they wouldn't heal without a scar if I didn't act fast. I moved the tube of sealant towards your arm.

"It's fine." You pulled away with a jerk.

A clattering overhead signaled Entrapta's departure through the vent above.

"It doesn't look fine!" I wanted to reach out to you, grab your arm and pull you over. You shouldn't hurt like this.

"Adora! Wait. Just stop for a minute. I need to…." You stared at me with your dichromatic eyes, the skies of Bright Moon and the Fright Zone. Tears pooled in the corners. Something you were carrying in your heart was about to let go. "I need to tell you something."

I twisted the tube of sealant again. The wounds drew my eyes and I had to fight the urge to touch them, to fix them. But those were also words I have wanted to hear for months now, maybe years. "Okay."

"Everything… everything is falling apart." Your voice cracked. "And I… It feels like…" You choked.

I sat back, crossing my legs under me. I put the sealant on my ankles and rested my hands on my knees. I was close, but not too close.

You grappled with the words, struggling for a way to say something that had festered since I'd gotten you back. "It…" A distressed suck of air through threatening sobs punctuated the word. "It feels like my fault."

It wasn't. Why would it ever be? Don't say that. "It's okay, Catra. I'm here."

You turned away. One leg propped up, elbow on knee, the other outstretched in front of you, hand on your thigh. You looked ahead. "I thought I was… When I was…" You furrowed your brow. The wrinkles looked like cracks forming on glass ready to fall apart. You shutter a breath to collect yourself. "Melog has been feeling tired. But too tired. They weren't following me. They couldn't stand up straight. I didn't know what was wrong. So I took them to the medical room. I was carrying them." Your lip quivered and you struggled to maintain some kind of composure. "I thought maybe… maybe Entrapta could help them too. They

could have the same sickness as Angella. I walked past her. She… she said 'thank you'." Your hands flexed again over your arms and I resisted reaching out for you.

"You brought her back. Of course she did."

You leaned your head back to stare at the nest of pipes and cables above. The heart of Darla thrummed around us. "Lot of good that did."

I wanted to grab you and shake you from these horrid thoughts. I clamped my hands down on my knees and instead said, "Catra, talk to me."

"You get to save the world, the galaxy. I try to do one thing and it falls apart in my hands. I can't control it. I can't do anything about it." Your voice was flat, monotoned. You stared past the metal walls of Darla. "It's like Prime's chip is still on the back of my neck and I just have to watch."

My heart stopped. I remembered that moment. So close to reaching your hand before it was torn away. I remembered the fall. "That's not true! You've done so much."

Your sardonic laugh cut through me. "You don't get it. Do you?"

"I'm trying to, Catra. I want to help." My thoughts slipped away from me like I was sliding down a scree slope.

"You don't know what it was like without you. When you left, I just had to survive. I had to make it out okay. Shadow Weaver, Hordak, I spent my life watching them. I was faster, smarter, I could resist them. I stayed one step ahead of them. And they couldn't stop me. I 'ran the show' like I said I would back in Thaymor. But I…" You stared ahead at a past long gone. "I didn't know what I was doing sometimes. It's like everything was moving and I was just watching myself do horrible things. If I ever—if I ever stopped to think about what I was doing, it would

all fall apart. I had to keep doing what I was and—and people died because of it."

I reached out a hand, but you recoiled away.

You turned to me, tears beading at the edges of your eyes. "Don't. Just listen."

I nod. I slip further down the slope, watching you pull away from me.

"It's quiet now. On this ship." You take a deep breath. "With you. I've never known quiet like this. And I never knew how much I was running from. It's all catching up with me. I can hear them at night, Adora. The screams. I see the fear. And I know…" A tear fell, finally wetting the fur on your cheek. "I know they were afraid of me."

A cold horror washed through me. My throat is dry and I swallow, struggling to find something to say. Anything to stop this.

"But… you're making it better. I don't know what you saw, or what you felt, but you're making it better by apologizing and helping."

Now that the first tear broke free, the rest wouldn't stop. "A lot of fucking of good that's doing."

"It *is,* Catra." I squeezed my legs, another attempt to respect your space. "Remember when we got back to Etheria? It was hard, right? Facing everyone?"

You hesitate, your eyes slowly drawing toward me. Focusing on me again. The small smirk breathes some warmth back into me. "I remember a punch in the face from Frosta."

"Okay, what about *after* that?" I reached forward again, towards your face.

This time you didn't pull away. "I guess."

I caressed a finger across your cheek, pulling one of the escaped tears away. "You guess?" I smirked back at her and felt my eyes welling. "Catra, it's not the same as what you're going through, but I had to face what I did. A lot of people lost someone to the Horde, and I was a part of that. I was guilty, too. But in time… they forgave me."

You nodded and looked down.

"Can I…" I held up the epidermal sealant again.

"Y—Yeah."

"Thank you." I shifted over and held the tube of sealant against your arm. The stream of clear liquid flowed out and staunched the bleeding as it touched your arm. This was one scar that I wouldn't let take hold of you.

Your eyes fixated ahead, unfocused. Lost in your thoughts.

Maybe I could still help. "I couldn't fix everything, either." I moved to the other side of you.

You huffed a short laugh. "So?"

"Angella was one of those things."

You turned to me. Your eyes gazed into mine. Confusion, fear, and anger lapsed over your face.

"Angella could die, Catra. But that will never change what it meant to all of us that you brought her back. I've had to accept that sometimes… sometimes making up for something isn't about fixing it. It's about trying." I finished up with the last of the sealant and discarded the bottle to the side.

You looked down again, away from me. I didn't know if those words meant anything to you. I didn't know if I made a crack in the despair in your heart. But I hoped it did.

"I just…" I reached up again, and I cupped my finger and thumb under your chin, pulling you up to face me once more. "I just want you to know one thing."

"What?" A softness returned to your eyes. Something fell in your hardened shell.

"I forgive you. For everything you ever want to apologize for, I will *always* forgive you."

"Adora…" You collapsed onto me. Arms clutched me tight, and we melded as one in that room. You sobbed on my shoulder. And I gave you every last word of forgiveness I could muster that day. It was the only thing I could do to heal the scars that you carried.

The door opened with a hiss, jolting me viscerally out of my head. We were surrounded by a dim green glow. That didn't seem right. Wasn't it supposed to be blue? With the… the crystal things on the walls… No, that wasn't right. This was more familiar. The green lights above each bunk in the barracks. The faint rumbling of the pipes in the walls and ceilings. We were almost back.

You were still in my arms. No, wait. I was in yours. You supported me as I limped each painful step back. Just a few more until I was at my bunk. My strength had left me a long time ago, but yours was immeasurable.

My boot caught on the lip of the threshold. A white-hot stab of pain shot up to my hip and a faint whimper escaped me before I could tamp down on it. I stumbled, the fatigue deep-set into my bones by now. You steadied me, your arm tight around my back, your hand clenching around my wrist where it hung over your shoulder. The force of your determination alone kept me standing.

"Shhh," you hissed.

"Sorry, sorry," I said under my breath. Were you angry with me? The faint glow of your eyes in the dark were hard to read. You

were scowling, but as you met my eye, something in them softened.

"Almost there," you whispered. "One step at a time. Okay? That's it."

Our bunk just had to be at the end of the barracks. I staggered forward arduously, swinging my bad leg outward to keep from bending my ankle, leaning all my weight against you before taking that next step. Perhaps the first blessing of the night was Kyle's thunderous snores. He lay sprawled on his bed, mouth hanging open. Rogelio had curled up in a tight ball beneath him, tucking his head in to drown out the noise. Lonnie was sleeping with her pillow over her head. No one would notice the uneven scuffling of our footsteps against the metal plating. Everyone was fast asleep and unaware of our discretion.

As the night dragged on into early dawn, the fatigue had eaten away my composure. What had I been thinking? I never wanted a night like this again. Everything hurt, and we were going to be on pins and needles for the next few weeks until my ankle healed. We should have just gone straight back from the overlook. But because I'd had stupid idea to race to the forge, for tomorrow's training you'll be tired and I…

I smothered the thought before I could finish it. It would be okay. It had to be.

We reached my bunk. You held onto my hands as I lowered down onto it. I grimaced as I stretched out my leg, ripping the blanket out of the way before it could tangle my boot. I stripped off the fresh jacket you'd nabbed from the locker room. It was surprisingly sturdy and I liked the collar. I was tempted to ask you where you had found it but thought better of it tonight. I rolled it into a ball to stuff under my ankle. Elevating it and a good night's rest. That was all I needed. I leaned back on my arms and released the breath I'd been holding against the pain.

You knelt and started to untie my laces but I brushed your hands away.

"Leave it. I don't want to have to put it back on in the morning."

Your nose wrinkled. "Your foot really is going to reek."

I gave a resigned sigh. "It's better than risking someone seeing it."

"All right." You sat back on your heels, grasping your arm against your side. Your tail swayed behind you in indecision. There was something you wanted to say, I could see it, but it couldn't breach the silence. All you did say was, "Hold on," before climbing up onto your bunk.

I wanted to call you back, but you moved so swiftly and I couldn't wake anyone. But barely a breath had passed before you landed back by my bunk on silent feet. You held your pillow, and without a word, replaced the rolled up jacket w ith it.

I stared at my dirty boot on your pillow before lifting my eyes to you. "Catra… are you sure—"

You didn't meet my questioning stare, but glared off to the side and grumbled, "Whatever. I'll just steal another."

" *Wow.* "

You glanced at me askance.

"If I didn't know any better," I couldn't help the smug grin, "I'd think you like me."

Your ears flattened against your head and you snarled under your breath, "I do *not* ."

I shake with suppressed laughter, the motion jostling my ankle and sending stiff rails of pain up my leg. It was worth it. That look

on your face. The complete indignation. It was beautiful. You were—

You shoved hard against my shoulders, knocking me back into the firm mattress. I choked between another chuckle and a yelp of pain.

"Next time I won't save your ass."

You started to climb away, back up to your bunk, but I hastily grabbed your hand.

"Wait!"

We both froze. You glanced down at where my hand encircled your wrist before meeting my eyes. My mind had gone blank. I couldn't quite believe I'd stopped you but now that we were here, now that I could see your eyes so close, glowing slightly in the dimness, I just didn't want you to leave. Not yet.

"You don't… we can..." I swallowed. My throat had become inexplicably dry. "We can share my pillow, since you're letting me borrow yours."

You scowl off to the side. It was hard to tell by the lighting, but I thought I could see the slightest blush encroach on your cheeks. I didn't feel you pulling away so I let go of your wrist and scooched over.

"This is *not* because I like you," you said, but when there was just enough space, you sidled in next to me.

It was slow and painful, but I managed to shift onto my side, my foot still propped up on your pillow. You lay facing me, but your eyes were downcast. The Horde-issued pillows weren't large by any standard—our faces were so close. The air was stagnant between us with the smell of soap from hastily scrubbing the soot and grime off in the locker room.

A knot of worry furrowed your brow as you stared at my foot. I recognized that expression. I knew what you were thinking.

"Hey." I nudged you slightly to get your attention. A quick jolsting of your arm, but then I left my hand there. Your fur was soft, but beneath were the firm muscles that had carried us here.

Your eyes lifted to mine slowly. However tired I was, I couldn't imagine how exhausted you were after carrying me so far. Behind the fatigue, lurked a tightness to your gaze, a burgeoning of anxiety behind those walls you'd built so carefully. But I knew. I could see it.

"Thanks." It felt weak saying it, but it was the only thing I could think of. "For helping me. I don't know what I would have—"

"Adora, it's fine." The smile that skimmed your lips was faint, almost undetectable in the lighting. "You would've done the same for me." You reached out a hand, brushing stray strands of hair from my face, careful not to graze the tender parts.

"I know. It's just…"

I bit the inside of my cheek. I didn't know what to say. I wished I did. How could I describe the terror I'd felt tonight? How the only reason everything was okay was because you were there? Because you were strong and I could trust you and sometimes you were the only thing that kept me going. I wanted to say everything. Something. But between the tightness of my chest and the throbbing in my foot, I couldn't seem to form the words.

"Thank you," I mumbled meekly, hoping that the tightness of my grip on your arm conveyed it better. It wasn't enough to express my gratitude. I knew it wasn't. But it would have to do for now. It was all I could manage.

"I'm just glad you're…" Your voice drifted off, your expression unreadable. Your tail flicked behind you, an ear twitched backward. Then you smirked, that left fang protruding from beneath your lip. "I'm just glad you have that thick skull."

I laughed faintly, knowing I should be annoyed, but somehow I wasn't. "Me too."

Your smile broadened. "You're such an idiot," you said as you tucked in closer. "Now get some sleep. We'll need it for tomorrow."

You curled your knees up, tucking them up into the hollow by my waist. Our legs aligned, but you were careful to keep clear of my ankle. I let my arm slip over you, fingers barely skimming your back. The other I tucked up under my head for support. You kept your hands loose between us. You closed your eyes and let out a long breath. The tension eased from you in an instant and, within a few minutes, your breathing deepened and I knew you were asleep, the exhaustion finally having caught up to you. But I couldn't seem to follow your lead. We'd lain like this a hundred times as kids, but something about tonight… maybe the fall really had done something to my head. I could barely breathe around the fluttering of my chest. It was like your warmth had zapped me with electricity and suddenly I didn't feel so tired anymore.

Your hair was still a little damp and I knew in the morning it would be extra unruly. I never understood how you wore your hair down like that. Mine always drove me crazy and got in the way, so I just wore it up. But you never seemed to mind. It seemed just as part of you as the stripes on your arm or the soft way you laughed.

A sudden urge hit me. I wanted to run my hand through your hair, see if I could smooth it down. I'd never before. Your hair was always something you wanted me to leave alone but now... I could almost see it, you with your hair smoothed back, a confident smile on your face. One that said you could take over the world and you knew it. Destruction would follow in your wake and—

The thought screeched to a sudden halt. Where had that come from? I'd never… you'd never looked like that. I retracted my arm from over you in trepidation. My heart thundered in my chest, though I couldn't understand why. Was I afraid? Of you? That didn't seem right.

I squeezed my eyes shut hard. They were just playing tricks on me. Something knocked loose in my head by that fall. It was still you next to me. The same you I'd known since forever.

But when I opened my eyes again and my vision cleared, you were staring back. Your eyes glowed a sickly, neon green. Behind you was sterile, white plating surrounded by a black abyss. Panic roared through me and I lurched forward, grabbing you by the arms. I had to catch you. Before you could fall and I would jump after you and find you lying there barely breathing—

"Adora!" Your surprised hiss jolted me back into myself.

I blinked. Your eyes weren't glowing, not that green color anyway. They were their normal blue and yellow, and slightly irritated. Relief flooded through me, a powerful tidal wave that washed everything away. All the worry. All the pain. Leaving just the elation that we were here, safe together.

"You and your sleep fighting." Your eyes were barely open, a sleepy smile on your face.

My hand still held tight to your shoulder. We were always like this. So much time spent together, but things felt different now. It wasn't as easy. We were close, but there was something between us, still in the way. And everything within me wanted to dismantle that distance, that final barrier. I didn't want it anymore, and I hoped you didn't either.

"Just relax and sleep, will you?" you said. "Save it for training. Tomorrow will be—"

I yanked you closer on a sudden impulse. I didn't know exactly where it had come from, why the knot in my chest seemed to be the end of a tether tugging me to you.

Our faces connected, cutting you off mid-sentence. I'd miscalculated though. The angle was off and my nose delivered a glancing blow off yours on my collision-course with your lips. I

caught my bottom lip on your fang before my momentum carried me forward. Then the dull impact of our teeth.

You stiffened. A moment passed. Or maybe no time at all. I couldn't tell. My heart had stopped. My brain had melted. Around the sting of pain from the clash, your lips were soft and warm, and this close I could still smell the undercut of soot beneath the soap and beneath that was you. It reminded me of all those quiet moments, just the two of us, and I wanted to steal an eternity of them. Then your firm hand pushing me away, your face jerking back from mine.

Cold anguish filled my chest. What had I just done?

"Watch it!" You touched your fingers to your lips, examining them as though expecting to have split a lip.

"I'm sorry—I don't—I…" I covered my own mouth in shock, feeling the bump where I'd hit your fang. Had I really just...

When you lifted your eyes to mine, I could see the accusation in them, the confusion and anger. "What was *that?* " you demanded.

I had to fix this. I couldn't... not without you. "I just had this… I think it was a dream. And you fell and I had to jump after you but when I got to you, you were… You were hurt. And then when I realized you were okay—that *we* were okay, I just… I don't know."

You glared at me, your hand slowly lowering from your mouth. It rested on the mattress between us, fingers unfurled loosely. "You're the one that fell today, idiot."

My eyes linger on your hand. You hadn't moved away. Maybe I hadn't messed this up completely. "I know," I said. "I don't know what I was thinking."

"Obviously." A small, hesitant smirk. Then you lifted that hand and prodded me on the center of my forehead. "Maybe we should be more worried about your broken head than your ankle."

Maybe my head was broken because, even though my lips were throbbing and the embarrassment was still a hot coil at the back of my neck, I thought it wasn't the worst thing. Being that close to you. Touching you that way. I wondered why it felt so familiar, so natural, though we never had before.

Your hand settled back between us, claws picking at the fabric of the sheets. One snagged on a thread, chipped from shearing through the pipe in the forge. The faint *plock* of your claw coming free was almost deafening in the silence.

"Did you—" I bit down on the question before it could fully escape.

Your eyes flicked up to me and I could tell you knew exactly what I was about to say regardless. My face was burning hot, waiting for your answer. Maybe it was another trick of the light, but I thought I saw the blush on your cheeks as your eyes drifted away, unable to meet my gaze. A slight furrow to your brow indicated your annoyance.

"Did I what? Like you headbutting me?" You growled the words and they sank into my heart. "Gee, Adora. What do you think?"

This was when you left. You pushed off me in frustration and crawled back into your bunk. That's how it happened because I never said the things I should have. I didn't hold on tight enough. I let go.

"I think we should try again."

Whose voice was that? Mine? An unknown source of confidence bled into me, emboldening me. The tightness of my chest loosened. You were going to leave, but this time I could stop you.

You looked at me, wide-eyed, almost alarmed. But you didn't pull away. I watched your gaze drop toward my mouth before you scowled and forced yourself to meet my eyes again. "You want to try to knock my teeth out again?"

I shook my head slowly. “Not like that. I messed up. It’ll be different.” There was no more panic in my heart. Everything had settled within me. I shuffled closer, grasping your arm. Gently this time.

Your breath hitched slightly as I touched you and you swallowed. Your eyes remained determinedly on mine. “What makes you think it’ll be different?”

I wasn’t sure how, but it was just something I knew. As though we’d kissed a hundred times before and I already knew the topography of your lips. As though I’d stared into your dichromatic eyes for lifetimes. As though every night we lay like this and kissed before going to sleep in each other’s arms.

The barracks around us faded, the greenish hue slipping into an ethereal blue. A night sky I hadn’t known, alight with multitudes of stars. The glow of your eyes brightened as I bent my head toward yours. You didn’t pull away, only held your breath as I pressed our foreheads together.

“Do you trust me?” I whispered.

You answered with the faintest of nods.

I caressed my hand up your arm, feeling the softness of your fur, the slight tension of your shoulder. It faded as my fingers slipped around to the back of your neck, my thumb rubbing against the line of your jaw. I tilted my head forward. I knew exactly the right angle. It had been weighed and measured a thousand times in my head. When our lips touched this time, it was a conduit arcing across dimensions. The faintest of brushes before sinking in. The dance tenuous at first but it was like finding our rhythm while sparring. You knew everything about me just as I knew everything about you.

I was filled with light and warmth. It sapped the pain away from my limbs. The worry from my heart. It was a connection that

seemed to transcend everything around us. Through time and space. All that mattered was that we were here. Safe. Together.

You broke away, leaning your forehead into mine again. The breath you released cascaded over my face, a wash of cold and warmth and you. I didn't open my eyes. Just felt you there with me. I didn't know when we fell asleep, just that you were in my arms the entire time. Maybe if we had just stayed that way, everything would have been okay.

I woke from my cot. Our cot? Or was it our bunk? Where were all of the sleeping cadets? No, wait... where was Melog? Had you left to go see Entrapta? I thought things were okay. Wait, where was I? I looked around the room. I remembered holding you in my arms. But was that a dream?

The kiss with you lingered on my lips. Had that happened? Was that what I remembered, or was that something else? Something felt different. A fork in a river and I drifted down a different path. But I wasn't in the bunk. You weren't in my arms. I didn't know where I was.

The door slams open and Melog startles up to look at the new interloper. Entrapta steps assuredly into the room with her face buried in the datapad. She taps naked fingers on the screen. In fact, her whole arms were uncovered. The grease spot is gone. She wears a clean white tank top and her overalls.

Without looking up from her datapad, she reaches out a hand of hair to pat Melog absently but lovingly. She confidently steps into the room and looks up at me with a quixotic excitement. "I think I figured something out! Well maybe, but it's a lead!"

Melog looks from her, back to me, glowing blue eyes reflect my confusion. Why is she here right now? Why…

Oh. A rush of disorganized memories assault me, trying to break through whatever calm is in this moment. My breath hitches

and a cold panic rattles up my spine. Melog knows. They always know. They affectionately rub their shoulder against mine and without thinking I wrap an arm around them.

I take a deep breath. In for five seconds. Hold for five. Breathe out for five. Hold for five. The mess of thoughts slot into some logical yet illogical structure. Entrapta knows what's happening. Or at least more than anyone else does.

"Did you figure out what's going on with my time distortion?"

She shakes her head. She picks up the datapad in her pigtails so she can type on it with both hands. "I don't know exactly, but I've been tracking the time jumps in present and future realities. I figured out how to make a connection through it to past and future time states! It was *super* clever of me to figure out how to channel the hypothetical space-time continuum maps back to my past self. It's helped me develop a topology of holographic reality so we can—"

"Entrapta…"

She fumbles the datapad and recovers looking back at me. "Sorry! Anyway the time disorganization seems to be tracing through memories of emotional states that you have experienced as your conscious mind tries to sort out reality. I think it was the best way for my future self to help resolve whatever is about to happen on Eternia. The memories are a mixture of positive and negative influences but they're not *quite* able to sort out since the brain is intentionally linear in chronological interpretation. It *seems* as though you're creating some time paradoxes to reconcile the emotional conflations that you're feeling."

"Time paradoxes?" Anxiety bubbles in my chest. "That doesn't sound good."

"Actually it appears to be working in your favor in resolving the strains in the time distortion that you're experiencing. I *didn't* predict that you'd be able to alter chronological bifurcations

without disrupting the delicate fabric of subatomic vacuum states and creating a singularity that would consume all dimensions of matter. They're tiny changes. Nothing too dramatic yet."

Tiny changes? I raise a hand to my mouth, touching my lips with the tips of my fingers. Had I really just changed the past to…?

"I need additional data. How did you figure out that you could alter temporal reality?"

I drop my hand, self-conscious of the motion. "I didn't. I was just…"

"Oh a *wild* hypothesis." Entrapta continues to type furiously on her datapad. "Those are some of my *favorites* . You might not've if you had known the risk to all of the known universe but that makes it better!"

I stare at her, but she's too caught up in her calculations to notice.

"What did you change? It had to be something *big* ." Her tone is almost casual, as though we're gossipping and not discussing changes to reality.

"I didn't really…"

"Nonsense! I detected a chronological alteration." She spins her datapad around and points to a sharp spike in a graph. "I just haven't been able to discern what the outcome was. Tell me everything—the data needs to be precise."

I hold my breath. She's right. I might not have risked all reality for what I did if I had known.

No... that's a lie.

"I kissed Catra."

A silence lingers in the room. Melog shares the quiet, unmoving on the bed with me. Entrapta's scarlet eyes study me for a moment, taking me in. I feel a heat crawl up my neck. Then her eyes brighten and her focus dives back into her science.

" *Fascinating!* " She types furiously on her datapad. "Did it feel different? Did you notice a shift in the subspace time continuum as a reflexive feedback of bending the laws of physics?"

"Oh, I felt that all right."

"This is incredible scientific data! I need to know more, but unfortunately the stability of further subspace experiences—" She pauses and scratches her chin with her pigtail, "— *and* the safety of our friends, has a higher urgency." She continues her number crunching with total disregard for if I was still following. "To tie up the chronological disorder, there needs to be additional supervision and guidance in order to finally sort out the future and present to provide stability for you to realign around and I think the thaumetic-matter fields may hold the key if they can be focused into a singular resolution of the chronological flux you're experiencing!"

I rub my forehead and sigh in frustration. She means well. She always means well. "So what can we do? I can't exactly tell my brain what to think."

Enthusiasm lights her face. "That's not true. I found someone that can help you."

Angella's calming countenance leaps into my mind's eye. But if it was her, then why hadn't my thoughts or memories taken me back to her? "Who is it?"

"I can't explain it. But she's waiting to meet you." Entrapta readies to punch a button on her datapad.

"Wait!"

Her finger hovers. "What?"

“If I changed reality and Catra and I…” I slowly retract my hand, outstretched in my effort to stop her. I can’t meet her earnest, curious stare. “If I fixed that day, why didn’t that change anything? Why did we still...”

“Well the outcome of the experiment is obvious.” She shrugs.

I clench my hands tight on my elbows, aware of phantoms of pain from battles long ago. “Not to me.”

“The conclusion of your separation from one another was inevitable. The experiences and emotions have too much momentum to be changed by a single action.”

“Oh…”

“But Adora.” One of her pigtails snakes over and caresses over my knee.

I look up at her.

She smiles with a radiance that could light up an Etherian night. “You were always going to find each other again.”

Before I can respond she punches the button. Reality crumbles around me. She, Melog, and Darla fade from existence and I am left in darkness.

Chapter End Notes

In honor of Pride Month and Adora, I wanted to share something quick.

Growing up, it was easy for me to compartmentalize. It started out of necessity as someone with chronic migraines to displace stressors before they could lay me out for days to weeks at a time. But it quickly turned into an easy way for me to take anything that scared or confused me, put it in a box, and shove it away to never look at again. Those wayward feelings I had around my friends that they didn’t

seem to share? Straight into the box. It was easier to lie and say I didn't like to be touched or hugged than for me to admit that I experienced it differently. Because I didn't want to be different. I was afraid to be. So I made this box and when I got that first crush on a boy, it was with relief that I shoved that box away into a dark corner, unlabeled and unexplored.

But it didn't make things go away. It was just stripping away parts of myself, hiding them and then lying to myself that they didn't exist. Denying it didn't remove my need for connection. It only made it more difficult to find.

As time went on, and I failed to connect with anyone, I tentatively took that box out from that dark corner, dusted it off, and opened it. Just a crack. I tried on those parts of myself that I'd ignored for so long. They didn't fit quite right. I hadn't let them grow with me. But I tried and slowly they began to fit back in and I let myself explore that side of myself despite my fear and confusion. Even so, something was still missing. Each relationship was like paddling a boat upriver when it's supposed to be something easy. They were fine, but I couldn't settle for fine. And so in disappointment that it hadn't worked, I repacked my box and put it back. It seemed that maybe I just wasn't built right, that I wasn't going to find that connection you always hear about. That I didn't deserve love.

Well, we know how Mara feels about that.

When I first started dating my partner, it finally all clicked together. I got those wiggle-squiggles everyone talks about, all the stupid cliches. I wasn't broken. It was a relief to find this sort of happiness that had, up until that point, seemed like a rarity where the discourse treated it as an abundance.

Then the pandemic hit and, as I'm sure many of you can relate, parts of my life fell apart. I was in a dark place when I decided to watch a cute sparkle princess show. Boy-howdy I was NOT expecting to be taken on such an emotional

rollercoaster the likes of which I haven't experienced in a long time. I was immediately obsessed. It was within watching Adora struggle herself with finding and accepting love that I really saw myself. Her tenacity and bravery around her confusion and fear. And the openness and kindness with which the show treats relationships was comforting.

She-Ra is about bravery and love and finding bravery in love. And so I did that. I found bravery in my love to begin unpacking that box and reclaiming all those pieces of myself I'd left behind for so long. This past year, I came out to my friends and family as bisexual.

I am still working on understanding everything I've ignored and denied about myself. And as a writer, I definitely process things better by writing them out. .These fanfics have been an amazing avenue to explore and evaluate myself. My co-author Dakian can hit me up with "Yoh, I need some gay panic in here" and I'm like "I got you fam," or "Hey, write a Catradora Cadets kiss" and I'm like *cracks knuckles and starts furiously typing*. Because now I am better able to recognize that those things that made me uncomfortable and fearful weren't abnormal experiences. They were okay and I was allowed to feel them and it's been liberating to release the shame I'd carried for so long about it.

I recognize that I am extremely fortunate to have supportive family and friends to work through all these things with, and not everyone has that. I hope that if you are reading this and you find yourself sharing my experience, you also find some comfort in knowing you're not alone.

It's definitely hard keeping your heart open, but I promise it is worth it.

You deserve love too.

Happy Pride Month!



Truth

Adora.

I recognize who that is. I open my eyes. I stand in the barren chamber of the throne room. Only now instead of the desolate tomb from before, it is full of light. Violet flames from lit torches dance in the still air. A rug the color of a rich wine with gilded fringe stretches to a throne now restored. A chandelier hangs above with skulls in place of where the candlesticks would be. They cast more violet-hued light into the room through their empty eyesockets.

She sits on the throne with one leg crossed over the other, hands on the armrests. Blue light laces through the stone behind her in the stylized circuits of the First Ones.

"Mara?"

"Hello, Adora." The unmistakable humanity of her smile adds an ethereal presence to her. There's something in the expression that breaks into me and I almost collapse on the spot. A dark chestnut ponytail drapes over her right shoulder. Her blue eyes show a kindness unlike any that I've known, except for maybe Queen Angella.

How'd Entrapta send me *here* ?

"I don't—What's going on?"

"I'm not really sure where to start at the moment." She sighs with a regret that instills doubt inside of my brief glimmering hope.

"Then can we start simple? Where am I right now?"

She smiles sweetly, disarmingly. I don't remember if I ever saw her happy. "You're in Castle Grayskull."

My wonderment clashes with an urgency of boiling latent frustrations. Who knows what She-Ra is doing right now? What destruction she is causing? What harm? "I need you to be a little less vague."

"I think you need to ask more specific questions then." She stops just an arm's length away from me. Even as Mara and not She-Ra, she is still a little taller than me.

I rub at a spot above my brow. "Okay, so you're not actually Mara. You're some kind of artificial intelligence then, like the First Ones had on Etheria?"

"Not exactly." She shrugs and looks down at herself. "I'm not really sure what I am, but I'm here. Things are a little confusing."

" *Confusing* ?" I choke down a laugh. "That's an understatement." I turn to take in my surroundings, hands on my hips. It's only the throne room. The rest of the world is silent. The hall is a stark contrast of the gothic macabre and egotistical art. Portraits of a bunch of impressively buff men in neon-colored tights adorned the walls. Almost as a counterpoint, iron crosses are embedded into the walls around the perimeter of the room.

I take a breath to gather myself. It's not her fault. "Sorry, how did you get here?"

"It feels like I just woke up here. I saw your friend, Entrapta I think, and she said she was bringing someone to meet me. But before that? It feels like a haze clouded by something that I don't think I want to remember." I spare a glance at Mara and a deep pain weighs heavy on her. "I've been trying to figure out what is going on since then. I'm connected to Grayskull somehow now."

I study her face. Fine lines of circuitry lace over her cheeks. I briefly try to puzzle out her confusion, but it is beyond my comprehension. Entrapta made this rendezvous happen. I can ask her later. All that matters is: "Can you help?"

"I've been trying. I can feel the network like I'm a part of it, but I don't understand it fully yet. The system is trying to stop She-Ra from reaching further inside of the Crystal Caverns."

A dull thudding pulses in the back of my head. I can tell my body—She-Ra's body—is running. "What happens then?"

"That data isn't available to me," Mara's form flickers briefly before settling back into shape, "but I know she has to be stopped before she gets there." A reverberant undertone sneaks into her voice.

My hands clench into fists on impulse. I understand the urgency but I'm not sure how to fix it. Nothing I've done has worked. "Why is She-Ra going berserk?"

Her eyes lose a natural luster and lights of electronic circuitry creep into the irises. "It seems the security protocols have been corrupted either by someone with malicious intent or a system corruption from age. The monitoring and diagnostic algorithms are offline."

"So she's going nuts because something is broken in the computers?" I could really use an Entrapta right now. She would know what to make of this. I rubbed the tightening tension from above my brow. "How did they even turn on? They've gotta be older than anything on Etheria"

"Our security protocol is strict. She-Ra cannot reach the Crystal Caverns. We must hold her at all costs, even with the lives of your companions at stake." Her voice has lost all of the natural cadence from before, replaced by a tinny resonance.

" *Your* security protocols? Well stop them or something!" Her placid expression boils a rising anger inside of me. I stomp a foot down to punctuate my frustration but no sound accompanies the impact. "There's gotta be something we can do."

Mara loses all natural expression. She is as stiff as the statues that adorn the halls of Grayskull. "The security protocol is strict.

She-Ra cannot reach the Crystal Chamber.”

Something’s wrong. She’s starting to sound just like… Light Hope.

A stiff rail of anxiety creeps up my spine, but I throttle it before it can overtake me. I dealt with Light Hope before. I can handle this too. “Okay well... can we try something else?”

She blinks in puzzlement at me. “I cannot compromise the safety of Castle Grayskull. She-Ra cannot—”

“Can it, sparks-for-brains! Where’s the Mara side of this AI?” I lurched forward and try to grab her by the shirt but my hands pass through immaterial data.

“The security proto—”

I’m running out of time. I can feel it in the dim flashes of pain, the tension of my muscles.

“Override! Administrator access!” I wave my hands in front of her frozen face. “I’m a friend of Mara!”

A visual tick breaks Mara’s stony visage. A rippling flicker starts at her feet and shimmers up her body. Once at the top, she stops and blinks away the artificial electronic circuitry in her eyes. The staleness of her tone dissipates.

“Hello, Adora.”

I suck in a sharp breath and stutter backward a step, surprised it had worked. She sounds just like her. From the recordings. “Hi… Hi, Mara.” I don’t really know what else to say. I want to say everything. But I struggle for words.

She looks at me in disbelief as she collects herself, as though she has just woken from a trance. She smiles sweetly at me. That disarming earnestness touches me somewhere deep, settling a

discomfort I didn't know was overwhelming me. "You look just like I remember."

I scratch at the back of my neck from the sudden self-consciousness and look down at myself. The dumb jacket I haven't changed in years, other than gilded accents on my shirt that I had the tailors in Bright Moon add. The same issue boots. I didn't look much different on Eternia than I did Etheria. "I guess that's a good thing."

"At least I know it's you." Concern wavers Mara's expression. "Is Etheria…?"

"It's safe now."

Her rigid posture notably relaxes and she places a hand on her chest. "Then you really did it." She smiles tearfully

"Y… yeah." I glance down, realizing I'm grasping my forearm. "I guess I did."

Mara wipes a wayward tear and smirks. "I'd hug you but I don't really have the body to do it."

I'd give anything to hold her, maybe just to make her a little more real. Beyond just the fear of what She-Ra is doing right now, is the feeling of distance between me and her. I don't know how much of this simulation I can trust. "It's mutual."

She looks around the room again. Her brow furrows slightly. "I think I remember this place."

"You do?"

She grins at me a little ruefully. "I don't remember it looking this intact though."

"So wait…" I shake my head, trying to cobble together my thoughts. "You were here back when it was destroyed, too?"

"I think so." She tilts her head as she thinks. "That's all that I remember at least."

How much of this could an AI remember? Is it programmed to do this? Light Hope was stiffer, so alien. But this seems more real. "What are you?"

Mara looks down at herself. She must feel just as confused as I do, but she only shrugs. "I don't know, but I'm here now. I might as well help."

"Okay, you're *so* much better to talk with than the AI already." A shock stabs at my back and the dream flickers around me. A ghost of pain from She-Ra's body so far away from her. She is fighting with you and Bow right now, isn't she? I glance over my shoulder, up at the ceiling, but there is nothing to see. Only feel.

"I don't really have a better answer though, I'm afraid."

I bite at the side of my cheek, but there's no feeling. "Can you at least tell me what's going on?"

"I'm trying." She examines the throne behind her. "I don't really know why I'm here. I have limited access to the databases. I just know there are all kinds of security systems here to stop She-Ra from reaching the Crystal Caverns depths of Castle Grayskull."

"And you don't know why, either?"

She shakes her head.

"Perfect." My annoyance causes another flicker in the delicate reality of the throne room. The edges of the chamber blur before snapping back into contrast.

"But I think we might stand a better chance at stopping her together."

The confidence in her tone brings my attention back to her. She rests a hand on her hip and shifts her feet. Despite the other

reality of this digital spectre, she exudes confidence and it allays some of the fear inside of me.

Here is my predecessor as She-Ra. I can't let her down.

"What can I do?" I gather the determination within me to match Mara's. "What's taken over She-Ra? It's like she's corrupted again."

"That's because she is." Mara pulls up an open portal next to her. She withdraws from it a red data crystal like the one Entrapta had so long ago. "The security systems were meant to control She-Ra, but I've never seen her like this. Something must have happened since she last… Since I last…" Her face twists in a grimace again.

A conflicting urge strikes through me. I need her help getting out of here, fixing this, but she needs someone, too. What do I do? There are so many things I want to say, but you and Bow are in peril. I take a deep breath. "Mara, I need your help."

She looks up at me and stows the painful expression. It disappears as easily as it appeared. "I'll try."

She turns the crystal over in her hands and passes it to me. I almost don't want to take it, but her smile is encouraging. I can be brave with her. The crystal is surprisingly heavy. It feels warm and tingly to the touch. A surge of power up my arm exacerbates how vacant my other senses are right now.

She looks to the crystal and back to me. "Even if we can't figure out how it's doing it, maybe we can help She-Ra."

I grasp the crystal between my thumb and forefinger. "Can't Bow and Catra just find where this one is hiding and bust it to get me back?"

She shakes her head gravely. "The core of the central network is infested with the corrupted protocol. You can't destroy it without destroying the whole Castle."

I pause, my eyes raking over the surrounding throne room. The flickering violet flames. The iron crosses and mosaics adorning the gray walls. A defiance ignites in my chest. A similar one I'd felt before I'd broken the sword.

I meet Mara's eye. "Why shouldn't we?"

She smiles sadly at me. "The—"

"Right, right. The crystal things in the basement." I huff out a breath. "Okay, then what? She-Ra is going to kill them." Panic tugs at my chest. I feel so isolated here, but that seems to be waning. A renewed sense of urgency rises.

Mara's smile hasn't changed. "You have to be calm."

"Well, I'm kind of *trying* that but she's got a mind of her own right now!" I bite back with a punctuation of a closed fist around the crystal. "It's not like I *want* her to hurt my friends but she won't listen to me!"

"She-Ra doesn't have a mind. Not like we think of one, anyway. She's a force beyond what we really can understand, and she binds to us. The First Ones found a way to channel her into a runestone with the Sword of Protection. But she still was a part of me and you." Mara holds her hand out indicating for me to hand the crystal back to her.

I look from her hand to the offending data crystal. I wish just smashing it right now could fix everything. "So why can't I just stop her? Every time I try it's like… like we're disconnected or something."

"There are parts of our minds that we can't control directly." Mara accepts the crystal and it spins over her hand on its axis and a shape materializes around it. You. Just standing there with that smug grin on your face.

I resist an urge to run forward and grab you. Hold you. But it's just a hologram, like in the Heart.

"Adora, you're confused and scared. That means She-Ra is, too."

I scowl at Mara, but I can't take my eyes off you for long. Those words twist at an old wound in me. One I thought had healed. All the things Shadow Weaver had told me—those lies. They don't have power over me anymore. At least...

"About what?" I ask.

"Catra, your friends, I think the whole universe." Mara studies your hologram with a mixture of curiosity and melancholy. "The worst part about being She-Ra was how little I could help everyone. People felt so delicate and I held on to the few things that I could. Even then, in the end, it wasn't enough."

I want to push away her words but they stick firmly inside of me. The flash of memories, of time and space that had trapped me for so long, point toward the truth of her words. Everything just seemed like it was ready to fall apart. "They… things still feel broken."

"I know, Adora. I know. But we can make it okay. We just have to let go." She flicks her hand and your hologram disappears into the ether of the simulation.

A searing anger rises inside of me. Those words. Those lies. You standing over me cutting the last threads of the rope that tethered me above an abyss. That contemptuous sneer.

I wonder what I could've been if I'd gotten rid of you sooner...

A thread inside of me snaps, beating back the thought and the memory. That isn't how I want to remember you. That's not who you are.

"No." The word leaves me like a missile. I shake my head, slowly at first but my agitation soon turns it into a violent motion of rejection. "I won't let go. Never again. Not her. Not Catra, or

my friends. Those were *lies* fed to me by Light Hope and you *can't* tell me they were true!"

My voice echoes in the hollow throne room. It impacts against Mara and she steps back. She holds her hands out between us in placation. "Adora, I'm sorry. I didn't mean that."

"I almost… it would've…" My fists squeeze so tight that I would've bit my nails into my flesh if they were real. "Letting go is how we *lose* ."

"Adora, it's okay." Mara smiles calmly. "I meant let go of your fear."

I stiffen. "My… But I'm not…"

"It's all right." She steps forward and places an incorporeal hand on my shoulder. "You're still afraid, Adora."

"I don't feel afraid." I want to smack her hand away but I know the motion is fruitless. "What more do I have to be afraid of? I've done everything that I can, everything that has been asked and *more* . I did what you said! I…" I force myself to pause and look at her imploringly. My hand bunches the fabric of my jacket as I clench it over my heart. Where the Failsafe is burned into me. "I am finally feeling whole. The world—the universe is making sense." And I have you…

"That's not true. You're hiding something from even yourself."

I would have argued the declaration from anyone else. But something about the earnest, empathetic way Mara said it left no room for argument. She knew I was afraid because she'd felt that same fear. "So, what do I do?"

Mara shifts her body, leaning in closer to mine. I can feel her, even though she isn't real. "What are you afraid of Adora? You haven't told me."

I shake my head, perplexed. “Nothing! Everything is like it should be. Horde Prime is gone, we’re saving the galaxy… again. And we have each other. We’ve helped Entrapta, we have Angella back, Catra is… Catra is…” No. Everything is fine. Everything is okay.

“What? What is it?” Something is different about her voice. It has the gentle authority of Angella’s but a deeper empathy unlike anyone else’s.

Confusion still bubbles inside of my mind as to how real she actually is. I don’t want to talk about you. I want everything to just be okay. Things are just the way they are. The way they always have been. And we got each other back. I don’t need to press it any further. Right?

All those times I woke up and you had slipped away in my sleep. When I found you curled in some dark corner, those scratches on your skin. The impatience and annoyance that stirred within you when we talked sometimes. I try so hard. But the more I have avoided it, the more obvious it is that something is wrong.

“I’m scared I’m losing Catra again.” My voice rings hollow in the empty simulated throne room.

The concern in Mara’s eyes doesn’t waver. “Again?”

I nod, the mere act a symbolic violation of the trust we had been building until now. “There’s a part of her that I’m scared of. I hoped it was gone, dead, but it’s not. And I don’t know if she’s strong enough to keep fighting it.” Mara isn’t real, but I want her to be. I want her to take my hands again and let me know it will be okay. “I’m scared what’ll happen if she doesn’t. But I can’t fight it for her. I can’t—”

“She can’t either. It’s a part of her as much as we don’t want it to be.”

“But I want to—”

She can't take my hands this time, but her eyes are as viceral as the deepest sunsets of Bright Moon. I can't meet them for long and drop my gaze to the stones at our feet.

"Adora, if you're afraid of something inside of Catra, then it will feed She-Ra. It's why she's attacking her."

I snap my eyes back up to her, my brow furrowed. "I don't understand."

"Tell me about her."

Her tone is soft. Inviting. Anyone else asking and I might not have answered. Perhaps the one thing I wasn't afraid of was speaking to Mara.

"Do you… Do you remember the last time we talked?" I glance up at her nervously and her expression only encourages me more. "When you said… when you asked what I wanted? I didn't know. I just wanted to help and protect everyone. Because that's what I was raised to do. It's what I was supposed to do. But I wasn't strong enough. So I figured I'd… even if I couldn't be She-Ra, I could save everyone as Adora. That's what made sense. It was what the universe wanted from me, right? Everything had been leading up to this moment. But Catra… she… She was there with me. And I realized that it was her. She was what I wanted." I almost laugh around the pain constricting my chest. I tighten my hand around my ethereal arm, the absence of the requisite touch flares the tightness further. "I guess I'd always known, but I still couldn't admit it until she said it first. Maybe I am an idiot."

A small smirk twitches the corner of Mara's lips upward, but she persists. "You're the last person in the galaxy that should think of themselves as an idiot." Entrapta's words resonate with Mara's rather uncannily. "What is it, Adora? Tell me.""

"Everything feels like it tries to tear us apart. And I keep fighting those things. I've fought them since I've known her. Shadow Weaver. The Horde. The war." I relax the useless touch of

my forearm and scowl at the foot of the throne. "But she didn't come with me. She let them take her. And she… she used them against me. And now it feels like it did when I left. When I became She-Ra. Like she resents me for… for… fighting." My eyes burn. I wish I could feel something, anything right now. There is just anguish inside me. "And I don't know how to fix it, Mara. I don't know how to stop that side of her."

"You can't," Mara says simply. "No one can."

"So I'm just going to lose her? I don't—I can't… Not again."

"No." She shakes her head, stepping closer. Hey eyes bleed conviction. "No, this is something much, much harder. You need to trust her, and you need to love all of her."

The words are red-hot irons of shame in my mouth but I have to speak them. "I don't know if I can."

"You can. If she's what you really want? You can. You have to. Those things that you're afraid of are a part of her, too. And you can't separate them. You have to love all of them. You've stood up to her, and shown her who you are. You have what she needs more than anything else in the universe. Your heart. No matter what happens, or what power we wield, it is our hearts that guide that force." She reaches out, hovering her hand over my heart. The edges of her form shimmer where she touches me, but I think I can feel her warmth. "Yours has been pure, and your devotion undeniable. Proof alone is that you're standing here in front of me."

I can only nod. Could I believe that?

"You have come this far because your strength has been a beacon to She-Ra. Now with strength, we have to find peace." Mara retracts her hand and steps back. "There's a love between you and Catra that is honest and pure. And that makes it scary. But it's what the two of you need, more than anything else. She knows it, and you have to believe her."

Mara flickers. The dream is ending.

My chest twinges with an ethereal pain—a pain of wishing there was infinite more time, but knowing there was none.

“Mara?”

“Yes, Adora?”

What question do I ask? What do I say? What moment will I ever have to speak to her again?

I meet her eyes, my vision wavering against the tears but I’m determined. “Thank you. You saved me at the Heart. It took me a while, but I understand now. I know what I want and I couldn’t have realized it without your help.”

She smiles at me. “I never wanted you to be there. I tried so hard to keep you from inheriting my failures. But you had to. I’m sorry, but I’m happy I could finally do something to help. Everyone needs you, but please, let them help you, too. She-Ra might be bound to you, but she is nothing compared to your spirit and your friends. You’re capable of so much when you’re together. You’ll find what you want as long as you’re together. Be strong, Adora. Be brave.”

“Wait!” I want to stop her. I want to tell her those things aren’t true.

She flickers out of existence and a single sparkling tear is left in her wake. It falls to the floor and when it splashes the simulation goes dark.

I opened my eyes to the soft green glow. It felt oddly cold for the Fright Zone. Two doodles adorned the wall in front of me. Our goofy grins.The mattress next to me was empty. I could only smell the barest traces that you had been there before. The kiss wafted away from my lips. I was doubtful it even had happened. Maybe I’d just dreamed it. But I guess it didn’t matter.

The cadets in the bunks murmured softly and I pushed up. I let out a long breath, gathering up the courage to look down at my leg.. It still hurt, a lot. It was stiff and unwilling to move. I dragged it from the pillow— *your* pillow reluctantly. The slightest tug if the blanket against the toe of my boot was agony.

But there was nothing for it. It was time to get up, go to training, and pretend like everything was okay.

Just another day.

The world is a spiral of flame around me. You whirl your hands in a circle, traces of fire coalescing into blinding light, and launch a net of flame at She-Ra. Behind it, another arrow follows. As the net casts over She-Ra's body, the arrow opens and a bola wraps around her. Me? I'm not sure. I'm awake. Sort of.

The world is a mix of agony and anger. She-Ra's anger feels different now. Under it, I can sense the fear. Or at least after speaking with Mara, I think I can. But it doesn't change the damage that she can do.

She-Ra flexes and breaks free of the bola with ease.

"You're going to need a better trick than that, Arrow Boy!" You throw another gout of flame her direction and it dimly washes over her arm. Echoes of pain singe my skin.

"Sorry! I've used up the good ones." His voice cracks with the tension.

A sparse hall is now the battleground. The bricks have foregone the gray monotone of the rest of the castle and instead are covered in white peeling adhesive or mortar. Scattered across the floor are small mosaic tiles that glint in green and orange. They'd fallen long ago over the eons . Even longer than Mara's time.

A large steel emergency door slams shut behind you, Bow, and Melog. It rattles the narrow hallway. She-Ra knows you're trapped

and she leans in on a charge towards you.

Bow winces and draws an arrow. His tight expression reflects regret. He knows he's about to shoot his friend.

Do it.

He releases the arrow and it streaks towards She-Ra's face. It explodes in a scatter of dust that burns the inside of her nose and forces her to close her eyes. She steps back and swipes futilely at the wall knocking stones loose that have stood for thousands of years.

The distinct noise of metal being torn through rises over She-Ra's agony.

"It's real nice that the *castle* is fighting us, too."

She-Ra brushes the powder out of her eyes. At the end of the hallway is a gaping black hole that you and Bow had sprinted through. She thunders ahead into the steel door. She swings a back-handed strike and buckles the entire assembly, scattering it into the room as though it's a plastic shell.

A quick silence gives her time to adjust her eyes to the darkness. A flash in the center of the room breaks through the stagnant blackness. The disembodied head of a man with chin-length, golden blonde hair pops into a sudden projection that fills the room with purple light. We're in a strange circular room. It's unlike the others in Grayskull and instead made of amethyst structures with flat faces. The head floats atop a central cylindrical projector, and surrounding it in a pentagram are five crystalline structures. It reminds me of the interface panels of Arxia.

The head begins to speak. "Greetings. I welcome you to Castle G—"

She-Ra snarls and grabs for one of the interface consoles and hoists it up. Shattering crystals and severed electronics are a discordant crackling as she rips it free. She turns and finds you

hiding in one of the corners as though she already knew you were flanking her. She launches the makeshift boulder at you. You spin away in a pirouette without missing a beat. You've been in this fight for too long to be caught with that kind of attack. You shimmer away as it passes through where you were. The crystal crashes loudly against the opposite wall in a cacophony of shearing crystal and snapping electronics. Both you and Melog appear paces away from where the crystal landed.

She-Ra bellows in anger and frustration. I catch sight of the red veins laced on top of her skin as thrashes her arms in her rage. They pulse with the fury that lurks inside of her.

It's okay. I grasp tighter at the thread of pain, of fear.

Bow launches another arrow at She-Ra. He aims low this time and a scattering of ball bearings lands at her feet. She steps and lands solidly on them. Her foot alights on a gaggle of bearings as she charges forward to attack. The trap does its work. She-Ra's gilded boot slips out from under her, sending the warrior crashing to the floor. Falling flat on her backside with a thunderous crash. I feel it in my own tailbone with a wince.

The fear resonates louder. They're going to hurt her.

I remember.

I remember long lonely nights sitting in Bright Moon, wondering if I'd ever see you again.

Glimmer telling me that it's like her mom never even existed.

The vines of Beast Island encircling Bow.

I was going to fix it. No one else could. Anyone else would just get hurt if they tried, and I couldn't let that happen. Everyone gets hurt because of the things I do. I have to protect them. I have to…

White eyes are enshrined in the black and red mask that materializes in front of me.

Shadow Weaver.

An avalanche of red hot fury radiates out from that thread of pain that She-Ra carries.

You dash across the room. You drop into a low kick, sweeping your leg in front of you, and an arc of orange radiance impacts against She-Ra, knocking her down prone.

I can't stop Shadow Weaver from hurting you. I tried Catra. I tried so hard. I was helpless.

The visage of Shadow Weaver's mask slips. It falls away and staring back at me is an amber eye full of fury, the other half cast in a nightmarish shadow. The sneer. The anger.

I made you this way. I couldn't help it. You were always going to be this.

A plummeting sorrow latches on to my feet and drags me towards an abyss of fear. Rage batters at my last threads of fraying sanity. I don't know what will happen if I let go right now. Will I be lost in this body, this form forever? There's no point. There's nothing else that I can do. The fear. Shadow Weaver's mask. That glare. I was helpless. I still am. I can only watch. I can't do anything.

I'm sorry, Catra.

I careen towards the pitfall of my mind and I scramble for any thought, any memory to dissuade the fear that grips my mind and fuels the rage and confusion in She-Ra. Nothing is ever going to change the world, the universe. I can't save them. I can't fix it. I can't fix us. I was always going to lose you. Not even with her strength.

I wanted to go back, Catra. I wanted to cut the Fright Zone in half if you gave me any reason, *anything* to drag you out of there. But you didn't. You never wanted to come back.

Not until…

Adora… I'm sorry! For everything!

Those words changed everything.

I grasp a mental hand-hold and my fall into the oblivion of fear halts. I latch tight to the lifeline.

I'd spent so many nights waiting to hear you say that. To say that you were sorry. And then you did. I did. I cut the universe in half just to get you out of the Velvet Glove. To get you away from Horde Prime. I fought through an army of clones, the depths of my despair, because I knew you could fight.

Our tormentors, our fears. We didn't experience them the same way. But we can fight them together. I can be strong with you.

You wouldn't leave. Not after everything.

The vibrating chord of fear flatlines.

It's okay. It's time to not be afraid anymore.

She-Ra stops trying to push herself up from the floor. She freezes like an engine stalled.

"Wait! Stop!" I hear your voice.

They can take care of themselves. They can take care of… us. It's okay.

I grasp around the thread of fear and warmth flows into my hand.

She-Ra follows in kind, and the Sword of Protection materializes in front of her hand.

We don’t have to be afraid anymore.

She reaches forward but the sword is snatched from the air in front of her. You run as a blur in front of us and scatter back towards Bow.

I feel She-Ra shout like an earthquake through my soul.

No, please don’t do this.

The chord vibrates again. The fear, the anger rises again like a surging tsunami. She pushes up off the floor onto unsteady feet.

“Catra, I think she needs the sword.” Bow’s voice is a mix of panic and conviction. Melog yowls next to him, looking between She-Ra and you in fear. Hackles still raised.

You hide behind him, holding the sword in both hands, point down. “Are you crazy? If she’s going nuts without the sword, what’s going to happen when she gets her hands on it?”

“We have to trust her!” Bow reaches behind him for another arrow but finds his quiver dry.

“I can’t just give it to her! She’ll kill us all.” The old anger is back in your eyes, the snarl of your mouth, but behind that I recognize the fear. The doubt.

I want to scream at you.

Do you trust me?

She-Ra charges. Heavy boots clank against the crystalline floor. Cracks spider from beneath her feet. You cast flame into my face, and you and Bow scatter to either side.

She-Ra narrowly misses grabbing anyone and she turns. The metallic boots scrape against the crystal floor. She doesn’t care about Bow or Melog. Just you. Rising, unstoppable tide of hatred burns through her. It breaks, and she snarls. She slams her hand

into the floor and digs her fingers into the dense rock. She plants, ready to charge and shatter through anything that's in her way.

You hold the sword in both hands, point still down resting on the floor. Ears flattened, teeth bared, you are defiant to the last.

"It has to work!" He's scavenged an arrow from the floor that he draws and fires. It uselessly plinks against She-Ra's bicep. "It's still Adora in there. She always trusted you and believed in the good in you. Do the same for her!"

Melog punctuates Bow's words with a yowl.

Your body relaxes. His words seem to hit you in a place where you didn't know you were vulnerable. You stand, no longer scowling, or angry, or defiant. Instead there's a confusion in your eyes, a little pain, but an unwavering strength beneath.

She-Ra notices and the inferno of rage flickers out.

Across all realities and all improbabilities, she wants this as much as we do.

We stare at each other. I am still locked behind the prison of She-Ra, but I see you. And I think, I believe, you see me. You glance briefly over to Bow and nod.

I feel the chord of fury flatline again. The red haze has diminished into a soothing white. Calm is overriding the storm of fear of the rampant She-Ra. The crashing waves breaking into reflectant stillness.

She steps towards you.

You offer up the handle of the sword. Point down. Eyes locked on mine.

She-Ra reaches out and touches it. There is a blinding light, and then blackness.

Peace

I stumbled.

Lonnie's staff aimed at my side and I pushed off my right foot to block. A clang rattled through the air, reverberated up the staff. My ankle twisted oddly. The impact of her blow pushed me down to my knee. I couldn't stand up. The pain radiating up to my hip locked my leg in place.

Lonnie hesitated her next strike. "Hey, are you okay?"

I nodded through gritted teeth. "Great. Never better."

She raised an eyebrow. "You sure? You look a little green."

I set the butt of the staff on the plates and stood, supporting my weak ankle. "Nope. All good here. Keep going."

"I don't know. You just kinda fell there." She lowers her staff, straightening out of her ready stance. I want to beg her not to be so obvious. "Can you even stand?"

"I'm fine!"

"Cadets!" Commander Cobalt's voice punched through the training arena. "You were not authorized to stop your training!"

Lonnie looked up in the direction of the loudspeakers. No hesitation or second thought, just shouted, "Adora's injured! We need to take a look."

"Horde soldiers are expected to still fight in the face of adversity. Training was not authorized to be—"

The commander's voice cut off abruptly. I held my breath, stifling the cold dread rising in me.

The speaker crackled for a breath before a cowed commander said, “Cadets, report to the locker room at once.”

My heart plummeted through the floor. “Lonnie, you shouldn’t have.”

“It’s all right, Adora. We can pick it up after we get that looked at.” Her smile radiated on her face. She thought she was doing me a favor.

I braced the staff like a crutch to remove the load from my injured ankle.

“Here let me help.” Lonnie stepped up and took my arm over her shoulder. I wanted to push her away. I didn’t want anyone to know. But I felt powerless to stop her. I couldn’t stop any of this. It didn’t matter what I did. I knew what was going to happen.

“Thanks.” I would not let go of the staff, though.

She hauled me easily, her strength more obvious than yours. “You know, you really should take it easy. You’ve been pushing yourself pretty hard. It’s making the rest of us look bad.”

“I’m just motivated.” I tried for a brave smile, hoping it worked. “Gotta earn that senior cadet rank.”

“Don’t be in such a hurry.” Lonnie shifted again and picked me up a little higher. Her body was tacky with sweat against mine. I could smell the body odor from training. Or maybe that was me? Did I still smell like oil and sulfur from the forge? Could Lonnie tell?

We caught a rhythm quickly and shambled into the locker room. Kyle and Rogelio stood with their backs against the far lockers, nearly touching. They glanced at me and Lonnie as we came in, Rogelio stoic with crossed arms while Kyle twitched with anxiety… or concern. Or both.

I nearly didn't notice where you lingered in the shadows on the opposite corner to them. You tail twitched nervously against the wall you leaned on, though you feigned indifference

I caught your eyes and you hastily looked away, saying, "Adora holding up training, huh? Must be *serious*."

It hurt. It hurt to hear that voice from you. The snide sarcastic tone cut my heart into ribbons that I can only stitch together with the most tenuous moments we shared. We couldn't break from our patterns, could we? We'd look suspicious. I had to play along, no matter what I tried to change. "Y—Yeah, I think I just twisted it during training."

Lonnie set me down on the bench and I propped my leg along the length. It throbbed in time to my heartbeat. "You did? When? You weren't doing anything too crazy."

"I dunno. It happened just—"

A voice of velvety tar cut into our conversation.

"*Adora.*"

Shadow Weaver emerged from the darkness lingering over the entrance to the locker rooms.

"Shadow Weaver!" I attempted to stand. A force of habit drilled into me. My ankle buckled beneath the weight and I yelped as the pain shot all the way up to my neck. I collapsed back onto the bench. Lonnie caught me by the shoulders before I could slip to the floor.

I gritted my teeth against the pain, afraid to look up and see everyone's expressions around me. To see yours.

Shadow Weaver slid into the room. Her mask loomed with white eyes, red steel, and black valleys. She towered impossibly tall without seeming to change her shape. "Are you all right, child?"

I shake my head, ignoring the rising nausea. "N—No. I mean yes. It's fine... I just twisted it."

"Nonsense." She spoke softly, the voice I can remember consoling me when I was little. "You had such a severe limp during training just now. It would be negligent to let an injury lapse without any proper attention. Let's see how bad it is."

I flicked my eyes to you in the shaded corner. You said nothing, but your posture was rigid. The pupils of your eyes were contracted and your ears flattened. You made yourself impossibly small in the corner, trying to remain hidden. Out of sight. Out of mind.

"If I could… could rest it—just for the rest of the day—I think it'll be fine," I stammered. "It's nothing. Really. I'm fine."

Shadow Weaver didn't seem to hear me. Or she did and just didn't care. "Lonnie, could you remove Adora's boot?" She hovered over me. The darkness surrounded me. What normally felt comforting and warm bled into a sinister presence.

"Yes, Shadow Weaver." Lonnie worked quickly to pull it free. I bit the inside of my cheek to keep myself from flinching. She was not as careful as you had been. She yanked the boot free and the tape from before was laid bare to the entire room. There was an audible hush.

"Adora, you shouldn't hide such a thing from me. What are we to do with you?" Shadow Weaver's luxuriated words set me on edge. Her voice cut like a blade hidden beneath silk and it took everything within me not to quail beneath it.

"It… I…" I fumbled for words. I wasn't good at this sort of thing. Not like you. I tried to catch your eye, but you were purposefully looking away. Like you wanted nothing to do with me. I couldn't blame you. Not after I…

I dropped my head, my voice quiet, subdued. "I was running to get to training and I slipped."

"Yeah!" You stepped out of the shadows. I caught your eye, just the briefest flash, but I could see you clutching at this chance. "She was running and tripped. Lucky I was there to patch her up —wouldn't wanna be late to—"

"*Silence*." The single word was like a door slammed shut. Shadow Weaver's black snakes of shadow crept towards you.

A pin could drop in the room and the princesses would have heard it in their lairs.

"Cadets—fetch us a stretcher. Adora will not be able to walk on that ankle."

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio looked to each other, and then to us. I saw Lonnie lower her gaze. She knew. Without a word they scattered from the room, disappearing behind the curls of inky smoke emanating from Shadow Weaver. You tried to follow, but—

"You stay."

You froze mid-step, ears tucked tight against your head, tail drooping low.

As soon as the others left, Shadow Weaver turned to you. "Look at me, you insolent child."

Defiance notched your brow as you raised your dichromatic eyes. You didn't even flinch as the shadows encompassed you. As Shadow Weaver lurked over you.

"Do not speak to me as though you have *secrets*."

A sharpness entered the shadows. A flickering of red light that I recognized. The gem at the center of her mask glowed ominously.

"Wait! It was my fault." I reached out to Shadow Weaver, turning on the bench. You were too far away. I would've had to stand but then what? "I was being reckless and—and… It's all my fault."

She ignored me once more. "*I* know that Adora nearly fell to her death because of your ineptitude. *I* know that you severed the pipe in the forge and destroyed almost all of the machinery in there. And *I* know that it was you that ransacked the infirmary and stole from the Horde. Your failures are nearly immeasurable, Catra. You have continued to be nothing but a *disgrace* and I should have taken care of you a long time ago."

The snakes of shadow lashed out and grabbed you. A toxic, red haze surrounded your body and she lifted you off the ground. Helpless. The air boiled with hatred and needles sprang from the amorphous mist. An arc of crimson electricity dashed between the innumerable needles and they lowered delicately, digging into your skin. . Your teeth gritted in pain. Eyes were wide.

"Please don't hurt her." I called out again. Meekly. The sting of tears in my eyes was worse than the pain in my ankle.

"You almost cost Adora her *life* and you think this *recklessness* would go unpunished?"

The screams that tore from your throat bore your pain.

I was scared. I was so scared. My knuckles were white as I clamped tight onto the bench. I watched helplessly. No matter how much I wanted to change what happened, I knew I never could. Why was it always like this? What was the point of all the small moments we stole when this was what always happened? I could only make pointless promises in the quiet, but they were always shattered by her. I was useless.

No. I remember what I did. I remember I was brave.

I was always brave for you.

I couldn't just watch this. I couldn't let this happen. I *didn't*.

I found the staff again, took it up in my hand.

Shadow Weaver clenched her fist and your body twisted. Tiny droplets of blood pooled where the needles dug. I'd never seen this power but I knew she wasn't going to stop this time. Your hair stood on end. Tail curled. You screamed again.

"I didn't—" You tried to cough out, but the agony was too much. The convulsions muted your screams.

"No, you will pay *dearly* for this one Catra. You—"

I stood, ignored all pain in my ankle, all fear in my soul, and swung. "Leave her *alone*!"

The staff passed through black mist and you fell down into a smoking heap. Coughing. Scrambling back against the wall.

I froze, dumbfounded. The staff slipped from my hands and fell to the floor with a clatter in the agonizing quiet. I wanted to run to you. I wanted to see if you were okay. But I was locked.

It wasn't my fear that held me.

"Shadow Weaver, I—" She loomed in front of me, her mask an implacable visage bearing down on me. A threat towering high. Tingling chaffed at my skin. My back stiffened as the sparks grew in intensity. They dug into my skin with pinpricks of red-hot pain. Sinking in deeper. And deeper. They could tear me apart in an instant.

"Adora." Her voice. It dripped like viscous oil, all the sharpness gone. "I'm disappointed in you."

I didn't know what pain you felt until that day.

I startle awake, shoving blankets off me.

The nightmare echoes in my mind and I feel the tingles across my skin. The Failsafe on my chest fades and the blue aura winks

out. The air is cold. I'm cold. Sweat clings to my body via my thermal shirt.

I suck in a deep breath, and look around.

You're curled up next to me, close but not touching. Your eyes are closed, and somehow you seem to be deep asleep. Normally you're such a light sleeper. Cat naps. But the day must've taken it out of you. I bend a finger and caress your cheek. Your cheek twitches and you smile. Melog looks up from their slumber, blinking glowing blue eyes at me before they lay back down.

Across the room, Bow sleeps much more noisily. His snoring is soft and harmonizes with the dim patter of falling rain. He sleeps on a makeshift bed of salvaged wood that had avoided the moisture and couch cushions that seem somewhat clean. It was at least soft enough for him to sleep on. We preferred a table with a tapestry laid across it. And another one as a blanket.

I debate for a moment. Curl into your embrace? Forget the demons and the fear, hold one another until the day breaks and washes the shadows away? Like we always have and always will. Not tonight. Not right now. It isn't that I don't want it. I just… An unwelcome vision of She-Ra's hands around your throat drives me away. Just for now.

I slip the covering off and swing my legs off the side and try not to jostle the table enough to wake you. I stand and cinch my belt tight. A torch materializes instantly in my grasp when I reach for it. Gravitational portal miniaturizations or something sure do come in handy.

I leave my boots, and instead walk barefoot over the rotten carpet and exposed stones. The whole castle feels different now. An aura of anger pushes down on me, but I fight it back with minimal effort. I am merely aware of it now. There are lingering doubts of my ability to withstand it forever. But for right now, things are okay.

The hallway with extinguished torches leads into the hall of crystal computers. The one She-Ra, or I, had wrenched free and thrown sparkles against the far wall. Still, four others stand in what was formerly a pentagram-type configuration, with traces of connections leading to a central cylindrical projector. This didn't seem like the Crystal Caverns Mara was talking about, but maybe the computer could tell me how to get there. If it still works that is.

How much destruction had I caused? How close did I come to killing you? Was I really… could I not protect you? I did in the end but how many more times will there be? How many times do we have to fight?

A visage of Shadow Weaver's mask flickers in my vision again but dissipates away. I traverse across the smooth, crystalline floors and touch a standing computer. It feels cold but tingly. I swing the beam of the torch around and the crystals capture the light and ricochets it around inside of their facets. A lot of answers could lurk in the halls of Grayskull. I suppose I always wanted to come here. Find out what happened.

What was the honor of Grayskull, anyway?

"Hey, Adora."

That delicate, loving craft around my name pulls a flash of a memory from a time long gone. Inside of the Heart of Etheria, when I thought everything was going to end. I almost don't want to look. I'm fearful that… you are gone. A ghost of my imagination. I turn but at the last moment extinguish the beam of light. You always hated it when I shined it in your eyes.

"Catra." Seeing you drags a smile from my lips no matter how much I protest.

You smirk, leaning against the wall with your arms crossed. "What are you doing snooping around so late?"

"Just curious." I pan the light of the torch across the room, taking in the crystals and the expansive hall. "I thought I'd take a look around now that—you know—I'm not trying to destroy everything." My awkward laugh echoes in the stillness of the night.

Your narrowed eyes indicate your suspicion. "Right. And this couldn't wait until day because…?"

My sigh seems to drain all the bravado out of me and my shoulders slump. "I couldn't sleep. Thought a walk around would help."

The smirk nearly slips from your face but you maintain it. "Normally I'm the one waking up in a cold sweat."

"Maybe you're rubbing off on me?" I set my hand on my hip while the other grasps the torch.

"Maybe." You drop your eyes, rubbing absently at your arm.

"I didn't mean to wake you up. You can go back to sleep. I was just going to look around." I swing the torch toward a darkened hallway. "You know, there was a painting somewhere around here that really looked like my uncle before you set it on fire. I was going to see if there was anything left."

You tilt your head, brow furrowing. "What's an uncle?"

"Oh, like what Castaspella is to Glimmer, but a man… I think?" I chuckle and scratch the back of my neck. "I'm not really sure."

You laugh quietly—that melodic stifled snicker of yours you saved for when I was being an idiot. It cuts off abruptly with a grunt of pain and you hold tight to your side.

Cold runs through me as I see your pain. "Are you okay?"

Your eyes flick up to me. They glow in the dark room. You push off the wall and step towards me. Elegance bleeds through your

movements as you walk toes first, tail swinging behind you. I'm mesmerized. For some reason, in this hall, in this moment, you feel like a dream walking towards me. A faint worry churns in my stomach. After so much, can you really be here? Or will you just disappear again?

"You *really* need to get the hang of looking after yourself." You crack a smile, your fangs peeking past your lips.

"Sorry." You're close enough for me to grab your arms and pull you closer. It's an impulse I can't quite control. I need to know—to make sure. No, you're real. You're here right now.

You push back with a hand on my chest, over where the Failsafe sometimes hangs, before I can envelope you completely in my arms. "And… stop apologizing, dummy."

"Okay, okay, I'm trying. But really… are you…" The words are too painful to speak. Could I have lost you back there? "Are you okay, Catra? That was… a lot."

"Not the worst you've put me through." You tuck into my embrace, head in the crook of my neck, pressing into my side. One arm you wrap around me but the other holds onto your injured side protectively. The warmth is welcome but it still doesn't completely banish the coldness of the night.

"Catra, I almost killed you back there. If Bow hadn't—" Wait, where did he come from? It was a blur when he arrived. I haven't thought to ask about him.

"Trust me, I never wanted to be on that side of angry She-Ra again either. But it happened, and it seems like it's over."

"You're just… okay with that?" I rub my hand up and down your back, the wavering light of the torch marking the movement. The other tentatively trails across your arm. I'm not sure where else to touch you, afraid of hurting you any more. It's like holding you that night after we broke you out of the Velvet Glove. The almost

painful intensity with which you clung to my jacket. The fear and relief and doubt. I didn't ever want to put you down.

"I don't know if that counts as *okay*, but it's not the worst fight we've had." You grip my bicep and nuzzle in closer to me.

A sharp memory—an explosion of glass, the sting of your scratches on my skin. I tense, my hand clenching into fists against your shirt. "I was…"

"Scared?" You push back to look at me again. A smirk on your face.

How do you always endure so much? "Of course I was."

"You shouldn't be."

I reach up a hand to cradle your cheek. I caress my thumb across the delicate fur there. "It's hard not to. Some days it feels like you're a dream yourself, you know? Like… like I'm just going to wake up in the Crystal Castle and all of this was just some simulation Light Hope made for me."

"Okay, *that's* being a little extreme." You push back a little further against me. It opens up more space between us. Why?

I resist the urge to pull you closer again and instead retract my hand. "It's true. I didn't… I… I never thought I would get you back. For the longest time, I didn't let myself think that. But then I did. *We* did. We fought for each other and that's why we're here." I reach out again, grabbing your shoulder, squeezing. The confusion in your eyes is disheartening, but I push forward. "I never thought things would be okay. And they just… are now. And it's scary because it feels like everything that's happened since then has been trying to wrench us back apart. And I'm just…" My breath hitches on the building tension within me and I have to pause to clear my throat. "Mara said that She-Ra's anger fed off my fear, and I realized that I've been afraid for a long time. That I've always been afraid that you're going to… that we're going to break again." I bite my lip and look down.

Speaking it out loud feels silly, trivial. A clinging to some juvenile ideal that we could be together forever. I let my hand slip from your shoulder and take a step back. You chuckle again, that light, playful laugh that dances up in pitch. The sound normally never failed to ease whatever tension was within me, but tonight it winds me up like a coil.

You touch at my shoulder. "Adora, don't be such a—"

"*Don't*." I smack your hand away. "Don't call me that. I'm not being—just…" The frustration within me muddles the words before I can speak them. The aura gathers around me, more difficult to ignore and I have to work to fight it. I press my palm to the side of my head to ward away the pressure. No. Not now. I need to say this.

The sensation fades and, when I look at you again, I see the concern in your expression, the fear betrayed by the slight flattening of your ears.

"When we… when we were in the Portal. Fighting. You meant the things that you said to me, didn't you?"

Your eyes widen and you touch your cheek compulsively. The wounds of our memories won't leave either of us. "I… I didn't—" You take a step back.

"Why, Catra?" I follow after you. No more hedging away. "Why after *everything* did you want to hurt me so bad? Why did it have to happen this way?"

You examine me closely. One arm creeps across your body to grab the bicep of the other. I've seen you make that gesture so many times. As though this alone would protect you from all the uncertainty and darkness of the world around you. "I didn't know what I was doing. Everything just hurt so bad." You shudder and narrow your eyes staring back at me like I was cornering you. Maybe I was. There was no more Portal to slip away in this time.

"And that's why you said it?"

You made me this. You took everything from me.

Those words are cut in my memory like scars from a knife. No matter what happens, I can't shake myself from them completely. They run too deeply.

"I'm sorry." You shake your head. A coldness cuts through your words like you've been asked these questions too many times. "I can't just make it go away. But I'm sorry, okay?"

"How do I know that's not going to happen again?" My voice catches. Stumbling over the hard knot of fear. I guess it's been there for years, no matter how hard I tried to ignore it.

"You don't remember, do you?" You fight tears. A hiccup of pain bounces you and you wince. In the darkness of the room, I hadn't noticed that it isn't anger in your eyes. It's pain.

"What?" I reel, taking a step back. The torch in my hand falls limp, the beam uselessly reflecting off the stones. "There's a lot I don't remember from the past couple of days."

"Not that." You laugh wryly. The space between us, you close it with a few easy steps. You grip my shoulders and this time I don't knock your hands away. "I told you—whatever happens, I am staying with you."

I am shocked out of words. The Heart, the Failsafe, my last dying breaths in your arms. A pain rises in my chest from a breath I didn't know I was holding. I release it with a shutter. My hand drifts over to my forearm, gripping it. I stare down. Sometimes I just miss the pressure of the bracelet there. Everything feels so bare and unprotected without it. "I really want to believe that."

"But you can't, can you?" A weight tumbles off your voice and lands between us. An admission of guilt and a further opening of a gulf.

I want to take it back, but it has been said. Too late now. "At least… I am having trouble."

"I get it." You give my shoulder a squeeze.

I glance up, meeting your eyes. "You do?"

"I mean… I think I do." Your hands drift from my shoulders and down to my arms. "All that time we spent fighting. Sometimes it feels like we lived our whole lives apart. And… well… It could have gone that way forever if Prime hadn't…"

My hand instinctively goes to your face before you can touch the back of your neck, cradling it in my palm. "Catra, that's not what I mean."

"I know. I'm not saying that Prime is why I..." You sigh in frustration. "It's just… always felt like I shouldn't be here. Like I was done back when… Well, I made my choice. And I thought it was going to go one way, and then it didn't. And now… I don't think either of us would have guessed it'd be me who had a change of heart…"

"I did." I affectionately caress your cheek again.

"No, Adora, stop. I know that tone. You just said that you were scared that I was a walking dream. You didn't think I was coming back. Not after everything I said and did. But now I am. And it seems like it isn't real and I get it." You tense your fingers around my arms. "I wake up sometimes and I don't know where I am or what happened. I shouldn't be here. And that has us scared sometimes."

I nod. You still feel so far away, even though we're holding each other.

"But then I see you and the confusion and fear are sucked away. And I'll fight everything in the universe to stay here with you." You fall into my embrace again, intertwining your arms around my back and squeezing me tight.

I feel a warmth, a new one since Entrapta gifted you with a runestone. My doubts and fears thaw. Things could actually

change. “Okay.”

A weight pulls us downward. Neither of us have the strength to resist it, burdened beneath all those years of turmoil and suffering, but now it is okay to rest. I lead you gently onto the floor, mindful of your side. We curl up together, our backs against the projector in the middle of the room. We hold each other like that for a while. The rain stops, the night lingers on. But neither of us wants to let go. At least for a little longer. And longer still after that.

You shift your body to settle yourself better and moan softly. “She-Ra really knows how to land a punch.”

I quell another apology. Instead, maybe a different joke. “Maybe you shouldn’t try so hard to make her mad.”

You shudder on top of me as a short painful laugh ripples through you. “*Maybe* she should learn to play nicer.” You lean deeper into me and sprawl more of your body across me, trying to take the weight off your side.

“Here, come here.” I reach down and thread an arm under your knees.

“What’re you doing?”

“You’re sitting on the hard ground and wincing every time you move. Come here.”

“Fine.” You grumble as I finish dragging you over and pulling you onto a seat on my lap. Your tail whips in a brief bout of happiness. You lay on me crosswise, head tucked into the crook of my neck, and threading behind me at the small of my back. My hand rests on your thigh, the other on your back. There’s a little more pressure against my back on the projector, but it doesn’t matter. Not when we’re like this.

“Better?”

You twist your body slightly and then relax, taking the rest of the pressure off your side. “Yes.”

The begrudging edge in your tone endears you to me a little bit more every time.

Your breathing slows as the pain washes away from you. You start a soft purr against me; shallow breaths keep you from indulging it further. “What was your nightmare about?”

“You, us, Shadow Weaver.” I rest my cheek on top of your head and squish one of your ears down.

Your arm tightens around me. “Those ones are awful, aren’t they?”

“They… yeah they are.” I suppress the urge to sneeze as your hair tickles my cheek. “You have them a lot?”

“More than I’d like. But they’ve been getting better. It helps having…” You nuzzle into the crook of my neck. “You’re helping. Just being there.”

That was all I ever wanted. It seemed so close a couple times. I’m brought back into a moment of pain, the heartbreak in the Crystal Castle when I felt so close to finally bringing you with me. I thought for sure you would. But then… I stare out into the dark hall just beyond us, a knot of anxiety forming in my stomach. I remember the disassembly of reality around me before slipping into darkness. *Let go.* I squeeze my eyes shut and pull you tighter to me. Not this time. Not ever again. That was just another lie. One within the twisted web we were slowly untangling.

“Do you remember back when we were roaming the Crystal Castle together?”

“Of course. There were crystals and a bunch of silly writing around.”

"Do you remember how it felt? What it was like being in there together?"

"A little… I remember being with you, and I remember when we… When I had the sword…"

I move the hand from your back and place it on your head, threading my fingers through your growing hair. "I don't mean that part. I just… I want to know. When you said I didn't do anything to protect you... Did you mean that?"

You reach around my arm to scratch at the back of your neck. Claws delicately scrape at your choker. "I did… But just at the time. I think Light Hope was messing with us."

"I wanted to think so, too. She was good at that." I release a thin wisp of a breath. "But after everything that happened, I just… You were right. I could have done more."

"No, Adora. I was wrong. I was… angry and I took that all out on you. I'm..." your words falter, as though you still struggle to speak them, "sorry I said that. And I'm sorry it took me this long to say it."

A phantom creeps inside of my bones—a memory of long ago dredged up. "I was having a nightmare about when I twisted my ankle and…"

"That was a *bad* one."

"I did try, Catra. I really did. It just was never enough and I was scared. Shadow Weaver—she… she was…" I see her lurking inside of my thoughts. She threatens the same thread of pain and fear that triggered She-Ra.

"Hey." You hold me tighter. "I know you did. You always did."

The next words I whisper, as though this will keep them from melding with the gloom around us. "I thought she was going to kill you."

"She might've." You sigh and tuck your head against my chest a little harder. "If you hadn't stepped in. I'm sorry she… well, that she turned it on you…"

"Now who's apologizing too much?" I kiss the top of your head.

You shift again, positioning yourself like you almost want to sink into me.

She won't hold this control inside of me anymore. It's time to let her go. The mask slips away and she's that woman fighting the guardian for… us. A different feeling rises, not appreciation or fear. Something else bubbles. "Do… do you think she… made up for what she did to us? When she… you know… sacrificed herself in the Heart of Etheria?"

You push away, bracing an arm against the projector. I guess you need to look at me for this answer. I watch your eyes flick right and low. I can tell you're wondering if you should tell me the truth. You meet mine again. Bright Moon and the Fright Zone stare back, somehow reconciling on your face and inside of me. "No."

"Good. Me too."

"As far as I'm concerned, that's the least she could've done after what she put us through."

Your point made, you sink back down onto me, grunting against the pain in your side. I reach over instead, tentatively touching at your injury. A slight wince but you don't push my hand away. A shiny bauble catches my attention. A pin that you've worn since that day back on Etheria. It decorates your loosely buttoned up shirt where your Force Captain's badge used to be, contrasting brightly with the maroon it adorns. I grasp it with my fingers. It's the same one on my belt. The wings of Bright Moon. After so long, after so many fights and so much grief, I didn't think you'd wear it so willingly. I never thought…

"Catra."

"Mmm?"

"Thank you… for looking out for me."

"Someone's gotta." Your ear flicks. That nervous tick.

I rub the smooth, golden metal between my fingers. "No, I don't mean… now. I don't mean even since you came back to us. I mean since… ever. As long as I can remember."

"I love you. That's my job." Your hand clenches behind my back.

"No… that's not it. Just listen." I shift slightly to relieve some of the tingling in my legs and to buy myself time to gather my thoughts. To put to words something that's been at the back of my mind for a long time and to tie up one last lingering thread. "There's been… a lot. A lot of things have happened and we've been through so, so much. And I'm…"

Your fingers twitch and you pull me closer.

I rub my thumb over the wings. I remember pinning the insignia to my new belt and staring at my reflection in the mirrors, the blinding daylight of Bright Moon coming in through the open windows along with the overwhelming perfume of flowers and the sound of birdsong and music just outside. It had felt like adorning a mask. A new costume. That wedge of doubt lodged deep within me. Wasn't I just a Horde Soldier? Why should these people trust me? And that desperate, uncontrollable urge of wanting nothing more than to prove that I was worthy of all their kindness and generosity. Seeing these wings on you now makes me wonder how much of that you feel yourself, how much of that I still feel.

"Do you remember Arxia?" I ask.

"Oh you mean when I said you were being an idiot and were walking into *another* situation that was going to get you killed?"

I try to keep the smirk from blooming on my lips. "Yes… that one."

"What about it?" The annoyance in your tone barely masks your growing fatigue. "Other than, 'You were right. Shadow Weaver was manipulating us again.'"

"You asked 'why does it have to be Adora?'" I remember the pressure of your grip on my wrist, pulling me away from the Failsafe when everyone, including me, was willing to let me walk in blindly. "A lot of people have loved me, but you're the only person that's loved me enough to try to stop me."

"Don't be an idiot. Of course—"

"No. Not since the sword. Not since I became She-Ra." I let my fingers slip from the golden emblem and instead hold onto you. "No one ever asked why it had to be me. They just all… let me take it. *She's Adora—she's She-Ra. She can handle it.* I don't think they meant anything bad, but… why? Why did you say that? Why do you keep fighting for… for me?"

"Because… Because…" Your voice cracks from the strain of the words you're about to say.

"Catra…"

"Because some nights I never wanted to wake up. And I felt your hand on mine. Because I always wore the ratty clothes, but you never made fun of me. Because when I wanted to hide, you were there. No one else seems to get it. That you're *there* . And I —" You hiccup and wince. "I realized something when I was trapped on the Velvet Glove and all I had was Glimmer. I belonged there because of what I'd done. She didn't. You were coming for her, and I knew the last thing I had to do was to try to keep you from making another dumb sacrifice for someone else. I thought that you'd know better. That Glimmer would have enough brain cells not to come back to that nightmare. Maybe someone could finally talk you out of being a *complete dumbass*. I had ruined so much. And I… I wanted to do that one good thing. I thought it'd be my last."

A pressure builds inside of my head. Another twinge of She-Ra's fear as I remember those sleepless nights on Darla. Glimmer's long stare as she recalled the horrors of her time there. The people callously conquered, turned into subjects or digested to feed his near infinite army of clones. And you were stuck in the middle of it. "But I couldn't just leave you there."

"I know." You tighten your hand into a fist and bump it into my chest. "I *know*. And I knew that no one could ever talk you out of it again. Because you're Adora. You just gotta save everyone and I… I hate it some days."

"I'm sorry. I—"

"No, Adora. Don't apologize. That's just how you are and you can't help it." You brush your cheek against my collarbone and I feel the stain of a tear left behind through my thermal shirt. "Trust me I know." You pause a moment to look up at me and smile before you continue.

"I hated that you left. I understand why now, but you do too much for everyone else. I love you, but you don't have to break yourself for the people that you love over and over again." Every ounce of pain you've carried over the past few days weighs on your face, but you smile through all of it with the strength of the words that you're saying. "I love you because if I'm ever afraid, if it ever seems like too much, I can fall into your arms, and the world seems okay again. And that is *all* that I need from you, Adora. Everything else is just gray rations."

I can't suppress the laugh within me. It fills me with weightlessness and relief. I hadn't quite realized the full pressure that had been weighing on me until unburdened from it. "Too bad it's not the brown kind. Sounds like you're getting the bad end of that deal."

You snort and thump me again on the chest. "You know I'm never letting you live that down, right?"

"I don't even know *what* you're talking about." I caress your forearm. "Besides, I was perfectly capable of handling myself in that condition."

"I don't want to hear it. It was a lot of work keeping you from smacking your head on something. Someone's gotta be around to save you from yourself."

"And that's you?"

"It's always been me, dummy." You unfurl your fingers and you grasp at the fabric of my shirt. "I'll carry you when you break your ankle, or when corrupted She-Ra leaves you all floppy and annoying. I'll—"

"Jump into fire for me?"

You pinch your eyes shut and thud your forehead against my chest. "Don't ruin it."

"I won't promise not to jump out of the airlock again. That was too much fun."

You pull back so you can glare at me but the expression has no teeth. "You're such an idiot."

I smile warmly at you. "I know."

The glare turns into a rueful smile. An earnest one that has become so common recently. The fights and the confusion burn away in the growing truth between us. I really do love you.

You see my thoughts in my expression. You know what I am thinking. A stillness in the air. An anticipation of what will happen next. You adjust yourself and lean in closer—

A loud beeping behind us startles both of us out of our skin. You leap from my lap, elbow knocking me in the cheek on the way up. You land a few feet back, tail puffed and ears flattened. I'm a little slower on the uptake, but manage to jump to my tingling

legs, fists up and ready to go. The dark hall is still empty however. I turn and the central computer projects a hologram of a bright crimson light pulsing bright and dimming. I feel a pressure in my head again. It's trying to reach She-Ra.

It won't.

"Maybe I can shut this thing down." I look back to you. "But I think I have to…"

Realizing the absence of danger, you hastily regain some of your dignity. Your tail relaxes, falling limply behind you. You hold onto your side as the pain catches up with you. You grimace, but gesture acquiescence with an open hand. "Glow it up."

I smile. With an open hand the Sword of Protection materializes in my grip. A whisper, Bow was still trying to sleep after all. "For the honor of Grayskull."

Across the cosmos—time, space, and all of the things I'll never understand—the universe speaks to me. It always starts as a whisper in my hand, tingling through my skin and into my bones. The tributaries of her energy rush faster and faster through my body until it's an unstoppable avalanche of light and incomprehensible power. Curtains of nacreous droplets rush and shimmer all around refracting her power back towards me. Shocks of the cascading light erupt in the aureate cuffs and boots, anchoring her inside of me and joining our beings.

The strangest sensation always comes next, the new one since we rescued you. Every measure of my being disconnects itself from one another, as though I am torn apart into my most indivisible self. She steps inside. Joins with me. She binds everything back together and the dislocations merge together in a person that's beyond any comprehension. I am one with her, and she's one with me. The coalescence fuses together and our bodies ignite in prismatic light. The regalia of She-Ra manifests itself on my body merging our spirits together in an echoing shock on my skin. The episode calms and the last remnants of light shimmer

through my wafting ponytail. We stand together. As She-Ra, but also as Adora.

I twirl and hold the Sword of Protection into the air. Just because I know it looks good. When the transformation completes, a pulse of resting fury reminds me of how tenuous this form is at the moment. But I still stand strong.

I lean forward, stooping over the table that the red pulsing light hovers above, and place my hand on it.

A tinny voice responds. "Authorization requested." A familiar tone lurks in the tinny mechanical voice. Could it be…?

I shake my head. That's a question for another time. "She-Ra."

"Bio-magical signature, recognized. What is your command?"

That was easy. "Disable She-Ra control protocol and stand down security measures."

"Control protocol, deactivated. Security barriers, deactivated. Self destruct sequence, halted."

"The *what* now?" Panic slips into your voice.

"No clue." I shrug at you. The sword dissipates from my hand and I take a deep breath. "But hey—it's halted."

You grab my wrist, stopping my transformation. "Don't… don't let go of it yet."

I look back at you with wide-eyed surprise. "Why?"

"I'm…" You release my hand to grasp your bicep. "You're always She-Ra when you're being a hero. And I forget who you are sometimes."

"Are you sure?" My thoughts are clearer. Is it because of the protocol being deactivated or is it—No. A door has opened

between us and the pain that we have been carrying alone. She-Ra's spirit is calm. A lopsided smile grows across my face.

You smile back, fangs protruding past your lips. "I think it's about time to start thinking of you as Adora no matter what. You know, so I can maybe stop you from doing stupid things whatever shape you're in."

An unexpected truth bubbles up from your words. It was so easy not to listen and charge ahead when I am in this shape and have this power inside of me. When I first found She-Ra, it had been easier to be her instead of me. But it wasn't as simple as that. I was never one or the other. She-Ra has always been part of me just as you have always been part of me. A warmth washes over me. A relief at the reconciling of the two.

I look down at you, barely up to my chest height. "It's going to make hugging each other a little awkward."

You crouch and pounce upward. Arms rest on my shoulders and legs lock tight around my waist. You use your claws to comb through my long hair draped behind me, pausing its elegant flowing in the ethereal wind. I reach down and brace my forearm under you, holding you with ease. Your tail wraps around my arm. My other hand rests on your back.

"We can make it work." Your face is precariously close to mine.

We stare at each other. I see discomfort slip away, and love exudes from your expression. Calm.

Your hands… they… they caress on either side of my face. All of my strength is nothing compared to your delicate touch. "You were talking about that day… the time when you fell down the pipe. Do you remember it happening differently?" You look on at me with delicate vulnerability.

"Which part?" I stretch my memory back into the past few days like I am trying to reassemble a shattered pane of glass.

"Just that… when we got back to the bunk. I remember… I think I remember something. I remember you being an idiot and smashing me in the face with your giant forehead."

A hot flush on my cheeks almost made me look away from you. "Yeah."

"But then… I thought I left. But I didn't. Like things are different. Does that make sense?"

A grin creeps up across my lips. An elation buoys inside of me. Being in a time loop had some perks. "Was it better the second time?"

You roll your lips over your fangs and nod, then lean in.

When our lips meet it is the culmination of an inevitability. You smell faintly of fire smoke—a mark of how much we've changed—but beneath that it's still you. And that's all I really ever needed. Your touch is the most familiar thing in the universe to me. The softness of your fur, the teasing ploy of your claws against my skin, the low vibrating purr in your chest. They are what I've known since I could remember and it feels like home to kiss you now. The excitement of races to the forge, the serenity of the gardens of Bright Moon, the stillness and quiet of Darla deep in space. The best parts of each are condensed and epitomized in your kiss.

I used to wonder about my destiny, fought against what destinies they wanted to thrust upon me. Despite everything Shadow Weaver tried to do to us, everything the universe threw at us, even despite ourselves, we ended here, together. Now I think my destiny was simply to love and be loved by you. And that's enough.

We break from the kiss and you beam at me. Happiness. "That was different."

"Howso?"

"Tingly." You twist on the seat of my arm. "Huh, my ribs are feeling better. She-Ra kisses got some healing magic, too?"

"I don't… I wouldn't…" I feel a flush in my cheeks.

"I could get used to it. And this view from up here." You lean in and peck a kiss on my cheek.

A new voice interrupts us. "Hey, I was wondering if something like 'Starlight' might be a good pick for Glim—" Bow enters from the hallway. He stops mid-step as he clears the sleep from his eyes. He flushes bright red. "Oh, oh I'm so sorry!"

"It's all right, Bow." I smirk at him.

"No, it's not!" His voice cracks. "I'll just go back to bed. You two can get back to… what you're doing."

"Bow, stop." You squirm and grasp tight on my shoulders. My tiara is knocked askew and over my eyes as you clamber up my body. You stand on top of my shoulders and leap towards him.

I grumble in annoyance as I fix my headpiece back in place. You envelope Bow in a tight hug. He stares at me in wide-eyed astonishment.

You squeeze him tight. "Thank you."

"Oh, I didn't…"

"No, she's right Bow." I smile at him. "Thank you. You saved us."

"Oh…" He flushes again. "It was nothing."

"No." His chest muffles your voice. "It was *everything.* "

He returns the hug finally with the earnestness only he can manage. "Well I'm glad I was here then. I couldn't leave you guys

behind. I'm just happy Glimmer was feeling well enough to teleport me in." He looks at me, no, behind me. "What's that?"

I turn again and behind me on the hologram projector is a disembodied head. A man with long locks of hair down to his chin and sharp masculine face hovers in the air. As though he was waiting for me to acknowledge him, he speaks.

"Greetings She-Ra, Princess of Power. I am Adam."

"I… uh…" I square my shoulder and match his self-important tone. "Greetings Adam. I am Adora."

The head glitches and shimmers, rotating in a steady circle so now we saw the back of his bob.

You sigh next to me. "Great, another old hologram. Wonder what sort of bullshit this one will say."

"Catra, shh." I elbow you. "You might mess up the—"

"Greetings She-Ra, Princess of Power." The head rotated back around, treating us to the square jawline again. "I am Adam."

"For fuck's sake."

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The bustle of waking cadets woke me from a tenuous slumber. Muffled conversation intermingled with the rustling of bedding and clothes. I flexed my fingers and… you're still there.

I opened my eyes with a snap to check what I was feeling was real. I squeeze my hand over the delicate fur of your arm. You'd never stayed with me until morning.

You peeked a blue turquoise eye open at me. And you smiled. You smiled in a way I hadn't seen in so long. The left tooth poked out of the crevasse of your lip.

"Hey, Adora."

"Catra…"

I wanted to grab you there, pull you close, and kiss you again despite everyone in the barracks milling about us. My thoughts raced. You were here with me. People weren't looking or commenting. They left us alone here. All through the morning.

You craned your head upward to peek out from under the bottom bunk. Our bottom bunk. "You think we should get up?"

"Maybe wait for everyone to clear out." I flexed my foot against the makeshift rest made from your pillow. Something else was down there. I felt it only dimly. Maybe a spare pair of combat pants I'd left behind?

You reached a hand up, out from under the blankets. You took an errant strand of my hair and tucked it back away from the side of my face.

In front of everyone.

This wasn't what I remembered.

"You okay?" you said.

I was speechless. My hand tightened around your bicep and I drew you in closer to me. I didn't care who saw.

"Why wouldn't I—"

The memory of the needles of fire and electricity piercing my skin interrupted the intimacy of our bunk. The agony of her hatred finally shared between us.

I nodded slowly. The muscles in my neck ached from the strain of the convulsions. You'd lived with this every time she tortured you. I couldn't—wouldn't let her keep doing it to you. I could be strong.

"You sure?" You wore concern so strangely. You were a different person here in this bunk. A seed of who you will become.

I broke into a smile. "Right now? Yeah."

You grinned back contentedly. "I think I—"

"Hey guys!" Kyle's voice cut through our tentative privacy.

You sighed. "What Kyle?"

"It's breakfast time! You gonna get up?"

I looked from him, back to you. Maybe we could get him to leave us alone for another few minutes. You had the same consideration on your face, but we couldn't keep this ruse up forever. At least not until tonight. I looked back towards him. "Yeah, I guess."

"Great! Hey, what's that?" He reached down and snatched something under the blankets.

A brief terror sheared through me. What was he grabbing from under my—our—blanket? Was he about to rip the tape off my foot? But no, instead he held up a red jacket. The one we'd taken from the lockers the other night. He grasped it by the shoulders. "Hey, this is pretty cool! I haven't seen this issued!"

You darted up and grabbed the jacket from his hands and snarled. "Hands off you little shit."

Kyle startled backwards. He held up his hands innocently. "Sorry! I was just…" He caught your feral look and realized whatever questions he had wouldn't be worth the inevitable gashes on his face. "I'll just… see you guys at breakfast!"

He scampered off leaving us in silence. The rest of the cadets had filtered out during our conversation.

You held the jacket with both hands on the shoulders between us. "I guess I should take this ugly thing back before anyone notices it's missing."

"No wait!" I grabbed it away from you and sat up. With a quick flip over my shoulders, I threaded my arms through it and straightened the collar. "I like it. It's pretty spiffy."

You grimaced in disdain. "Adora, don't ever use the word spiffy again."

I straightened the jacket again, once more for good measure. "No promises. But you gotta admit…"

"What?" You grinned, that left fang jutting out past your lip.

"It's a nice little reminder of how much fun we had the other night."

You smacked me on the arm. "Whatever, dork. Let's get to the mess hall before Shadow Weaver catches us slacking off."

I watched you get up. The moment lost, but not ruined. I spared one last kindness to myself. The dreams were ending, and I couldn’t change things anymore. It wouldn’t have done any good. I knew I couldn’t stop it from happening. I’d leave, eventually. But I know I made those nights better for us until I was gone.

Chapter End Notes

Hey All, Thanks again to BA TU for their artwork and making this story that extra little bit special.

We're working on Bow's fic now and expect it to be ready in a week or two depending. Thank you again to all of our lovely readers.

See you in the next novella.

End Notes

This fic is dedicated to Noelle Stevenson and all of their beautiful creations. Because of them we've found pieces of ourselves that we'll treasure forever. These fics are our little way of giving back to them and keeping the love going.
See you in the next novella.
-4theHonourofGräysküll & DakianDelomast

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!